

ANGLIA RUSKIN UNIVERSITY

FACULTY OF ARTS, HUMANITIES, EDUCATION AND SOCIAL SCIENCES

UNDERSTANDING THE SPIRITUALITY OF CHRISTIAN CHINESE-
SINGAPOREAN OLDER ADULTS WHO ARE POSITIVELY ENGAGED WITH LIFE

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A thesis in partial fulfilment of the requirements of Anglia Ruskin University for the
degree of Professional Doctorate in Practical Theology

Submitted: Dec 2025

Acknowledgments

Firstly, I would like to thank all the research participants who graciously agreed to share their time and experiences to make this project possible. I would also like to express my deepest gratitude to my supervisors, Revd Dr Jane Leach and Dr Christine Lai, for their patience and guidance throughout this research project. As my first supervisor, Jane had to put up with my countless drafts and multiple schedule changes, helping me with the many administration tasks that arose because of the schedule changes due to my various health and caregiving issues. For the same reason, I also want to thank Revd Dr Andrew Todd's patience and help to make those changes. Finally, I want to thank my husband, Eric for his love, encouragement and assistance in helping me complete this course.

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ABSTRACT

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PROFESSIONAL DOCTORATE

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The purpose of this research was to understand the spirituality of Christian Chinese-Singaporean older adults and how it helped them to be positively engaged with life.

Interpretative phenomenological analysis methodology was adopted where one-to-one interviews were conducted with a sample of six participants who were above 65 years old.

The findings indicated that they used the contents of their faith to create a Christian worldview which they used to live their daily lives. Their five key beliefs were: that God cares about them; that He is in charge or in control of everything; and He has a plan which they are a part of. They also believed in heaven and the Bible. The research participants demonstrated skills including the ability to find themselves in the Christian master story; to own/disown local concepts and practices; to reframe their lived lives within the master story; and to reframe the master story. The participants also engaged in spiritual practices that helped them stay at peace through the vicissitudes of life. These were: attending church and small group, praying, “quiet time” with God and studying the Bible.

The findings were coded and then analysed using literature from gerontology, faith development and theology. The conclusion was that all the participants had the “owned faith” style of Westerhoff’s theory. They did not fit well into Fowler’s theory, showing characteristics of non-consecutive stages though most showed characteristics of Fowler’s third stage, i.e. Synthetic-Conventional Faith. Using the skills identified above, a model of faith development from the Singaporean context is presented for testing and use in this and other contexts.

Key words: Spirituality, positively engaged with life, Interpretative phenomenological analysis, reframing, Westerhoff, Fowler.

VERSION_DEC 2025

Contents

I.	Chapter One - Introduction	9
I.1	My work with older adults (OAs)	10
I.2	Challenges of aging in general and specifically in Singapore	11
I.3	Fears and loss of purpose of life among local OAs.....	15
I.4	Conviction to embark on this research.....	17
I.5	Towards a researchable question.....	18
II.	Chapter Two - The research question	19
II.1	The research need.....	19
II.1.1	Limited research on spirituality of local OAs	19
II.1.2	Understanding local OAs to serve them better.....	22
II.2	The research question.....	22
II.3	Reasons for locating this research within the field of practical theology	24
II.4	Conclusion.....	27
III.	Chapter Three - Conceptual Framework.....	28
III.1	Old age.....	28
III.1.1	How is old age defined?	28
III.1.2	What does old age look like?.....	29
III.1.3	How does the Singaporean society view old age?.....	33
III.2	Spirituality	38
III.2.1	What is Christian Spirituality?	40
III.2.2	What “spirituality” to look for in the research participants.....	42
III.3	Positive engagement with life.....	50
III.3.1	A psychological/gerontological perspective.....	51
III.3.2	What are the characteristics of Maslow’s self-actualisers (SAs)?.....	53
III.3.3	What are the qualities of Erikson’s successful “basic virtue” acquirer?	54
III.3.4	What are the attributes of Tornstam’s gerotranscenders?	57
III.3.5	What is common amongst the SA, basic-virtue acquirer and gerotranscender?.....	59

VERSION_DEC 2025

III.3.6	What is positively engaged with life from a theological perspective?	61
III.3.7	What are the attributes of Christians who are living life to the full?.....	65
III.4	The criteria for selection of research participants	68
III.5	Conclusion	71
IV.	Chapter four - Research Methodology.....	72
IV.1	Selecting an appropriate research methodology	72
IV.1.1	Impact of my worldview on the selection process	72
IV.1.2	Reasons for a qualitative methodological approach for this project.....	73
IV.2	The research method.....	77
IV.3	Language considerations	80
IV.4	Ethical considerations.....	81
IV.5	Conclusion	83
V.	Chapter five – Recruitment and Data Gathering Process	84
V.1	Identification and recruitment of research participants.....	84
V.2	The interview process.....	85
V.2.1	Interview with participant A.....	85
V.2.2	Interview with participant B.....	86
V.2.3	Interview with participant C.....	86
V.2.4	Interview with participant D.....	87
V.2.5	Interview with participant E	88
V.2.6	Interview with participant F	89
V.3	Transcribing the interviews.....	90
V.3.1	The transcription process.....	90
V.3.2	Confirmation of the transcripts.....	90
V.3.3	Translation of the Chinese transcript.....	91
V.4	Coding the transcripts.....	91
V.4.1	The coding methodology chosen.....	91
V.4.2	The coding process.....	92
V.5	Recording the impact of the Covid-19 pandemic.....	96
V.6	Conclusion.....	96
VI.	Chapter six – Findings	98

VI.1	Details about coding the transcripts.....	98
VI.2	Background information on the research participants.....	99
VI.2.1	Participant A.....	100
VI.2.2	Participant B.....	101
VI.2.3	Participant C.....	103
VI.2.4	Participant D.....	104
VI.2.5	Participant E.....	105
VI.2.6	Participant F.....	106
VI.3	Process of coding and grouping the codes into categories.....	107
VI.4	Categories identified.....	109
VI.4.1	Disposition.....	110
VI.4.2	Influences.....	113
VI.4.3	Outcome_impact on daily living.....	119
VI.4.4	Outcome_spiritual practices.....	122
VI.4.5	Own theological beliefs.....	125
VI.4.6	Spiritual experiences.....	131
VI.4.7	Impact of Covid-19.....	133
VI.4.8	Advice to grow as a Christian.....	135
VI.5	Identifying Patterns/Themes.....	136
VI.5.1	Pattern of holding on.....	136
VI.5.2	Pattern of healing.....	139
VI.5.3	Pattern of indigenising.....	142
VI.5.4	Pattern of discerning.....	145
VI.5.5	Pattern of retelling.....	150
VI.5.6	Patterns are themes.....	156
VI.6	Conclusion.....	157
VII.	Chapter seven - Discussion of Findings.....	158
VII.1	Analysing the findings to answer my research question.....	158
VII.1.1	Key beliefs and the pattern of “holding on”.....	160
VII.1.2	Patterns of indigenising and discerning.....	169
VII.1.3	Patterns of retelling and healing.....	184

VII.2	The importance of the state of being “at peace”	190
VII.2.1	The state of being “at peace”	190
VII.2.2	As a discerning tool	191
VII.3	The skills demonstrated by research participants	192
VII.4	Conclusion	194
VIII.	Chapter eight – Contributions to knowledge and practice	196
VIII.1	Contribution to knowledge	196
VIII.1.1	A local model of faith development	196
VIII.1.2	Master stories and theological beliefs of the research participants	198
VIII.1.3	Owning and disowning local concepts and practices	199
VIII.1.4	Spiritual practices of the research participants	200
VIII.2	Contribution to practice	201
VIII.2.1	Targeted Christian education for Christian OAs	201
VIII.2.2	Greater emphasis on increasing spiritual experiences	203
VIII.2.3	Publicising Biblical understanding of local practices	204
VIII.3	Learning journey for me	204
VIII.4	Limitations and Future Research	205
VIII.5	Conclusion	206
Annex A		207
Annex B		211
Bibliography		215

List of figures:

Figure 1: Pattern of holding on (participant A)	137
Figure 2: Pattern of holding on (participant B).....	139
Figure 3: Pattern of healing (participants A and D).....	142
Figure 4: Pattern of indigenising (participants A and D).....	144
Figure 5: Pattern of discerning.....	149
Figure 6: Pattern of retelling	155
Figure 7: Skills demonstrated by research participants	197

List of Tables:

Table 1: Psychosocial stages of life (Erikson, Erikson and Kivnick, 1986, pp.34–38).	56
Table 2: Summary of similar attributes described in the theories of Tornstam, Maslow and Erikson	60
Table 3: Attributes of Christian having life to the full vs those identified by Tornstam, Maslow & Erikson	68
Table 4: English and Chinese words describing gratitude and benevolence	71
Table 5: Sample page of the NVivo codebook generated by NVivo 12	94
Table 6: Row 13 from working table on transcript of A’s interview	109
Table 7: Categories	110
Table 8: Disposition and its codes	112
Table 9: Influences and their codes.....	114
Table 10: Row 5 from working table on participant A’s interview transcript	118
Table 11: Outcome_impact on daily living and its codes	121
Table 12: Outcome_spiritual practices and their codes	122
Table 13 Own theological beliefs and their codes	131
Table 14: Spiritual experiences and their codes.....	131
Table 15: Impact of Covid-19 and its codes	134
Table 16: Advice to grow as a Christian and its codes	135
Table 17: Table of identified patterns	156
Table 18: Contents of faith of the research participants	161
Table 19: Skills demonstrated by the research participants.....	193

I. Chapter One - Introduction

The practice context in which this thesis arose and to which it seeks to contribute is the work of my local Methodist church in Singapore amongst older adults (OAs). I became involved with this work following early retirement from my first career and obtaining qualifications in gerontology and counselling. In this chapter, I give an account of the events that led to this research project and the call that I felt to embark on this research project. I conclude by explaining the shape of the thesis, outlining the task of each chapter, moving from a research topic to a researchable question, to research design, findings and conclusions.

After working twenty-five years in auditing and risk management roles, I had a breakdown in health. At that point, I oversaw both the operational and credit risks of my company which was a global investor. It was a “24 by 7” job as the financial markets are open round the clock and our staff travelled through different time zones. It was not unusual to receive alerts of credit or operational risks in the middle of the night and having to take actions immediately to manage them. With failing physical health, it became a vicious cycle of feeling inadequate hence pushing myself to work harder and then falling sick more frequently. The job satisfaction that I had previously was totally lost, my health nosedived and I lost my mobility. I resigned but was offered leave instead to work on recovering my health. After several months and various medical interventions, I recovered my mobility and returned to work on a part-time basis. However, the feeling of not being fully competent returned so I worked out a schedule with my company to retire early on medical grounds.

Upon retirement, I found that not only had I lost my role as a professional in a reputable company, I was also no longer a key bread earner for both my family of origin and my nuclear family. My role as a parent had greatly diminished over the years as my children grew up and moved out, and my spousal role had also changed as I joined my spouse in retirement and we had more time together than we ever had previously. Without an official job title and less income, my social status also changed significantly. These changes required lifestyle changes that I had anticipated and was prepared to accept, but I did not anticipate the impact on my life purpose and sense of worth. I realized that I was not as prepared for old age as I had thought. For a start, I had not figured out where I fitted in God's plan going forward.

I took up two master courses, one in gerontology and another one in counselling and put what I learnt into practice by volunteering in various organisations serving OAs. I had wanted to care, connect and contribute to the new community that I found myself in. Coincidentally, these were the three thrusts – care, contribution and connectedness –announced by the Singapore government in 2023 “to help Singaporeans live life to the fullest” (Teo, 2023a). Although the process was enriching, it was hectic and full of activities. It also put me in touch with many OAs, some of whom were searching for a reason to be positive about living.

I.1 My work with older adults (OAs)

From 2016 to 2020, I volunteered at three eldercare centers working as a general aide, an exercise instructor and a counsellor. These centers were situated in public housing estates and provided day-care for OAs living in the community, the oldest being 99 years old. Every OA was given a health assessment before they joined the centers and were regularly assessed thereafter.

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Counsellors were assigned to those OAs that needed them but only with their caregivers' and their consent. Based on their registration forms, all the OAs that I worked with were either Buddhists, Taoists or Christians. These are the main religions in Singapore making up more than 60% of the population, i.e. Buddhists/Taoists making up 43.2% and Christians 18.8% (Department of Statistics Singapore, 2016, p.23). In addition, I am a lay counsellor in my church since 2017, but my clients from this channel are mainly Christians from other churches and may not be OAs.

Given the organisations that I volunteered with, I worked mainly with OAs. I remember the first OA who spoke to me about her anxieties was a female in her 60s. She was physically healthy but was anxious about falling ill as she aged. She was living with her children and was worried that she would be sent to a nursing home or home for the aged when she could no longer look after herself. This future possibility made her so worried that she was showing signs of clinical depression. After working with more OAs, I realized that having a negative outlook about life is common among the local OAs.

I.2 Challenges of aging in general and specifically in Singapore

According to the World Bank by 2050, one third of the world's population will be over 60 years old and eight out of ten will live in low and middle-income countries. The latter are also aging faster than the high-income countries such as Japan, Korea and Europe. For instance, France took about 115 years for the percentage of her population over 60 to double from seven to 14 percent whereas in Vietnam, the change occurred in 15 years. Although these newly aged countries have the benefit of learning from their frontrunners, they often lack the resources and infrastructure for social security, healthcare and eldercare that wealthier countries have developed

over the years. At the individual level, the challenges facing the OAs are no less, including health issues, difficulties in performing activities of daily living, social isolation, financial insecurity, discrimination and loss of purpose (Wachs, Demarco and Stewart, 2024).

The support that the OAs receive depends on political, economic and social situations of their countries as well as the cultural perception of old age. Countries in political, economic or social turmoil often leave their old and weak to fend for themselves. In the lower and middle-income countries, economic strains from lower labor force participation and increased demand for healthcare and retirement costs, inadequate protection from weak social safety nets, healthcare system deficiencies and limited resources in rural areas often leave families to bear the financial and caregiving burden. Families with lower socio-economic status face immense challenges in supporting their aging family members with major issues including financial strain, inadequate healthcare access, social isolation, and heightened vulnerability to environmental stressors. These factors are exacerbated by rapid urbanization, climate change, and the increasing burden of chronic diseases. Aging in such a context is expected to be difficult but it could be mitigated where the OAs are respected, valued and integrated into their family and community life within their cultures. Cultures that place great value on beauty, vitality, economic and military prowess, innovation and trendsetting tend to favour the young over the old. Such favouring is a form of ageism, i.e. stereotyping, prejudice or discrimination based on age. When resources are scarce, favouring one age group often results in deprivation of another. Dr Kanwaljit Soin, the first female nominated member of parliament and the founding chair of the Singapore chapter of the United Nations Development Fund for Women, noted that “on a culture scale, two factors tend to make a society

more ageist - scarce resources and a growing percentage of older people in the population” (Soin, 2023). Singapore is one of those countries that meets both these conditions.

Old age can be challenging in a country like Singapore. Firstly, like all OAs, the Singaporean OA needs to manage the normal aging of the body, which would result in reduced efficiency or lower functioning of organs and increased susceptibility to illnesses. In addition, there are also unique societal-economic factors that Singaporean OAs must manage.

In Singapore, many OAs are first- or second-generation migrants and are our nation-building pioneers since the country only became independent in 1965. Most are not highly educated. In 2010, only 17.2% of those above 55 had post-secondary education (Department of Statistics Singapore, 2016, p.11). Most of them worked hard to provide for their families and did not plan for their retirement. Even as recent as 2023, 6 out of 10 Singaporeans expect to work after official retirement (The Straits Times, 2023). To make matters worse, Singapore’s cost of living has risen significantly since the 1970s. In 2023, the Economic Intelligence Unit (EIU), the research and analysis division of the Economist Group, ranked Singapore as the most expensive city in the world for the ninth time in eleven years (Garcia, 2023). The Economist Group, which publishes The Economist, specializes in international business and world affairs information. Singapore is a city-state, a small island of only 735 square metres with a population of more than 6 million (Lim, 2024). To have enough good living and working space for her population, only approximately 1% of her land is used for farming (Singapore Food Agency, 2024). She imports almost everything that she needs including food and water, which explains why living in Singapore is more expensive compared to her South-East Asian neighbours.

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In addition, Singapore is not a welfare state (Chin, 2023). Only a few key political and public service positions provide pensions and medical care after retirement. To avoid creating a huge financial burden on the state, the Singapore government has adopted the “Many Helping Hands” approach since 1995 in her management of social welfare. Her ideology of social services is one of shared responsibilities between the individual, families, community, with the state acting as the last resort (Tang, 2022). OAs without sufficient savings for retirement need to rely on the support of family/friends, voluntary welfare organisations (VWOs) and finally, the government if they cannot support themselves (Basu, 2014). Even with a central agency, the Agency for Integrated Care, to coordinate the various organisations involved, it can be very confusing for the OA who needs help outside the family. Hence, the very first set of “helping hands” , i.e. family/friends, are often strained to breaking point because they are the primary caregivers, especially the family.

The other reason for this over-loading of family members is the need to “save face”. Generally, the older Singaporeans pride themselves in being able to look after themselves as they were the generations that built the nation. To ask for external help in old age is not something that they are proud of. Having poured most of their resources into nurturing their children, they expect their children to voluntarily support them in their old age but the rapid development of Singapore in the last few decades created significant generational differences across cohorts of Singaporeans. Expectation gaps as well as communication barriers between the OAs and their better educated and generally more cosmopolitan children often result in ineffective communication and misunderstandings, creating cracks in their relationships with their children and eroding their main

pillar of support in old age. By the time their children are independent and the cracks are apparent, it is usually too late for most OAs to build up an adequate nest egg to maintain their desired standard of living for the remaining days of their lives. Being fearful of not having enough provisions and care in old age is a common phenomenon among the OAs that I met.

I.3 Fears and loss of purpose of life among local OAs

I work with OAs who are community-dwelling, this means that they are healthy enough to live independently, or with some domestic help. However, many believed that their situation would get worst with age, and they will become “more useless” as their physical and mental health continue to decline. They also feared that they are already or might be perceived as “financial burdens” to their loved ones as medical care and nursing home care are costly in Singapore. Some of these OAs suffered from anxiety attacks while others have major depressive disorders. It is common to hear them say that life is meaningless, and they are waiting for death. These observations are consistent with results of research done in western countries which showed that meaninglessness, if left unresolved, can lead to symptoms of anxiety, depression, hopelessness or physical decline (Reker, J Peacock and Wong, 1987). Such physical and psychological decline not only impacts the OAs but also their loved ones, especially those who become or eventually become their caregivers. While working with these OAs, some of the questions that came to my mind were: did they have a meaning in life previously? If they did, what was it and how did they lose it? If they never had a meaning in life, what had sustained them all these years? How can they find meaning in life now?

As mentioned earlier, most of the OAs that I worked with had a religion. I had expected their religion to provide some support during this stage of their lives as past research has shown that spirituality/religion is “a source of meaning and purpose in life” (Moberg, 2005, p.11). David Moberg, an American sociologist and pastor, summarised the results of research on spirituality, aging and health done up to 2005 in his paper published in the Journal of Gerontological Social Work, and wrote that “religion and spirituality are among the most significant means for coping with crises and problems of living and dying” (Moberg, 2005, p.17). Similarly, Dr. Harold Koenig, who is the Director of the Center for Spirituality, Theology and Health at Duke University Medical Center, reviewed 724 quantitative studies on religion, spirituality and mental health. He found that that a majority of these studies reported statistically positive associations between religious involvement and mental health (Koenig, 2009, p.285). In the Singapore context, there was a research project funded by the Singapore Ministry of Health and Temasek Foundation (the charitable arm of one of Singapore’s sovereign wealth fund) to investigate the association of religious affiliation with positive mental health and mental disorders (Vaingankar et al., 2021). The data was collected from August 2016 to April 2018 as part of the larger Singapore Mental Health Study 2016 which aimed to find out the state of mental health in Singapore’s adult population. The result of this project, which involved cross-sectional survey of 2,270 adults in Singapore, was consistent with the research results from Western countries that I referred to earlier. It showed that having a religious affiliation is associated with higher scores for several components of positive mental health, including general coping and emotional support. These research results showed that religious affiliation was helpful for majority of those who participated in those studies, but my interaction with local OAs has suggested that such a positive effect of religion is not

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apparent in a significant number who claimed to have a religion. Aging is a complex process which cannot be the same for every OA, having to take into account factors including changing physical health, social roles and finances plus perception of increasing proximity to end of life. Religious affiliation could provide a coping mechanism, social support or give identity/meaning to some OAs, but can also be used by other OAs to justify a fatalistic approach to life such that they give up even to upkeep themselves or despair because they feel that nothing they do matters. In a highly religious society like Singapore where 80% of her population reported having a religion (Department of Statistics Singapore, 2021), I believe that there is value in understanding how religious affiliations work positively for local OAs so that programmes can be designed to improve their aging process.

I.4 Conviction to embark on this research

Having volunteered since 2016, there were several occasions where my emotional wellbeing was negatively impacted after listening to the problems of the OAs and reflecting on them. During these episodes, I felt “triggered”, feeling suddenly anxious about my old age, and at times, this progressed towards feeling sad and isolated. Such negative mood could last for days and were usually resolved by activities that reinforced my trust in God such as searching the Scriptures or attending worship services. Through these episodes of toggling between being negative or positive about life, my faith helped me swing back to being positive, for example, when I was reminded that God will provide for my needs. I also felt a calling to embark on a study of the kind of spirituality that would help our local OAs in their old age. Having seen the mental

anguish that some of the OAs went through, there was a voice urging me to do research in this area for them as well as myself.

I.5 Towards a researchable question

I believe that my spirituality helped me to be positive about life. However, to be useful for the local OAs that I work with, I need to study them to understand the type of spirituality that would help them. The first task of this research was to identify through a literature search whether there was any material relevant to my research aim and the gaps in knowledge, if any. I outline the results of this literature search in the next chapter and explain how I arrived at my research question. In chapter three, I explain the key concepts that I used in this project and the research methodology used is explained in chapter four. The challenges that I met while recruiting the research participants and what happened during the data gathering is described in chapter five and the findings presented in chapter six. Finally, a discussion of the findings and my contributions to knowledge and practice are covered in the last two chapters.

II. Chapter Two - The research question

Having explained what triggered my research, this chapter identifies the research gap that I seek to fill, how the research question was formulated and why I located this project within the field of practical theology.

II.1 The research need

II.1.1 Limited research on spirituality of local OAs

Singapore is a rapidly aging society, according to government projections, around one in four of Singapore residents will be 65 years or older by 2030 (National Population and Talent Division, Strategy Group, Prime Minister's Office, 2016). That being the case, the government has identified this as an issue of national concern and has set up various national committees to develop strategies to cope with the likely consequences of a rapidly ageing population. For example, in 2016, the Singapore Ministry of Health announced her action plan for successful ageing, focusing on the social, physical and healthcare needs of the ageing population including funding for research in these areas, but there was no mention of spiritual needs of the OAs. The refreshed 2023 action plan for successful aging also did not mention spiritual needs (Teo, 2023a). However, as mentioned in chapter one, our ministry of health had funded a research project to investigate the association of religious affiliation with positive mental health (PMH) and mental disorders (Vaingankar et al., 2021). The result of this project showed that having a religious affiliation is associated with higher scores for several components of PMH including general coping and emotional support. The study was done through surveys which asked participants if they agreed with certain

statements about their religious affiliations. This methodology meant that it could not go in-depth to find out more about their spirituality.

There are many reasons for the limited research on the spirituality of local OAs but I believe one reason is that most research funding from the government are focused on the bio-psycho-social needs of OAs and spiritual needs are acknowledged but expected to be met by the religious organisations.

Singapore is a multi-faith society and the government strives to maintain racial harmony among the different faiths by keeping religion separate from state. From my work, I observed that spiritual interventions were not an integral part of most government-funded social care programmes for community-dwelling OAs in Singapore. Although religious organisations are encouraged to set up voluntary welfare organisations (VWOs) to provide social services to OAs, these VWOs need to adhere to strict regulations to ensure that religious harmony is maintained. One of the two principles of the Maintenance of Religious Harmony Act 1990 was that followers of different religions should exercise moderation and tolerance towards each other and their beliefs, and not instigate religious enmity or hatred (MHA, 2024). In practice, most eldercare programmes would not include spiritual interventions to avoid inadvertently breaching this law because it is difficult to interpret the scope of the MRHA. This lack of practical applications in government-endorsed programmes was also a likely contributing factor for the limited research into the spirituality of local OAs in 2017 when I initiated my research project.

A search using internet and the library systems of the National University of Singapore, Trinity Theological College (Singapore) and the University of Cambridge yielded only a few published research papers with discussion of the spirituality of local OAs. They included the work of well-known academics in Singapore's geriatric/gerontology field such as Prof Kua Ee Heok, Associate Prof Ng Tze Pin and Prof Kalyani Mehta. Both Prof Kua and AP Ng are medical doctors, with the former specializing in psychiatry and the latter is a physician epidemiologist. Their interests in OAs are mainly in the OAs' physical and psychological health such as dementia and depression (Kua and Ho, 2008; Ng et al., 2016).

On the other hand, Prof Mehta's training was in social work and her research interests were in gerontology, policy, long term eldercare including the spirituality of local OAs. She has published comparative studies of OAs across culture and faiths e.g. her cross-cultural comparison of the impact of religious beliefs and practices on aging (Mehta, 1997) and interreligious comparison of the effects of religion on aging (Jianbin and Mehta, 2003). The latter compares the effect of Buddhist and Christian beliefs on the integration process that helps the OA to connect various parts of his/her life into a meaningful whole. Mehta has defined integration as "a complex, multidimensional subjective process through which the very old individual connects various parts of his life into a meaningful whole" (Mehta, 1997, p.102). According to her study, religion can play an integrative role and "although there are fundamental, irreducible differences in terms of religious beliefs and practices between Buddhism and Christianity, there are far fewer difference in the way they impact on the integrative aging process" (Jianbin and Mehta, 2003, p.500). Her research work is

one of the few on the spirituality of the local OAs in the Singapore context, and her work points to more areas for further fruitful research.

II.1.2 Understanding local OAs to serve them better

Because of limited local research on OAs, the results of research done in other developed countries such as US and Australia were often used to develop local eldercare programs. For example, the Bio-Psychosocial-Spiritual (BPSS) framework that our medical social workers use to assess their clients was developed based on research done by psychologists from the Americas including George L. Engel, John S. Roland, Ami Rokach and Daniel Sulmasy (Chung et al., 2023). The work of the Australian researcher, Elizabeth MacKinlay, was used to develop programmes for clients with dementia in some of the eldercare centers ran by a local Catholic VWO (MacKinlay and Trevitt, 2015). There are many advantages in using research results from other countries, but one obvious limitation is that adaptations must be made to account for the cultural, social and political differences between Singapore and these countries. Singapore is unique in many ways as compared to other developed countries, notably, her largely Asian migrant population, rapid economic progress over a short span of 50 plus years and unique political environment. To ensure appropriate adaptation of overseas research results for local use, there is a need to understand our local OAs better.

II.2 The research question

Through my research, I hoped to understand and better support the OAs that I work with. Although “Singapore is a natural laboratory for researchers who wish to study cross-cultural and

cross-religious social dynamics because it has a multi-cultural, multi-lingual, and multi-religious population” (Jianbin and Mehta, 2003, p.486), I focused my attention in this study on OAs of Christian faith. This is to simplify the study and to apply the learning directly to the work of my church with OAs. Furthermore, due to the restrictions imposed during the Covid-19 pandemic, the research participants finally recruited were all ethnic Chinese (see section V.1 for details). However, this turned out to be a positive development because it allowed the research findings to be analysed within the same cultural context without having to isolate for differences arising from the research participants’ cultural backgrounds. Research participants from other ethnicities and faiths can be covered in subsequent research projects.

Next, instead of trying to find out the reasons for some OAs being weary of living, I decided to seek to understand those OAs who are positive about living and how they arrive at/maintain this perspective. This is because my interest is in helping my OAs develop or maintain a positive outlook towards life and not so much in the reasons for their bleak outlook.

Therefore, the final version of my research question was: ‘What is the spirituality of Christian Chinese-Singaporean older adults who are positively engaged with life?’ The purpose of exploring this was to identify the ways in which spiritual life can be a support and resource for positive living amongst Christian OAs so that my church’s programmes can take this into account and help more people enjoy the fullness of life.

I chose the term ‘spirituality’ because, although there is significant overlap between spirituality and religion, spirituality is a wider concept. According to the American sociologist Moberg (cited in chapter one), religiosity most often refers to commitment to a religious faith,

holding personal beliefs that one's faith advocates, and participation in the rituals and other activities associated with that faith; whereas "spirituality has a more experiential and existential focus upon an individual's internalized faith, values and beliefs and their influence upon daily behavior" (Moberg, 2005, p.14). The key words are "their influence upon daily behaviour" – to me, the spirituality that I seek to study should be able to impact the daily lives of my OAs such that they are able to get out of bed each morning feeling positive about the day, not hopeless and weary of life. I explore the definition of spirituality I am using, and the signs of positive engagement with life that I looked for in the next chapter.

II.3 Reasons for locating this research within the field of practical theology

The key reason for locating this research project within the discipline of practical theology is my own faith commitments and engagement with OAs as part of our church's mission. Assoc Prof Terry Veling, a theological educator and writer, wrote that theology should be a way of life, i.e. integrated into the weave and fabric of human living and is a verb-like word and not a noun-like word. I subscribe to this view. Theology is not only knowledge of God but also knowing God (Heitink, 1999, p.107). John Calvin (as cited in Heitink, 1999, p.108) argued that our knowledge of God and our knowledge of self are intimately connected. This unity between revelation and experience also leads toward the view of theology as a practical discipline. Following this argument, all theology is practical theology and can be a person's way of life. Veling also forwards the view that practical theology is an appeal that calls for God's people, to live and act on earth as "it is in heaven" (Veling, 2005, p.18). This does not mean that life on earth is perfect, rather that we could strive towards that perfection. Veling identified two fundamentally

interpretive acts that are central to theological activity – searching the scriptures and reading the signs of the times. Searching the scriptures, as explained by Veling, is an interpretive and communal exercise that links us with our faith tradition, filled with commentary, teaching, liturgy, art, prophetic witness and saintly lives; whereas reading the signs of the times means paying attention to God’s concern for the world. It means listening and responding to questions and issues circulating within our culture, society, our lives, our parishes, congregations, workplaces and neighbourhoods. For Veling, understanding these two interpretive acts, how they relate to each other and the response called forth are central to theology (Veling, 2005, p.25).

When I observed the weariness of living that some OAs displayed, including those of Christian faith, it appeared to be inconsistent with John 10:10, where Jesus Christ said that “The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy; I have come that they may have life, and have it to the full” (The Holy Bible, 1984). Is living life to the full only a future promise? I do not think so because I have also met Christians OAs that reminded me of Psalms 23 “¹The Lord is my shepherd, I lack nothing... ⁴ Even though I walk through the darkest valley, I will fear no evil”. These OAs were gentle, loving and thankful for each additional day and were not anxious about death. I believe that understanding the spirituality of this latter group of OAs would contribute towards helping the former group. My approach to this research therefore mirrors Veling’s approach, i.e. reading the signs of the times through listening to those aging in Singapore and searching the Scriptures.

The second reason for locating this research project in the field of practical theology is the desirable characteristics of a practical theology activity as described by the authors of “The

Blackwell Reader in Pastoral and Practical Theology”. They identified 14 characteristics that they considered essential for an activity to be practical theology (Woodward and Pattison, 2008, pp.13-16). Besides characteristics such as being honest, truthful and committed, skillful and demanding, socio-politically aware and committed, which are characteristics that all good research projects should strive for, the other characteristics identified by Woodward and Pattison include being interdisciplinary and transformational. All these desirable characteristics were kept in mind and guided me while I conducted this project.

My training in gerontology was used to help me understand the social, physical and psychological issues that the research participants have in old age. In addition to the work of many theologians including Veling, Heitink, Woodward and Pattison, Bernard of Clairvaux and John Wesley, the work of experts from other disciplines including psychology and sociology were also drawn upon. These included Erik Erikson’s theory of psychosocial development and Lars Tornstam’s theory of gerotranscendence.

When I embarked on this research project, I believed that it would be transformational for me and eventually, for the OAs that I work with. For example, I struggled with certain prayers because of verses such as 1 John 5:14-15: “¹⁴ This is the confidence we have in approaching God: that if we ask anything according to his will, he hears us. ¹⁵ And if we know that he hears us—whatever we ask—we know that we have what we asked of him”. Because of my training and work experience that emphasized efficiency, I struggled with praying to God for something that will be done eventually as it is according to His will. Further, due to my cultural upbringing, the idea that one should pester God until He gives one what one prays for (Isaiah 62:7) also did not

seem respectful. My siblings and I were brought up respecting those in authority. For example, as children, if we pester our parents for something that they have already refused to do/give, we usually end up getting flogged with a cane for being wilful. However, when I interviewed my research participants and heard them talk about their praying experiences, I understood the importance of the *time* spent in prayer to them. It was in those prayer times that a space was created for them to taste God's grace, and having tasted the Lord, they know that He is good (Psalms 34:8). It was also in this space that they felt God's presence. I can now better appreciate prayer as a means of grace and view it as the gift of a space to encounter God. Please refer to chapter VIII for details of how the results of this research can be transformational for the OAs that I work with.

II.4 Conclusion

As I embarked on my journey to better understand the spirituality of the local OAs, I found that there was limited research in this area. After my literature search and reflection on what my immediate aims were, I narrowed the scope of my research to Christian OAs but did not restrict it to only church practices as I believe "spirituality" is a wider concept. Although I have located this project in the field of practical theology because of my worldview and my current practice, I believe my research results will be useful to researchers in other fields who are studying how to support Singaporean OAs so that they have a positive outlook of old age.

III. Chapter Three - Conceptual Framework

This chapter explains the key concepts that have shaped my research and research question, i.e. old age, spirituality and being positively engaged with life. Each concept requires careful unfolding with attention to its meaning within different disciplines and in the Singaporean context. These concepts are inflected by culture and religious affiliations, and materially affect the criteria for the selection of the research participants. In this chapter I also set out the psychological, gerontological and theological perspectives that I used to develop my selection criteria.

III.1 Old age

III.1.1 How is old age defined?

Old age does not have a universally agreed definition. It could be based on chronology, for example, when one reaches a certain age; or on the basis of biology, i.e. how well one functions; or by social standards or norms, for example, when one becomes a grandparent or when one retires. According to the World Health Organisation, most developed world countries use the chronological age of 65 years as the definition of elderly or older people (World Health Organisation, 2002). Others have advocated defining it after a certain chronological age and a change in health status, such as no longer able to live independently (Orimo et al., 2006).

A serious shortcoming of using the chronological criterion for determining old age is that it assumes everyone ages in the same way and within an identical time frame. Obviously, this cannot be true since each of us is unique. Human beings are not biological clones, neither do they grow up in exactly the same set of circumstances even if they are

from the same family. Our life experiences affect how we perceive ourselves. Gerontologists Hiller and Barrow described how individuals define themselves to themselves, i.e. our “self-concept” dictates “the way in which people interpret and make meaning of the events that occur in their lives” (Hillier and Barrow, 2010, p.37) and it is the events that occur with the passage of time that is relevant to one’s self-concept, and not the passage of time per se. Charles Gerkin, theologian and the author of “The Living Human Document” also wrote that as “living human documents”, we continuously interpret our lives and the environment in which we are embedded (Gerkin, 1984).

In Singapore, chronological age is usually used to define who is an OA and the minimum age to qualify as an OA is 60 years old. For instance, to enjoy senior citizen concession on our public transport system, one has to be at least 60, but under the Singapore Retirement and Re-employment Act, our minimum retirement age is 63 years old. On the other hand, some government ministries define elderly or older people as those who are 65 or older (Ministry of Social and Family Development, 2015, p.3). In addition, most research done on OAs in Singapore used chronological age to define who they are. Hence, for better comparability with local studies, I am also using chronological age to define who OAs are in my research.

III.1.2 What does old age look like?

Aging is a process that everyone goes through from the day of birth and gerontology is the scientific study of mainly the biological, psychological and social aspects of this process. Biologically, as we age, our skin loses its elasticity and becomes wrinkled, our hair

becomes grey and thin, and our body less erect. We get tired easier and faster. We develop presbyopia and slowly lose our hearing, especially among men. As aging progress, we lose our teeth and may develop gum diseases, we gain weight and lose muscle strength, especially if we do not reduce our caloric intake and is not physically fit. The ability of the body cells to absorb calcium declines, resulting in more brittle bones. With wear and tear of our joints over time, the probability of arthritis and rheumatism increases with age. The ability to achieve homeostasis declines and we find it more difficult to get back to normal after a stressful event. Our organs become less efficient: the lungs have lower maximum breathing capacity, the volume of digestive juice decreases, the speed which the kidneys get rid of waste drop, bladder capacity decreases and the level of sex hormones drops setting off more changes to our bodies. There is also a drop in our immune system's ability to protect us from diseases, for example, older persons are less immune to flu, are likely to become more sick from it and have longer recovery periods.

However, this physiological decline in bodily function is offset somewhat by “an intellectual and psychological increase in competence”, i.e. our wise use of our past experiences (Hillier and Barrow, 2010, p.94). Even though our five senses that relay environmental information to our brain loses acuity with age, our crystallised intelligence, i.e. knowledge gained through experience and education, do not. Fluid intelligence, i.e. our information processing skills, does decline with age but overall, research has shown that declines in intelligence is only significant after people reach their seventies. Memory varies greatly among individuals of all ages and types of memory vary greatly within the same

individual, i.e. inter-individual and intra-individual differences are great. There seems to be a slight and progressive decline as we age but the extent of such deterioration remains inconclusive. Senility or mental disorder in old age is also not an inevitable consequence of growing old (Hillier and Barrow, 2010, p.135) and some forms of such “mental disorders” can be treated such as those due to thyroid deficiency or emotional problems. Certain chronic organic brain diseases such as Alzheimer’s disease (AD), have a higher prevalence among OAs. Research has shown this may be because more people are living into later life as the incidence of AD does not appear to have increased. Functional disorders, i.e. emotional problems of psychological rather than physical origin that interfere with daily functioning, can affect an individual in any stage of his life but the effects of such disorder in an OA can be more debilitating. For the OA, depression may follow the onset of a disabling illness or loss of a spouse. The loss of a spouse could mean not only a relationship loss for the OA but also a role loss, i.e. loss of the spousal role. It could also be a material loss because the surviving spouse may be forced to sell or vacate their matrimonial home, for instance. In addition, it could be an intrapsychic loss because the death could force the abandonment of plans for a particular future with the deceased spouse. Similarly, the onset of a disabling illness may not be just a functional loss to the OA, it could be material loss because the OA has to leave home to live in a care facility. For OAs, the death of a loved one or onset of some disabling illnesses are more likely than for younger people. Hence they are more likely to suffer from some, if not all of the six major types of losses described by the theologians, Mitchell and Anderson, i.e. material, relationship, intrapsychic, functional, role and systemic losses (Mitchell and Anderson, 1983, pp.36–44). Kenneth R. Mitchell was

VERSION_DEC 2025

a Professor of Pastoral Care at Eden Theological Seminary in Missouri before his death in 1991 whereas Herbert Anderson is the Research Professor of Practical Theology at Pacific Lutheran Theological Seminary in Berkeley California. These are some of the challenges of living longer, and for Singaporeans, the latter is something that we can expect to have.

Singaporeans have the longest life expectancy now as compared to any time in the country's short history, but the government's attempt to increase the health span of its population had not been as effective until the last few years. According to the 2019 report on the burden of disease in Singapore, the average Singaporean born in 2017 can expect to live for 85 years and spend 11 years in poor health, whereas those born in 1990 had a life expectancy of 76 with only 9 years in poor health. (Epidemiology & Disease Control Division, Ministry of Health, Singapore and Institute of Health Metrics and Evaluation, 2019, p.19). The causes of disabilities that showed the largest increases during the study period were sense organ diseases, such as hearing loss and vision impairments; neurological disorders, which includes Alzheimer's disease and other dementias; and musculoskeletal disorders. However, in a more recent speech at a local symposium in 2023, Singapore's Minister of Health said that the average Singaporean suffers from 10 years of ill health before death. Nationwide programmes have been introduced in recent years with the aim of shortening the gap between her population's lifespan and health span as "Singapore is different from the other Blue Zones, such as Okinawa prefecture in Japan, because it does not have a tradition of healthy lifestyles. The pace of life is fast and stressful; many families keep to themselves and rarely talk to their immediate neighbours" (Teo, 2023b). The pursuit

of career and scholastic excellence has not left much time for being a good neighbour in our highly competitive society. This competitiveness and pursuit of excellence is especially pronounced among the Chinese Singaporeans because of the Chinese's long history of using rigorous nationwide examinations, such as the imperial examinations, to select bureaucrats. Excelling in such examinations was an important way to gain social status and power not just for the individual, but also for the family and clan/community. Hence, there is a bias towards those who have the potential to excel. Most OAs would not be part of this group as they would have realised most of their potential.

III.1.3 How does the Singaporean society view old age?

Biologically, Singaporeans have life expectancy comparable with those living in other blue zones, but as a society, we may not be as kind to our OAs. “In order for the aged to have status and value”, according to sociologist Leo Simmons (Simmons, 1945 cited in Hillier and Barrow, 2010, p.7), the culture of a society “must state that aging is a positive achievement and must value the aged”. Historically, in the agricultural communities where most Singaporean OAs originated from, the status of OAs is significantly related to property ownership as it resulted in the control of political resources. However, Singapore first flourished because of her port and value-added services associated with it. Her push towards industrialisation had been rapid and very successful as compared to other developing countries. Her industrialisation reinforced the value of productivity and her speed of industrial, technological and social changes made skills and knowledge obsolete quickly. Like in other industrialised countries, employers in Singapore tend to value younger,

stronger, faster employees with newly acquired knowledge over older employees. Our current batch of OAs are mainly first-generation migrants and their families who have moved to Singapore seeking a better life. They are among the first wave of immigrants who came mainly from poor farming families in rural China, India/Pakistan, Indonesia and Malaysia. Singapore had developed quickly into a first-world industrialised nation within five decades of independence. The OAs bore the full brunt of the effects of the rapid socio-economic changes in the nation – finding the experiences, knowledge and skills that they have acquired earlier in their lives obsoleted faster than they could gain new ones, the latter hindered by their generally low educational levels. According to our Department of Statistics, the mean years of schooling for those 25 years and above in 1980 was 4.7 years compared to 11.1 years in 2018 (Department of Statistics Singapore, 2023).

Property ownership in Singapore, is also not “monopolised” by the older generation as the government effectively owns all the land in Singapore because of its legislations on land acquisition. She provides subsidised public housing for around 80% of her people. With very low overall unemployment rate of 2.4% on average between 1992 and 2023 (Manpower Research & Statistics Dept, 2024), most younger Singaporeans can afford to apply for subsidised housing once they register for marriage or when they turn 35 years old. Inheriting property rights from parents or grandparents can be an advantage but is not a necessity. Existing government policies for subsidies/rebates also favour the formation of small households consisting of a nuclear family, even though young families are encouraged to live near their parents. OAs are encouraged to continue living in the community and not

in institutions such as homes for the aged or nursing homes because the government believes that it is healthier for OAs and, also because of her “many helping hands” approach to social welfare.

The formation of nuclear families means that most children of school-going age do not live with any OAs. According to the “Population Trend 2019”, no more than 11% of Singapore households are made up of three or more generations. The exact percentage is smaller since they are grouped under the “other” category of households (Department of Statistics, Ministry of Trade & Industry, Singapore, 2019, p.21). This reduces cross-generational interaction, an important way of bridging the generation gap created by rapid social changes. Among the different ethnic groups, the Chinese has the lowest average household size of 3.1 persons with 61.6% of Chinese households with three or fewer persons according to the 2020 census (Department of Statistics Singapore, 2021). This means that most Chinese OAs do not live with their grandchildren.

Generation gap contributes to ageism, i.e. the prejudiced behavior of individuals and systems within their culture against OAs, and the negative consequences of inaccurate stereotyping of the elderly (Hillier and Barrow, 2010, p.12). Negative stereotyping or labelling is the first step of stigmatisation which allows so-called “normal people” to single out victims for rejection and discrimination. According to Allan Kellehear, a medical and public health sociologist, negatively labelled people are “usually chosen for their non-productivity, because ‘normals’ are productive people” (Kellehear, 2007, p.220). In his book ‘A social history of dying’, Kellehear also wrote that in the “cosmopolitan period” – a period

which describes what Singapore has been experiencing – “status has become a negotiated quality dependent on maintaining positive economic, social and bodily information for interpersonal support. Loss of a job or income, demotion, public disgrace, physical or psychiatric disability, contagious disease or even disagreeable looks will compromise one’s ongoing status in the social world of the cosmopolite” (Kellehear, 2007, p.215). This is something I experienced myself, especially during the period when I could not walk properly. For the OAs, not having a job, failing health and looking old not only compromise their social status but contribute towards their stigmatisation. When someone is stigmatised, most people relate to them based on a single characteristic, in this case, the characteristic of being “old”. The actual identity of the stigmatised, which composes of multiple roles and social expressions, is ignored.

I remember an incident involving a Chinese couple. I was sitting with the old lady during her hospitalisation in a community hospital ward. She was getting anxious because her husband, who was supposed to bring her lunch, was very late. When he finally turned up, he apologised and said that he had underestimated the time it took to walk from his home to the hospital. When we asked him his reason for not taking the public bus, he said because the previous day he was reprimanded by a youngster, who was taking the same public bus, for taking too long to board it. The youngster asked him in Mandarin why was he taking the bus when he was “so old” and said that he was obstructing other passengers from boarding the bus. The old man used a walking stick as he was not steady on his feet. He could not walk fast and had to be careful with stairs to avoid falling. He brought his wife lunch because

she had complained about the hospital food. He wanted her to at least enjoy her lunch as she had already been trapped in her hospital bed for several weeks. For me, the fact that no one on the bus, including the bus driver, stood up for the old man spoke volumes about the local public's perception of the aged, i.e. that they slow down and inconvenience others.

Prejudiced behavior against OAs, i.e. ageism, contributes to the fear of aging and people try to hide their age when they can, going to great lengths to project a youthful image. This is also happening in Singapore as described by Helen Ko, a local gerontologist, in her news article on the attitudes of local employers towards older workers. She wrote: “the stereotypical views of these workers are so prevalent that some of them even resort to disguising their real age in job applications. To boost their chances of securing interviews, some use a much younger photograph of themselves in their WhatsApp profiles while others omit some work experiences in their resumes” (Ko, 2019). Such a phenomenon shows that not only were the OAs discriminated against, but they also seemed resigned to the discrimination. Instead of putting in effort to work against the ageism, they became “complicit” in it, especially among those who are in their fifties. Many of them are among my circle of ex-colleagues and business associates. They dress and speak like their adult children/nephews and nieces, work-out at the gym at least three times a week, use supplements and micro-surgeries to look young. Unfortunately, such coping behavior strains not only their physical health but also their mental and financial health. Their appeal to medical science in their attempts to stop aging is like the “prolongevity” approach described by the American historian, Christopher Lasch, in his book “The Culture of Narcissism:

American Life in An Age of Diminishing Expectations”. According to Lasch, this approach relies on medical science to deal with the problem of aging completely (Lasch, 1991, p.215). Regardless of the validity of such reliance, their complicity does not help the OAs in their fight against ageism. Further, this resistance to becoming old could eventually become resignation as they continue to age. This could explain the “waiting to die” attitude I have observed among my OAs which made it difficult for them to be positively engaged with life.

Having defined old age as those who are at least 65 and described the challenges of old age from gerontological and sociological perspectives, I now turn to the role of spirituality in old age, beginning with the definitional question of what is spirituality?

III.2 Spirituality

In order to arrive at a definition of spirituality for this project, I examined how it has been defined in past research papers. As mentioned in chapter one, Moberg summarised the results of research on spirituality, aging and health done up to 2005 in his paper “Research in Spirituality, Religion, and Aging” (Moberg, 2005, p.17). He noted the difficulty in its definition as it reflects the cultural values, philosophical assumptions and theological positions of its users (Moberg, 2005, p.14). There were definitions that emphasized meaning and unity, interpreted it as a dimension of persons that transcend self or any experience at hand, focused on it being a motivating force or belief in a power apart from a person’s own existence, others linked it with breath and its activities (Moberg, 2005, p.13). Another researcher, Cheryl Delgado, a professor at Cleveland State University, reviewed 117 publications through an internet search on the word “spirituality” and identified four characteristics of spirituality. These are: (1) faith or acceptance of a personal belief

system; (2) a personal search for meaning and purpose; (3) an awareness of connection or relatedness to others including the divine; and (4) self-transcendence (Delgado, 2005, p.159) where one is not constrained by one's physical existence.

Within the field of spirituality and ageing, two key voices are those of Elizabeth MacKinlay (inaugural Director of the Centre for Ageing and Pastoral Studies at St Mark's National Theological Centre, Canberra and Professor in the School of Theology, Charles Sturt University) and Susan McFadden (Professor Emerita of Psychology of University of Wisconsin Oshkosh and co-founder of the Fox Valley Memory Project, a nonprofit that offers programs and services for people living with dementia in northeast Wisconsin). MacKinlay's research on OAs in Australia is well-regarded locally and some of her research results were adopted for use by our local researchers. Both MacKinlay and McFadden conducted many interviews with OAs and heard their stories, identifying spirituality with the meaningful connections in their lives. MacKinlay has suggested that spiritual dimension is mediated through relationship, environment/creation, the arts and religion, and so locates religion as a subset in her diagram of the spiritual dimension of ageing (MacKinlay and Trevitt, 2012, p.18). Thus, differentiating spirituality from religion which she defined as "the practice of a religious faith that includes a community of believers, doctrine and a body of understood religious behaviours and practice" (MacKinlay and Trevitt, 2012, p.17). Similarly, Joanna Collicutt, the British clinical psychologist whose main area of research is in the psychology of religion, distinguished these two concepts when she described spirituality as "more individualist than collectivist; more emotion-focused than practice-focused; more inwardly than outwardly directed; more informal than highly structured, with self-actualisation more important

than sacrificial demands and duties; and more anti-authoritarian than religion is”(Collicutt, 2011). I find helpful this distinction, and am adopting a definition of spirituality proposed by McFadden, i.e. the experience of meaningful connectedness(McFadden, 2022). Phenomenologically, then spirituality is a broader category than religion. However, because the focus of this research concerns Singaporean Chinese Christian OAs, I am expecting that their sense of meaningful connectedness will be constructed largely within Christian doctrines and practices. It is now to an understanding of Christian spirituality that I turn.

III.2.1 What is Christian Spirituality?

From a theological perspective, according to Chan, a local theologian who was the dean of studies at the Trinity Theological College in Singapore, Christian spirituality is the lived reality of one’s faith (Chan, 2009, p.16). For Philip Sheldrake, a British theologian who also has a background in philosophy and the social sciences, it is the “conscious relationship with God, in Jesus Christ, through the indwelling of the Holy Spirit and in the context of a community of believers” (Sheldrake, 1995, p.60). Joanna Collicutt in her book “The Psychology of Christian Character Formation” refers to Paul’s description of Christians as letters written by Christ using the Spirit of God as ink (2 Cor. 3.2) and defines Christian spirituality as ‘life in God’s Spirit and a living relationship with God’s Spirit’ (Collicutt, 2015, p.5).

From these writers I am adopting an approach to Christian spirituality that concerns how we live our relationship with God, manifested in what we do and how we change (i.e. our behaviours and attitudes) as our faith develops.

The notion of faith development raises the question of how spirituality and faith are defined and related to each other. Just as there are many definitions of spirituality, there are many definitions of faith. The literature of faith development is relevant to this study because it looks at what kind of faith or spirituality is adequate for older adults. According to James Fowler, the most prominent thinker in this field, faith is “an orientation of the total person, giving purpose and goal to one's hopes and strivings, thoughts and actions” (Fowler, 1995, p.14). For Fowler, faith is not primarily the content of faith but the act of faithing that he believed was common to all people. For Westerhoff, who acknowledged Fowler’s influence on his theory (See section III.2.2.4 below for description of Westerhoff’s theory), faith is a way of behaving which involves knowing, being and willing (Westerhoff, 2000, p.87). Faith is a verb while religion is focused upon faith’s expression within institutions such as churches, documents, statements of belief, convictions and moral codes etc. (Westerhoff, 2000, p.18). For my purposes Fowler, Westerhoff, Chan and Sheldrake are all focused on the way in which faith is lived. This is what I mean by spirituality.

From a phenomenological perspective, the American psychologist Gordon Allport wrote about those who use their religion and those who live their religion (Allport and Ross, 1967). Those people with extrinsic orientation are likely to use religion in various ways, e.g. to provide security and solace, sociability and distraction, status and self-justification. Whereas person with intrinsic orientation “find their master motive in religion...Having embraced a creed the individual endeavors to internalize it and follow it fully. It is in this sense that he *lives* his religion.”(Allport and Ross, 1967, p.434). However, the authors

pointed out that most people fall upon a continuum between these two. Batson, another American psychologist, suggested that there are also those who see religion as quest. An individual who “approaches religion in this way recognizes that he or she does not know, and probably never will know, the final truth about such matters. Still, the questions are deemed important, and however tentative and subject to change, answers are sought. There may or may not be a clear belief in a transcendent reality, but there is a transcendent, religious aspect to the individual’s life.” (Batson, Schoenrade and Ventis, 1993, p.166).

In the light of the above, I decided to use the term “Christian spirituality” because of its focus on the impact of the contents and practices of Christianity upon attitudes and behaviours. While spirituality/faithing may be universal, my focus is on the spirituality of a particular subgroup of Christians in Singapore to understand the impact of the content and practices of their Christian faith upon their attitudes to life.

III.2.2 What “spirituality” to look for in the research participants

The kind of Christian spirituality that would support Christian OAs to be positively engaged in life was the type that I wanted to study in this research project. The New Testament (1 Cor 3:2; Col 1.28) presents a vision of faith that matures. In order to understand what kind of faith might be adequate to the challenges of old age I considered existing literature on faith development, which all came from the Western theological tradition because of a lack of research in this area in the local context. Across the centuries various ways of conceiving the stages of Christian maturation have been developed. Here I examine

four influential approaches: Bernard of Clairvaux from the pre-modern period, John Wesley from the Enlightenment period, and James Fowler and John Westerhoff from the 20th century.

III.2.2.1 Bernard of Clairvaux's description of spirituality

In the pre-modern period, an influential example of understanding faith developmentally is provided by Bernard of Clairvaux (1090-1153). He was a French Abbot who was an important leader of the Benedictine monastic reform. In his treatise “On Loving God”, he described four degrees of love. The first degree is when one loves oneself for one’s own sake. The second degree is when one loves God for one’s own benefit because it is “a matter of prudence” to keep from offending God. The third degree is for one to love God for God’s sake. This happens when one has tasted God’s sweetness and loves God truthfully. The fourth degree is when one loves oneself for the sake of God. At this stage, according to Bernard of Clairvaux, one loses oneself as if one no longer existed and “we wish that neither ourselves or other beings have been nor to be except for His will alone”(Clairvaux, 1995, pp.25–30). He gave the example of holy martyrs as those who would have experienced at least partially this kind of love where one forgets oneself and only focus on God’s will. I would associate Bernard of Clairvaux’s first two degrees of love with those who have no real religion or an extrinsic orientation towards their faith as described by Allport and Ross in section III.2.1 above. The third degree of love is likely to be intrinsic because Bernard of Clairvaux wrote that at this stage, God is loved “for God's sake and not for his own benefit”. Finally, I expect the fourth degree of love to be rare because the

abbot “do not think that can take place for sure untilthe heart does not have to think of the body and the soul no longer has to give it life and feeling as in this life” and even the holy martyrs might have only “partially” experienced it. Hence, for this research project, I did not set my criteria to look for the last degree of love but was looking for those who professed to love God for His sake or have “tasted God’s sweetness” (Clairvaux, 1995, p.28).

III.2.2.2 John Wesley’s description of spirituality

Similarly focusing his thinking on growth in love of God, is the work of John Wesley (1703-1791). His work interests me particularly because I am a Methodist working in a Methodist context. John Wesley, the father of Methodism, was not a pure theorist but a practitioner, a practical theologian. Writing in 18th century England, in his sermon on zeal (Wesley, 1758), Wesley gave his vision of Christian living where he identified discipleship practices and arranged them according to their importance. These practices were arranged under the following headings, from the least to the most important:

- 1) the church – where Christians provoke one another to love, holy tempers and good works;
- 2) works of piety - such as receiving the Lord’s supper, private and public prayer, fasting as well as reading and hearing the Scriptures;
- 3) works of mercy – performing charitable acts and other means to encounter God;

- 4) the Holy tempers - including long-suffering, gentleness, meekness, goodness, fidelity, temperance;

and lastly, the most important or core of these discipleship practices is

- 5) love – love of God and neighbour (Stobart, 2019, p.2)

In this sermon, Wesley described the relative importance of these practices and their role in supporting love of God and neighbour – “count all things loss in comparison to this” (Wesley, 1758, p.8). He also provided his rationale for his arrangement of these practices – “If you have not compassion on your fellow- servants, neither will your Lord have pity on you. Bring no more vain oblations. All your service is an abomination to the Lord.” (Wesley, 1758, p.7). Where works of piety interfere with works of mercy, the latter should be preferred because God will have mercy and not sacrifice (Hosea 6:6, NIV). The practices identified in Wesley’s vision above were very useful in helping me to identify my research participants as many are observable and were used to draft the participant selection criteria. Examples of such observable practices are attending church, praying, studying the Bible and helping others by volunteering in programmes that benefit the community.

III.2.2.3 Fowler’s faith development theory

In the twentieth century, discussions of faith development, originating in the United States have sought to be more phenomenological and more evidence based, drawing on a variety of disciplines to form their conclusions. James Fowler (1940-2015), an American theologian and researcher in human development, developed his

VERSION_DEC 2025

theory of faith development in the structural-development tradition for all faiths, not just the Christian faith. His six stages have been summarised by Fowler as follows:

Stage I Intuitive-Projective Faith: Imagination, stimulated by stories, gestures, and symbols, and not yet controlled by logical thinking, combines with perception and feelings to create long-lasting images that represent both the protective and threatening powers surrounding one's life.

Stage II Mythic-Literal Faith: The developing ability to think logically helps one order the world with categories of causality, space and time, using narrative; one can enter into the perspectives of others; and capture life meaning in stories; symbols are perceived literally and as one-dimensional.

Stage III Synthetic-Conventional Faith: A coherent identity is formed within a group, integrating diverse images of self into a coherent identity. A personal faith is formed from conventional elements, the meanings of symbols are implicit, rich and powerful, supporting identity and enabling one to unite in emotional solidarity with others.

Stage IV Individuative-Reflective Faith: Critical reflection upon one's beliefs and values and their meaning; an ability to see oneself with the eyes of another; understanding of the self and others as part of a social system; the internalization of authority and the assumption of responsibility for making explicit choices of ideology and lifestyle open the way for critically self-aware commitments in relationships and vocation.

VERSION_DEC 2025

Stage V Conjunctive Faith: Polarities are embraced; there is alertness to paradox and the need for multiple interpretations of reality. Symbol and story, metaphor and myth are newly appreciated as irreducible vehicles for expressing truth. There is openness to the traditions of others and an interest in the unconscious processes of the self.

Stage VI Universalising Faith: Paradox and polarities dissolve in a oneness with the power of being; vision and commitment free one for a passionate, yet detached spending of the self in love. An ability to overcome division, oppression and violence and co-operation in God's commonwealth of love and justice (Leach, 1997, pp.28–29).

The six stages are closely linked to the development of an individual's mental and operational capabilities as one grows from infancy. This means one can only develop the next stage of faith after the individual has developed the corresponding mental and operational capabilities, but the transition to the next stage of faith development does not automatically happen as a person grows from infancy to adulthood. Per Fowler's theory, one can develop to a particular stage of faith and then stay at that stage without moving to the next stage for the rest of one's life. His faith development theory focuses not on the content of one's faith but on its structure. Fowler identified seven categories in relation to which the dominant features of the stage of a person's faith may be identified: form of logic (based on Jean Piaget's work), perspective taking, form of moral judgment (based on Lawrence Kohlberg's work), locus of authority, form of world coherence, bounds of social awareness (based on Erik

Erikson's work) and symbolic functions. Fowler's own method for identifying the faith stage of any adult required an in-depth interview with each individual. For that reason, I did not attempt to use his theory to develop my research participant selection criteria. In addition, critiques of Fowler's theory from non-Western contexts made me suspect that it might not be entirely transferable to the local context. These are discussed in some detail in relation to my findings in Chapter VII.

III.2.2.4 Westerhoff's faith development theory

John Westerhoff III (b.1933), an American professor of Theology and Christian Nurture for more than two decades in Duke University, suggested that there are four styles of faith – one expanding from one style to the next by adding new elements and needs but without outgrowing the earlier style. He had developed his styles after reviewing Fowler's stages of faith development which had six stages.

Unlike Fowler's theory, Westerhoff's theory is not closely linked to one's structural development and is focused only on the Christian faith. Westerhoff's first style of faith is "experienced faith" as "a person first learns Christ not as a theological affirmation but as an affective experience" (Westerhoff, 2000, p.90). "Experienced faith" is the result of our interaction with other Christians. God made Himself known through His words and actions – the Word became flesh and made his dwelling among us (John 1:14). Westerhoff's second style of faith is "affiliative faith" where one seeks to act with others in an accepting community with a clear sense of identity. There is a dominance of religious affections and a sense of authority. The third style is "searching

faith”. This style of faith is characterized by doubt or critical judgement where one’s faith is questioned; experimentation where alternatives to earlier understanding and ways are explored so that one can reach one’s own convictions; and the need to commit one’s life to persons or causes. Provided that the needs of “searching faith” have been met, Westerhoff suggested that one may expand into an owned style of faith – where due to the struggle that one went through to arrive at “owned faith”, it often appears as a great illumination or enlightenment. People with “owned faith” strive to witness their faith through both their words and deeds, i.e. there is a great change in their behaviour. They will struggle to eliminate any dissonance between their faith as stated in their beliefs and their actions in the world, but “liberation, wholeness of life, spiritual health and identity are known and (such) persons can live a life in but not of the world” (Westerhoff, 2000, p.95). They understood who they are and where they stand in the great scheme of things in God’s creation. According to Westerhoff, adults typically have their faith arrested in the “affiliative style” (Westerhoff, 2000, p.97). Although Westerhoff’s work comes from a Western context, the key observable characteristic of those with this dominant style of faith, i.e. belonging and participating in a Christian community, was used to validate one of the research participant selection criteria developed.

III.2.2.5 Probable faith characteristics of potential research participants

Based on the discussion so far, for one’s Christian spirituality to have a positive impact on a Christian OA’s life, the research participant is likely to at least

have Bernard of Clairvaux's third degree of loving God for God's sake or the affiliative faith of Westerhoff's theory and be zealous enough for God to perform the acts of piety and/or mercy described by Wesley.

Bernard of Clairvaux's first two degrees of love for God is more a form of self-preservation where one loves oneself and tries to gain more resources to achieve that. There is no sign of seeing past himself/herself and his/her own needs. Therefore, such a person is less likely to experience support from his/her faith whereas in the third degree of loving God for God's sake, there is recognition of God's godliness and the ability to see beyond him/herself. Hence, such a Christian most probably will not be trapped in the OAs' declining bodies and spiral down into despair.

In Westerhoff's stage two – affiliative faith, the Christian OA has a clear sense of identity as part of his/her church community, affirmation of the story and way of life of such community dominated by religious affections. Again, this type of faith is likely to provide some support to the OA during crises, if not directly from the OA's relationship with God, at least indirectly from being part of his/her church community.

Finally, the potential participant should show some zeal for God, be involved in his/her church activities, and perform acts of piety such as praying, searching the Scriptures and receiving the Lord's Supper. These acts, besides being manifestation of their relationship with God, are likely to provide social and emotional support to the OAs who practise them.

III.3 Positive engagement with life

VERSION_DEC 2025

III.3.1 A psychological/gerontological perspective

So far in this chapter I have attempted to define old age and describe some of its challenges in the Singaporean context, and to articulate a vision of the kind of Christian spirituality that will help me identify suitable research participants whose experiences can help shed light on how Christian spirituality can support those living in old age. Because I wanted to interview those who are positively engaged with life, I needed to gain a clearer understanding of how that might manifest itself to be able to purposively identify appropriate participants. To get a clearer understanding, I put these theological perspectives alongside perspectives from psychology and gerontology. James Woodward and Stephen Pattison, the British practical theologians who edited the Blackwell Reader in Pastoral and Practical Theology, noted that “theology in itself cannot reveal all that one needs to know adequately to respond to contemporary situations and issues” (Woodward and Pattison, 2000, p.15). Theologians are human beings and do not claim to know all there is to know about God and His creation. There are many others in other disciplines that are performing rigorous research work to understand human beings to contribute to their wellbeing. Personal development is an area that has been heavily researched and theorized in psychology whereas gerontology focuses on the study of aging and OAs. Hence, I have chosen to look at the work of several seminal thinkers in these fields. They are Maslow, Erikson and Tornstam. Maslow’s and Erikson’s theories are on how a person develops into a healthy person and live life well as they grow, whereas Tornstam claimed to have identified the final stage in the process towards maturation and wisdom (Tornstam, 1994, pp.203–204). All three gave descriptions of the attributes of these people who have “successfully” completed

their development (per Maslow and Erikson) or reached gerotranscendence (per Tornstam). These attributes are useful input in the development of my participant selection criteria.

Abraham Maslow (1908-1970) was chosen because his theory has withstood the test of time for almost eight decades. His seminal piece “A theory of human motivation” was published in the Psychological Review in 1943. Although he had not used empirical research to support his theory, it has been studied, referenced and used extensively by other researchers and academics in their own work. The fact that his theory is still being studied and used more than 70 years after its publication, is more telling of its ability to describe personal development than other theories that had been “empirically validated” but no longer referred to after their publications. He was also the first psychologist to focus on the study of people who are psychologically healthy instead of sick.

The other seminal thinker that I chose is Erik Erikson (1902-1994), Maslow’s contemporary. Maslow cross-referenced Erikson’s psychosocial development theory in his book “Motivation and Personality” published in 1954, and suggested that the continuum of increasing degree of need gratification, if taken as “steps or levels of maturing or personal growth toward self-actualisation, through the individual’s life-span, it supplies a schema for a developmental theory roughly approximating and paralleling Freud’s and Erikson’s developmental system” (Maslow, 1987, p.38). Erikson’s eight stages of psychosocial development were published in his book “Childhood and Society” in 1950. Erikson passed away in 1994 but his work is still being referenced and studied today by students and researchers. Erikson’s wife, Joan Erikson added a ninth stage to the original eight stages of

psychosocial development (Erikson and Erikson, 1998) when she updated the last book they co-authored. She also referred to the theory on gerotranscendence proposed by Lars Tornstam, the Swedish gerontologist/sociologist, in her discussion of this ninth stage of psychosocial development.

Tornstam (1943-2016) developed the theory of gerotranscendence (Tornstam, 1994) to explain the behavior of OAs when he found that the theories that existed then could not explain those behaviours to his satisfaction. He and researchers such as his colleagues at Uppsala University, Associate Professor Barbro Wadensten and Professor Emeritus Marianne Carlsson, did extensive research on his theory using the empirical approach. For example, Tornstam had identified the dimensions of gerotranscendence after both qualitative interviews (50 Swedish between 52-97 years old), and quantitative analyses of responses of 912 Danish (between 74-100 years old) and 2002 Swedes (between 20-85 years old).

III.3.2 What are the characteristics of Maslow's self-actualisers (SAs)?

According to Maslow, SAs are those who have fully used their potential and he could find very few of them. He noted that “self-actualisation, since I have studied it mostly in older people tends to be seen as an ultimate or final state of affairs, a far goal, rather than a dynamic process, active throughout life, Being rather than Becoming” (Maslow, 1998, p.32).

In his book “Toward a psychology of Being”, Maslow wrote that the clinically observed characteristic of SAs were: “superior perception of reality; increased acceptance (not resignation) of self, others and of nature; increased spontaneity; increased problem-

centering; increased detachment and desire for privacy; increased autonomy, and resistance to acculturation; greater freshness of appreciation, and richness of emotional reaction; has higher frequency of peak experiences; increased identification with the human species; improved interpersonal relations; more democratic character structure; greatly increased creativeness and certain changes in the value system” (Maslow, 1998, p.32). Peak experiences are moments of ecstasy (Maslow, 1971, p.48). “It is as though the person ascends for a brief moment to the top of a very high peak, and from there, looks out at limitless horizons with ecstasy and wonder and awe” (Maslow, 1998, p.xx) and can include such phenomena as mystical experiences, aesthetic experiences, emotional experiences involving nature etc. The other characteristics of SAs are mentioned in another of his book “Motivation and Personality”, i.e. humility and respect; having high moral standards; able to clearly distinguish and appreciate between means and ends; humor and resolution of dichotomies. Despite many positive characteristics, Maslow emphasized that the SAs have imperfections as they are human (Maslow, 1987, pp.131–149). Keeping these characteristics in mind, I will look at those whom Erikson considered to have successfully negotiated each stage of their psychosocial development and should be able to manage life well.

III.3.3 What are the qualities of Erikson’s successful “basic virtue” acquirer?

Based on his clinical practice and cross-cultural studies, Erikson identified eight basic psychosocial conflicts which are present through our lives to some degree but comes to the fore at different stages of our lives. The positive resolution of the focal conflict in a particular stage of life will help us manage future conflicts, and negative resolution will

cause difficulties later in our lives. From infancy to old age, at each major stage, one has to balance two seemingly contrary dispositions, i.e. the syntonic and dystonic, to develop a basic virtue. The stages, the respective focal conflict and basic virtue gained if the syntonic and dystonic is successfully balanced are listed in Table 1 below.

	Stage:	Focal conflict:	Basic Virtue
1	Infancy	Basic trust vs. mistrust	Hope - the enduring belief in the benevolence of fate; this according to Erikson, is the ontogenetic basis of faith.
2	Early Childhood	Autonomy vs. shame, doubt	Will - the determination to exercise free choice as well as self-restraint; a maturing will, and recognition of its limitation, is the basis for acceptance of law.
3	Play Age	Initiative vs. guilt	Purpose - the courage to envisage and pursue valued goals.
4	School Age	Industry vs. inferiority	Competence - the free exercise of dexterity and intelligence in completing tasks.
5	Adolescence	Identity vs. role Confusion	Fidelity - the ability to sustain loyalties freely pledged in spite of the contradictions of value systems. It is the cornerstone of identity.
6	Young Adulthood	Intimacy vs. isolation	Love - mutuality of devotion which pervades the intimacy of individuals and is the basis of ethical concern as elaborated in affiliated patterns.
7	Adulthood	Generativity vs. self-absorption/stagnation	Care - the widening concern for what has been generated by love, necessity, or accident; it overcomes the ambivalence of arising with irreversible obligation and attends to the needs of all that has been generated.

	Stage:	Focal conflict:	Basic Virtue
8	Old Age	Ego Integrity vs. Despair	Wisdom - detached concern with life in the face of death. It maintains and learns to convey the integrity of experience, in spite of the decline of bodily and mental functions.

Table 1: Psychosocial stages of life (Erikson, Erikson and Kivnick, 1986, pp.34–38).

Per Erikson, the development of the virtues of hope, will, purpose, competence, fidelity, love, care and wisdom, will allow an individual to live life well as compared to those who do not have them. I will look at the last two stages in greater detail since my focus is on OAs. In the seventh stage, the individual is faced with generativity vs stagnation. Generativity is primarily concerned with establishing and guiding the next generation and this is in tension with self-absorption/stagnation. In reaching a balance between the two during middle-age, the individual learns to care for that which one truly cares for (Erikson, Erikson and Kivnick, 1986, p.50). In old age, the reconciling of generativity and stagnation involves the OA in expressing a “grand-generativity” that is beyond the direct responsibility for “maintaining the world” that one experiences in middle adulthood. The OA is challenged to accept caring and to do so in a caring way (Erikson, Erikson and Kivnick, 1986, p.74).

In Erikson’s eighth stage, individuals are expected to have achieved wisdom, i.e. a form of informed and detached concern for life in the face of death after having balanced the tension between ego-integrity and despair. Ego-integrity is “the acceptance of one's one and only life cycle as something that had to be and that, by necessity, permitted of no substitutions” whereas despair is the feeling that the time is now too short for the individual

to attempt alternate roads to integrity. “The lack or loss of this accrued ego integration is signified by fear of death: (when) the one and only life cycle is not accepted as the ultimate of life”(Erikson, 1987, p.242). In his final book published in 1982, when discussing the 8th stage, Erikson suggested that hope, the basic virtue of the first stage, should be called faith by the time it has developed into “mature hope” (Erikson, 1982, p.62).

After Erikson’s death, his wife and collaborator, Joan Erikson added a 9th stage to his theory to cover those in their eighties and nineties. She believes that despair which haunts the OA in 8th stage will be a close companion at the 9th stage because of failing body and mind. “To face down despair with faith and appropriate humility,” she wrote, “is perhaps the wisest course” (Erikson and Erikson, 1998, p.106). I will do a comparison between the characteristics of the self-actualiser and basic virtues after we look at the characteristics of that those who have “gerotranscended” under Tornstam’s theory.

III.3.4 What are the attributes of Tornstam’s gerotranscenders?

Tornstam developed his theory of gerotranscendence in his effort to reformulate the disengagement theory on aging. The latter was the first theory on aging but this theory in its original form has since been rejected by most gerontologists (Tornstam, 1989). Instead of disengagement, Tornstam suggested that the change in social interaction as one ages could be the result of a higher degree of transcendence, allowing the individual to enter a new meta-world with a new definition of reality. He used the term “gerotranscendence” to describe this shift in meta-perspective from a materialistic and rational view to a more cosmic and transcendent one, normally followed by an increase in life satisfaction (Tornstam,

1989, p.55). The Swedish psychologist described this shift as including changes at “cosmic” and “self” levels as well as in social and individual relationships. At the “cosmic” level, there are changes in the definition of time and space, increasing connection to earlier generations, new comprehension of life and death including decreased fear of death, acceptance of the mystery dimension in life and rejoicing in a range of events and experiences. At the “self” level, there is a discovery and confrontation of hidden aspects of the self - both good and bad, decreased self-centeredness, developing of body transcendence, moving from egoism to altruism (or self-transcendence), rediscovery of the child within, and realizing that the pieces of life’s jigsaw puzzle form a wholeness (ego integrity). Finally, in social and individual relationships, there is a change in the importance and meaning of relationships involving a decreased interest in superfluous relationships and increased need for solitude, a new understanding of the difference between self and roles, the addition of innocence to maturity, the understanding of the petrifying gravity of wealth and the freedom of asceticism; and the transcendence of the right-wrong duality (Tornstam, 1999, p.12). Tornstam believes that this process is generated by normal living but modified by specific cultural pattern. The movement towards gerotranscendence is continuous but can be obstructed e.g. by elements in one’s culture, or accelerated by a life crisis (Tornstam, 1999, p.11). He highlighted that the one important difference between Erikson’s 8th stage and gerotranscendence is that in the former, an individual is looking back at his/her lived life, whereas gerotranscendence implies a forward looking and outward looking view of the self and the world.

III.3.5 What is common amongst the SA, basic-virtue acquirer and gerotranscender?

Having looked at the theories of Tornstam, Maslow and Erikson, I cross-referenced the common attributes of an OA that should be well-adjusted and positively engaged with life according to these three theories in the table below:

	Tornstam	Maslow	Erikson
1.	At the “cosmic” level, there are changes in the definition of time and space, increasing connection to earlier generations, new comprehension of life and death including decreased fear of death, acceptance of the mystery dimension in life and rejoicing in a range of events and experiences	Superior perception of reality; greater freshness of appreciation, and richness of emotional reaction; has higher frequency of peak experiences; increased identification with the human species	Mature hope (faith) wisdom care
2.	At the “self” level, there is a discovery and confrontation of hidden aspects of the self - both good and bad, decreased self-centeredness, developing of body transcendence, moving from egoism	Increased acceptance (not resignation) of self, others and of nature; increased spontaneity; increased problem-centering; humility and respect;	Fidelity Wisdom Competence Humility Care Purpose

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	Tornstam	Maslow	Erikson
	to altruism, rediscovery of the child within, and realizing that the pieces of life's jigsaw puzzle form a wholeness (ego integrity)	increased identification with the human species	
3.	In social and individual relationships, there is a change in the importance and meaning of relationships involving a decreased interest in superfluous relationships and increased need for solitude, a new understanding of the difference between self and roles, the addition of innocence to maturity; and the transcendence of the right-wrong duality	Increased detachment and desire for privacy; increased autonomy, and resistance to acculturation; improved interpersonal relations; humility and respect, ethics (high moral standards), means and ends (able to clearly distinguish and appreciate them), humor and resolution of dichotomies	Will Love Humility Care Wisdom

Table 2: Summary of similar attributes described in the theories of Tornstam, Maslow and Erikson

Before proceeding further, I need to point out that my research is not seeking to validate the theories of Maslow, Erikson or Tornstam in the Singaporean context. Rather,

the attributes identified here were used to inform my research participant selection criteria alongside theologically identified criteria.

III.3.6 What is positively engaged with life from a theological perspective?

Having engaged with these three thinkers I now want to bring their work explicitly into a conversation with Christian theology. From a non-faith perspective Maslow suggests that physiological needs are the first needs that should be satisfied before all other needs. However, he pointed out that the higher needs develop on the basis of lower needs but eventually, the higher needs become independent of the lower needs. He calls this “functional autonomy” of the higher needs. He also noted that there can be reversal of the hierarchy because of habituation, when a need has been satisfied for so long that it is undervalued or when it involves “ideals, high social standards, high values etc., with such values people become martyrs”(Maslow, 1987, p.27). He also described “peak experiences” which need not be faith related, even though most spiritual experiences could fit into his description of such peak experiences. From a theological perspective, one can argue that phenomenologically what Maslow observed could be a maturing towards what might be described as a more spiritual perspective on life.

Tornstam did not associate his theory with any particular faith, instead he wrote about a “cosmic connection”. For a Christian, his/her Christian faith could provide this connection.

Finally, Erikson located his theory in psychology even though he was a Christian. Although he mentioned that trust is “the touchstone of the actuality of a given religion”, he

did not develop this further within his psychosocial theory of human development. After his passing, in adding another stage to his theory, Joan Erikson stated that faith and humility are key to facing down the despair in the last stage of life.

Hence, all three theories included spirituality/faith as important attributes amongst those who live life well. In addition, I will show that there are other attributes identified by these psychologists and sociologists that are also characteristics of those who live life to the full from a theological perspective.

Beginning with the Scripture, “¹⁰ The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy; I have come that they may have life, and have it to the full. ¹¹I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep (The Bible, John 10:10-11)”. In John 10:10, Jesus said that He has come that we may have life and have it to the full. For John, it is the self-offering of Jesus in his life and death that shows Christians how to live well (as example) but more than that, by participating in the eucharistic mystery, Christians keep Christ's sacrifice present, and so spiritually participate in his death (die daily to sin and pride, to self-centeredness and the will to power), that his life-giving love may be present amongst us (enabling us to love self, other and God). So, John 10.10 has a context: 'I have come that they may have life and have it to the full' is defined with reference to Christ - a life that follows the pattern of self-giving love; a life that is given over to the death of self-focused living through participating in Christ's death (in baptism and communion); and that exhibits the pattern and character of true love (Grayston, 1990). According to Collicutt, the transforming work of the Holy Spirit is not to change the Christian into something that she/he

is not but to enable the Christian to be truly and fully herself/himself. Because of Christ, Christians have a new relationship with God's glory and Christians themselves becomes glorious according to Paul in 2 Cor 3:18. With God doing a work of glory in them, the Christians' response should be one of joy and delight (Collicutt, 2015, pp.7–8). Further, Paul is convinced that to attain the well-being and wisdom of Christ, Christians have to participate “in the senseless confusion and pain of his Passion and death with him” (Collicutt, 2015, p.233). Hence, being a Christian does not mean that one does not experience suffering (including frailty and losses in the lead up to death) but such suffering is to be seen in the light of Christ's example. To Collicutt, the Christian's attachment to Christ begins when he/she turns to Christ and is strengthen by suffering with Him and the Christians' joy “flourish not only in good times, but even more so in adversity” because it brings them closer to Christ and “the ultimate transformation of all things” (Collicutt, 2015, p.111).

In his sermon “The Unity of the Divine Being”, John Wesley told Christians that “You are made to be happy in God”(Wesley, 1789) and quoted the Shorter Catechism's answer to the question: “For what end did God created man?” which is “to glorify and enjoy him forever”. He also stated that being happy in God is not just going to happen in heaven, it is supposed to be happening now when we are living our lives on earth, for Psalm 16:11 says that “You make known to me the path of life; you will fill me with joy in your presence, with eternal pleasures at your right hand”. This is consistent with what Bernard of Clairvaux described in his third and four degrees of love, i.e. Christians who love God for God's sake and love self for God's sake will find joy in living in accordance with God's will.

To Wesley, any religion that does not imply the giving of the heart to God is false. Christians should love God with all their hearts and their neighbours as themselves (Matt 22:37-39), hence the two key attitudes to have: “gratitude to our Creator and supreme Benefactor, and benevolence to our fellow creatures”. God-focused instead of self-focused living, is the key for Christians to live life to the full, i.e. be happy in God. This state of being happy in God allow the Christian to transcend the external circumstances that he/she finds herself as described by Paul in Philippians 4:11b-13: “for I have learned to be content whatever the circumstances. ¹² I know what it is to be in need, and I know what it is to have plenty. I have learned the secret of being content in any and every situation, whether well fed or hungry, whether living in plenty or in want. ¹³ I can do all this through him who gives me strength”.

It is important here to define the concepts of ‘happiness’ and ‘well-being’. According to the Merriam-Webster dictionary, well-being is the state of being happy, healthy or prosperous (Merriam-Webster, 2025). Being healthy and prosperous are often expressed using objective measures such as health and economic/material indicators whereas happiness is inherently subjective, and is often described by psychologists as “subjective well-being”, SWB (Diener, Napa Scollon and Lucas, 2009). Dr Ed Diener, an American psychologist noted for his three decades of research on happiness, defined SWB as one’s own evaluation of one’s life focusing on an individual’s personal feelings, emotions and satisfaction with one’s life. Absent from this definition are objective factors such as health, comfort, virtue

or wealth. Such factors are “potential influences” but “not seen as an inherent and necessary part of it” (Diener, 1984, p.543).

From a theological perspective, Wesley’s work suggests that the objective conditions of life are important – physical and economic conditions, health and family circumstances (Wesley, 1786) and yet these are not sufficient or determinative for the condition of ‘happiness’ (which he equates with holiness). The conditions of objective well-being may provide the resilience, and stability needed to pursue the God-focused life that promotes integrated discipleship but shifting from self-focused to God-focused leads to contentment that is independent from the circumstances that the Christian finds himself/herself in, i.e. whether in period of continued growth and fulfillment (e.g. third stage of life), or a time of physical and cognitive decline, dependency and frailty (such as that in the fourth age of life).

III.3.7 What are the attributes of Christians who are living life to the full?

From the above discussion, the attributes of the Christian who is having life to the full are summarised in the last column of Table 3 below. A comparison across the four columns of Table 3 shows that they are not inconsistent with those attributes that the theories of Tornstam, Maslow and Erikson predicted would enable one to live life well. Hence, I used the picture of such a Christian to develop my research participant selection criteria.

	Tornstam	Maslow	Erikson	Living life to the full in the Christian context
1.	Changed definition of time & space Increased connection to earlier generations New comprehension of life and death including decreased fear of death Acceptance of the mystery dimension in life, rejoicing in a range of events and experiences	Superior perception of reality greater freshness of appreciation & richness of emotional reaction More peak experiences; Increased identification with the human species	Mature hope (faith) wisdom care	God-focused, hence see reality including time, space and creation from a new perspective.
2.	Discover more of the self Decreased self-centeredness	Increased acceptance of self, others and of nature Increased spontaneity	Fidelity Wisdom Competence Humility Care	Moving away from self-focused, become more accepting of self and God's other

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	Tornstam	Maslow	Erikson	Living life to the full in the Christian context
	Move from egoism to altruism, Rediscover child within Realizing that the pieces of life's jigsaw puzzle form a wholeness	Increased problem-centering; Humility and respect; Increased identification with the human species	Purpose	creations, seeing self as part of God's plan, becoming more authentic and humble.
3.	Decreased interest in superfluous relationships Increase need for solitude, New understanding of difference between self and roles	Increased detachment and desire for privacy; Increased autonomy, and resistance to acculturation; Improved interpersonal relations;	Will Love Humility Care Wisdom	The love for God leading to prioritisation of relationship with God over other relationships, not being unduly influenced by others and modeling life

	Tornstam	Maslow	Erikson	Living life to the full in the Christian context
	Addition of innocence to maturity Transcendence of the right-wrong duality	Humility and respect, ethics (high moral standards), able to clearly distinguish means & ends and appreciate them humor and resolution of dichotomies		upon Jesus', His focus on God, self-offering and compassion for creation.

Table 3: Attributes of Christian having life to the full vs those identified by Tornstam, Maslow & Erikson

III.4 The criteria for selection of research participants

Based on the discussion so far, I developed my research participant criteria as follows: the potential research participants

- a. are 65 or older;
- b. are well-adjusted to life (see above discussion on the theories of Maslow, Erikson and Tornstam and “living life to the full”), for example, they are not weary of life;

VERSION_DEC 2025

- c. are able to give informed consent, and willing to talk about their life experiences and spirituality. This is an administrative requirement.
- d. self-identify as Christians and evidence this through certain activities, such as belonging to a church congregation, read or listen to the Bible for those who are not literate, praying regularly. This was derived from the above discussion of the work of Wesley and Westerhoff.
- e. show evidence of gratitude to God and benevolence to our fellow creatures. Please see discussion on the works of Bernard of Clairvaux and Wesley above. Gratitude to God and benevolence to fellow creatures could be evidenced in their behavior and speech, i.e. words that the potential participants use, or others use to describe them. Taking into account the fact that some of the OAs might not use English in their social interactions, both English and Chinese words describing gratitude and benevolence were listed in a table (see Table 4 below) and given to the center managers who were helping with the recruitment of research participants.

Attribute:	Words likely to be used to describe potential participants:	Chinese words likely to be used to describe potential participant	Words likely to be used by potential participants	Chinese words that potential participants may use
Gratitude	Thankful, appreciative, respectful, contented	感恩, 尊重他人, 知足常乐	Gratitude, thankful or grateful to God, thanksgiving, grateful for God's grace, praise God,	感恩, 感谢, 感激, 赞美主, 荣耀归于主, 蒙恩, 蒙福, 义

VERSION_DEC 2025

Attribute:	Words likely to be used to describe potential participants:	Chinese words likely to be used to describe potential participant	Words likely to be used by potential participants	Chinese words that potential participants may use
			honouring God, appreciate, indebted, respect, respectful, contented, satisfied, God's grace is sufficient for me, blessed.	务，尊敬，知足，满足，上帝的恩典够我用的，上帝保佑
Benevolence	Kind, kindhearted, loving, bighearted, openhearted, generous, good, humane, humble, altruistic, caring, interested in other people's welfare, thinking of others' feelings and needs, considerate, compassionate, walks in other's shoes, sympathetic, gracious, noble, selfless, unselfish, forgiving, forbearing,	善良，有爱心，有大爱，慷慨，和蔼，仁慈，无私，会体谅，为人着想，体贴，富有同情心，关怀他人，有同情心，有高尚情怀，	Need for: love, kindness, kindheartedness, bighearted, openhearted, generosity, goodness. Being humane, altruistic, caring, interested in other people's welfare, thinking of others' feelings and needs, considerate, compassionate, walking in other's shoes, sympathetic, gracious, noble, selfless, unselfish. To forgive, forbear, be magnanimous, be patient, charitable, merciful	仁慈，仁爱，善良，大爱，慷慨，大方，和蔼，无私，体谅别人，为人着想，关爱，体贴，富有同情心，和蔼，关怀，同情，耐心

VERSION_DEC 2025

Attribute:	Words likely to be used to describe potential participants:	Chinese words likely to be used to describe potential participant	Words likely to be used by potential participants	Chinese words that potential participants may use
	magnanimous, charitable, merciful			

Table 4: English and Chinese words describing gratitude and benevolence

III.5 Conclusion

In this chapter, I have defined the concepts that underpin my research. These concepts enabled me to be clear about what I am looking for in selecting and interviewing research participants. Old age was defined to be consistent with the definition used by the local government departments and researchers, and Christian spirituality was defined using the theories of Bernard of Clairvaux, Wesley and Westerhoff. Next, after comparing the attributes of those whom theories of Maslow, Erikson and Tornstam predicted should be well-adjusted to life against those of Christians living life to the full according to Bernard of Clairvaux and John Wesley, I was comfortable to use these two theologians' theories to identify those who are positively engaged with life to participate in this project. In the next chapter, the research methodology including the research methods are described.

IV. Chapter four - Research Methodology

This chapter gives the rationale for the research methodology, and research method chosen for this project. Key challenges encountered and ethical considerations are also discussed here.

IV.1 Selecting an appropriate research methodology

IV.1.1 Impact of my worldview on the selection process

As a Christian, I believe that God created all and declared that creation was good per Gen 1:31 “God saw all that he had made, and it was very good...”(The Holy Bible, 1984). Although we are made in the image of God (Gen 1:27 So God created mankind in his own image), each is fearfully and wonderfully made (Psalm 139:14), i.e. each one of us is custom-made. Each individual is unique and deserves to be studied as such. This is aptly expressed by Gerkin in his book on human beings as living human document: “each individual living document has an integrity of his or her own that calls for understanding and interpretation, not categorization and stereotyping” (Gerkin, 1984, p.38). Statistics from a quantitative methodology can be used to provide a general overview of the state of affairs and I would use them for that purpose, but I do not think they represent a person well and is not appropriate for a research project to understand the spirituality of OAs.

Further, since God created everything and human beings are made in the image of God (Gen 1:27), it should be possible to learn more about the living God and His purpose through them - just as we can learn about Him through the life stories, occurrences etc. in the Bible (Bennett et al., 2018, p.30). Knowledge is gained through experiences, both my own and those of others – in life experiences, observations of creation, innovations, analyses,

reflections etc. and experiences are best understood if they are studied in context. To be contextual, it is necessary to understand the experiences shared by the OAs through their interpretive framework and be mindful of how my own interpretative framework impacts my understanding of their experiences. Hence, between qualitative and quantitative research methodology, my personal preference is the former but I arrived at the final decision to use a qualitative methodology because of the purpose of this research project.

IV.1.2 Reasons for a qualitative methodological approach for this project

My purpose of carrying out this research project is to gain insight to the relationship between the spirituality of OAs and their experience of old age. I seek more to understand and not so much to explain. Bearing in mind this purpose, the research question and assumptions, I concluded that the most appropriate research methodology for this project is a flexible or qualitative research design.

Fixed or quantitative research designs usually involve the use of aggregates and working with group properties and general tendencies. They are theory-driven and usually designed to avoid any “experimenter effect” (Robson, 2002, p.98). My research was a small-scale project which did not involve the use of aggregates or trends. It was not undertaken to prove or disprove a particular hypothesis. For this project, I was not using a well-developed theory with identified variables that could be used to design procedures and create a somewhat controlled environment to test these variables. As a practical theologian working with OAs to understand their spirituality and its role in their lives, I needed a research design that would enable me to work closely with the research participants instead of being a

“detached” researcher. That would mean taking account of my own role in the research as a research-practitioner, but there was not enough information to design a fixed/quantitative research plan that could isolate the “experimenter effect”. Instead, by using a flexible/qualitative research approach, intentional practices of reflexivity could be relied on to manage the effects of any researcher bias.

A flexible research design allows for an evolving design, the presentation of multiple perspectives, the use of the researcher as an instrument of data collection and a focus on the participants’ views. It is just as rigorous as a fixed research design, uses combination of methods for data collection and the data collected can be analysed at different levels of abstraction (Robson, 2002, p.166). The findings can be reported as narratives which reflect the realities of life more accurately than averages or trends.

The flexible research methodological framework that I chose is Interpretative Phenomenological Analysis (IPA). The primary goal of IPA research is to investigate how individuals make sense of their experiences (Pietkiewicz, 2012). It is based on phenomenology, pioneered by Husserl and further developed by Heidegger, Merleau-Ponty and Sartre (Smith, Flowers and Larkin, 2009). It synthesises ideas from phenomenology and hermeneutics to produce a methodology that is both descriptive and interpretative.

According to Larkin and Thompson (2011, p.102), “IPA has an interpretative phenomenological epistemology....It assumes that understanding the world requires understanding of experiences” and the research participants are always “immersed in a linguistic, relational, cultural and physical world...therefore the IPA researcher needs to take

an idiographic approach...to facilitate a detailed focus on the particular”. There is a dual interpretation process because research participant makes sense of his/her experience and then the IPA researcher tries to decode that meaning, i.e. makes sense of the participant’s meaning-making. To make sense of the others’ experiences, the IPA researcher needs to be able to identify and reflect on her own experiences and assumptions. The final assumption is that researchers “cannot escape interpretation at any stage but can reflect on their role in producing those interpretations and maintain a commitment to ground them in the research participants’ views” (Larkin and Thompson, 2011, p.103). These assumptions are reasonable and useful and I tried to keep them in mind throughout the research project.

The main concern of IPA is to give full appreciation of each research participant’s account as IPA studies have small sample sizes and usually involve verbatim transcripts of first-person accounts that have been generated by a particular research participant. This fitted my intention of giving full attention to each of my research participants so that I could understand their context and the experiences they share as well as I could.

Smith, Flowers and Larkin (2009) identified six steps in using IPA. The first step involves reading and re-reading the transcript of the interview to enter into the research participant’s world. This allows the researcher to construct an overall structure of the interview and discern any patterns e.g. from generic to specifics as rapport between the researcher and the participant is built up during the interview. The second step, initial noting, is where the researcher maintains an open mind and writes any explanatory notes or comments as she reads the transcript, examining the semantic content and language used.

Developing from such descriptive comments that stay close to the participant's explicit meaning, the researcher is also expected to do more interpretative noting to understand how and why the participant may have certain concerns. The authors wrote that "it is important to engage in analytic dialogue with each line of transcript, asking questions of what the word, phrase, sentence means to the researcher and attempting to check what it means to the participant" (Smith, Flowers and Larkin, 2009, p.84). The third step of developing emergent themes involves working primarily with the initial notes after having a very familiar model of the interview. The narrative flow of the interview is broken and discrete parts of the transcript are used to support the identified themes. This step of the analysis involves more of the researcher in the sense that the research participant provided the original words to support the themes, but the interpretation belongs to the analyst. The fourth step involves searching for connections across emergent themes. The emergent themes are mapped according to how the analyst thinks they fit together bearing in mind the research question. This is where super-ordinate themes emerge. The fifth step is to move to the next case, treating it like it is the first and allowing new themes to emerge. This is in line with the idiographic commitment of IPA. The sixth and last step is to look for patterns across cases. This is done with the help of a master table of themes for the research project. This comparison would lead to reconfiguration or relabeling of the themes. It could also help the analysis move to a more theoretical level if it is recognized that themes that is particular to an individual case are also shared by other cases.

From the above description, one can see that the IPA methodology calls for a meticulous, rigorous and time-consuming research process. Although it was developed for use in research in psychology, I believe that it is a research methodology that is suitable for my interdisciplinary project, capable of producing insightful and rich accounts of the research participants' experiences that would give insight into their spirituality and how it supported them in old age.

IV.2 The research method

My research question is “What is the spirituality of Christian Chinese-Singaporean older adults who are positively engaged with life?” The question is open and exploratory as I seek to understand their relationship with God, the experiences that shaped their spirituality, their meanings of such experiences, their responses to such meanings and the effects, if any, on their experience of old age.

The research participants were selected purposively, i.e. six OAs who met the selection criteria (see section III.4). According to Smith, Flowers and Larkin (2009, p.51), many studies by experienced IPA researchers have sample sizes in the range of three to six. Hence, a sample size of six should be enough to provide for the development of meaningful points of difference and similarity among them and not generate too much data to jeopardize IPA's commitment to good qualitative research work.

The six research participants are 65 years or older Singaporeans who are community dwelling and not in institutions such as nursing homes or homes for the aged. The chronological age of 65 was used as the minimum age because it is the most commonly used age for defining

OAs in Singapore, making it easier to compare this research results against other local research results. One reason for selecting community dwelling OAs was because the research participants needed to be healthy enough to attend a one-to-one interview session lasting at least an hour. The other reason is because I work with such community-dwelling OAs in my practice.

The research participants were supposed to be invited from the various eldercare centers that I worked with and the center managers had agreed to be my gatekeepers to ensure that my interaction with the research participants were respectful and cordial. However, this process was disrupted by the Covid-19 pandemic where the government ordered all the eldercare facilities for community-dwelling OAs to be closed. In the end, one of the center managers helped me recruit those OAs that volunteered at her center instead of the center attendees. These volunteers met my selection criteria but they were all Chinese. This is not surprising because 85.4% of the local Christian population is Chinese according to the 2020 population census(Department of Statistics Singapore, 2021). With such a sample, ethnicity is clearly not a research variable and my research question was modified to reflect this.

During the recruitment process, potential participants were given information on the research project including the research method, i.e. interviews, the time commitment, the discussion topic, the proposed interview dates and the type of protection that would be accorded to the data that they shared. Only those OAs who could and were prepared to sign written consent forms were invited to participate in the project. They were prepared to talk about their understanding of spirituality, those experiences that they considered spiritual and how such experiences had impacted them and their outlook to life. Their gender and ethnicity were not of

concern to me initially since I was not looking for a sample that was representative of Singapore's Christian population. Post my annual review with the university review board, the ratio of male to female participants was changed to 1:2 so that there was more male participants in my sample.

To have rich, first-person, detailed accounts of the research participants' experiences, given my lack of experience with groups, I chose one-to-one in-depth interviews as my data collection method although some IPA research projects were done with focus groups. In the one-to-one interviews, I was able to give full attention to each research participant and had more reaction time for good quality interaction with him/her.

Being new to the IPA methodology, I used semi-structured interviews so I had a list of questions (see Annex A) to remind me of the topics that should be covered, but also had room for the research participants to explore areas that I had not thought of. The questions related mainly to experiences that had given them meaning and purpose in life, important relationships especially their relationship with God and how they felt those experiences had impacted how they perceived and lived their lives etc. The questions were open-ended, and their use subjected to the pace and the flow of the conversation. As the research focus was on the spirituality of the participants, the discussions were intimate and sensitive at times. Respect for the participants overrode the interview schedules. Effects of the interview on the participant were monitored, including non-verbal cues and the interview pace was adjusted to take them into account. The sequence of the questions and number of questions asked were also adjusted as the interviews progressed. The target time of the interview was one and a half hour and I tried to cap it to the maximum of two hours, but it was difficult at times to interrupt the flow of the participant's thoughts and feelings

without appearing abrupt. Hence, some of the interviews went beyond two hours. The research participants were never rushed and could pause for as long as they wanted. Their requests for deletion of parts of what they had said were also discussed to find out their concerns and deleted unless they felt comfortable about retaining those parts after such discussions.

Two pilot interviews were conducted with my friends so that the interview questions could be tested and amended before using them with the selected research participants. These interviews and transcripts were used to review the interview schedule and strategy so that improvements were made before conducting the actual research interviews.

During the interviews, I tried to take some notes but realised that it was not possible as I needed to be attentive otherwise I was unable to follow the conversation. Hence, I relied mainly on the voice recordings of the interviews. I had requested for a follow-up interview with each participant but realized that it was not necessary as the original interviews were already very rich.

IV.3 Language considerations

In Singapore, most OAs are likely to be more comfortable in their mother tongues than English because most of them would have picked up English only when they entered school or the workforce. According to government statistics, the group of local OAs who were my potential participants have, on average, 4.7 years of education (Department of Statistics Singapore, 2019, p.vi). As such, the research participants were asked beforehand if they were comfortable to be interviewed in English. One of the participants preferred not to be interviewed in English, so her interview was conducted in Mandarin. For that one interview, the transcript was translated into English before analysis.

Another issue that I foresaw, based on my interaction with local OAs was that, even those who were fluent in English switched to their mother tongues during conversations when they could not readily find the English words or phrases that could describe the meanings that they wanted to convey. For instance, many used idioms in their mother tongues or colloquial phrases such as those in Singlish. This is could be because they felt that certain nuances their dialects or Singlish convey would be lost when translated into English, or even Mandarin. Unfortunately, both interpretation and translation involve an element of interpretation and some analysis by the interpreter/translator. As such, in the English transcripts, both the words or phrases in their original language/dialects and their translations were shown. In this paper, key phrases or words quoted are included in their original language/dialects as well as their translations into English to inform the readers of this additional process (Marshall and Rossman, 2010, p.166). A copy of the interview transcripts were also offered to the respective research participants for feedback to help correct any errors in the transcripts.

IV.4 Ethical considerations

My key ethical consideration is to maintain the appropriate attitude throughout this research project, i.e. not to impose or be seen to impose my beliefs on my research participants either during the interview or when analysing the transcripts. This awareness was always at the back of my mind throughout this project. My research participants are OAs and they are a vulnerable group. For example, they are more likely to suffer from some form of health impairments as compared to young adults e.g. hard of hearing, being forgetful at times, or tires easily. As such, they could be bullied or deceived into acting to their detriment or giving up their

rights etc. There could also be rights that they are unaware of because they are not legal literate or have not been keeping themselves up to date. For instance, they may not be aware of their rights under newer legislations such as the Personal Data Protection Act (PDPA) in Singapore. As a researcher it is my personal responsibility to protect my research participants and not abuse their trust. One safeguard in place was the center manager since I recruited my research participants through her.

During the recruitment of research participants, I also explained my research project, the information that I would be gathering from them and the time commitment. They were encouraged to ask questions before committing to the project. Informed consent was sought from each participant respectfully, and their consent were all in written form so they could read what they were consenting to. The informed consent form included consent: to participate in the project; to report illegal activities, for instance, if there were clear signs of elder abuse; to do a voice recording of our interviews; and to allow parts of the information that they shared to be made public, for example, verbatim extracts published in journals or presentation at conferences. Their privacy were protected through the shield of anonymity, i.e. their names were replaced with pseudonyms, i.e. research participants A, B etc. Even with such consent, I will not publish such information if it is so unique that the research participant can be readily identified. The research participants were informed that they could withdraw from the research project any time during the data collection phase if they felt uncomfortable. This right to withdraw is time limited though, i.e. within one month of the interview (Smith, Flowers and Larkin, 2009). Before signing the written consent, the form was explained and the research participant were reminded that if there were

illegal activities shared e.g. elder abuse, my supervisor would be consulted and if necessary, legal advice would be sought. I also shared with the research participants, where appropriate, some resources available to Singapore OAs for support, for example, they could turn to the Hua Mei Center for Successful Ageing at Tsao Foundation for geriatric help (<https://tsaofoundation.org/what-we-do/services-programmes/about-hmcsa>) and to the Faith Methodist Church's lay counseling team (<https://www.faithmc.sg/counselling>) for free counselling services.

My basic tenet in working with the researcher participants is to treat them the way I would like to be treated, as written in Matthew 7: 12 "So in everything, do to others what you would have them do to you.." and Matt 22:39 "...love your neighbor as yourself".

IV.5 Conclusion

IPA was chosen for this research project because it was the best fit with the purpose of this research. Further, one-on-one semi-structured interviews were used to allow the participants to fully describe their experiences and meanings. The participant selection criteria was developed after comparing different theories to ensure that participants selected were appropriate. However, all considerations taken to prepare for the research project did not take into account the Covid-19 pandemic which demanded significant changes to be made for the project to continue. These are documented in the next chapter on the recruitment and data gathering process.

V. Chapter five – Recruitment and Data Gathering Process

This chapter describes how I recruited participants and gathered data for this project during the Covid-19 pandemic. Changes were made to the intended process in order to continue with the research project despite the strict restrictions imposed by the Singapore government during the pandemic. The data gathering and coding processes were also described in this chapter.

V.1 Identification and recruitment of research participants

After having developed the criteria for the selection of research participants, the two center managers who had agreed to help with the identification of such candidates were contacted. Unfortunately, due to the Covid-19 pandemic in early 2020, both centers were told to stop operations because they were classified as “high risk” locations. The centers served OAs who generally have weaker immunity systems and were more vulnerable to diseases than the general population. During the initial stage of the Covid-19 pandemic, there were no vaccinations against this group of viruses hence all eldercare centers were shut down until further notice. At that point, no one was able to predict when the centers would re-open. As there was a lot of uncertainty, I had to wait while the centers worked out the plans for their operations.

After a few months, I managed to discuss my stalled project with one of center managers and we agreed that based on the selection criteria, the volunteers at the center were also potential research participants. By then the Covid-19 restrictions were not as stringent and she agreed to help identify some of them for my project. She subsequently identified three volunteers and arranged for me to meet two of them at her center. Meeting them one by one, I explained my research project to them and took the opportunity to assess their suitability for my project. They

were both warm and affable based on this first contact. For the one-to-one interview, I arranged to meet them individually at a place of their choice.

I did not meet the third potential candidate physically for pre-selection but called him instead. I have seen him at the center previously since he was a very active volunteer and was there most weekends. Based on my past observations and our tele-conversation, I invited him to consider becoming one of my research participants. He readily agreed and chose to be interviewed at his home. Having decided that volunteers at the center were potential research candidates, I approached another volunteer at the center who was also a fellow befriender in my church. Based on our past interactions, I believed she would meet the selection criteria to be a research participant. I contacted her and explained my research. Despite her busy schedule, she agreed to be interviewed but preferred to do so via a video call.

After interviewing these first four participants, the sample size was increased from four to six to have more data to work with. The last two research participants were also volunteers from the same center that the first four research participants volunteered at. I spoke to both over the phone to assess their suitability and both agreed to participate when I invited them. In total, there were six research participants aged between 66 and 86 years old. Four of them were women and the other two men. All were ethnic Chinese.

V.2 The interview process

V.2.1 Interview with participant A

Participant A was an 82-year-old lady who had a pleasant and warm disposition. As we were amid a pandemic, there were Covid-19 restrictions on physical meetings so I

VERSION_DEC 2025

could not book any meeting rooms. Participant A suggested that we meet at a hawker center next to the block of public housing flats that she was staying at. She preferred a physical meeting even though I offered to interview her via a video call as a physical meeting increased her risk of being infected by Covid-19, especially since she had chosen a public place to meet. During the interview, she was patient and keen to share. She was at times animated, aggrieved or tickled by the events that she described during the interview. She was very tolerant of all the interruptions as the hawker center was being fumigated. Even though she might be complaining during sections of our interview, despite some of the words used, she spoke in an even, soft but not resigned tone. She has a sense of humour, laughed frequently but also had a sense of calmness about her.

V.2.2 Interview with participant B

Participant B was a 75-year-old gentleman who speaks with a slight mumble and at times, a slur but overall in an audible tone. He lives in a public housing flat with his wife who had gone to the market during my visit. Participant B has a kind disposition and was keen to contribute to local research on Christian OAs. Hence, even though conversation was difficult for him because of his hearing problem in one ear, he was very patient and asked me politely to repeat my questions when he could not hear them. He was calm, gentle and patient throughout the interview, beaming when he talked about his family.

V.2.3 Interview with participant C

Participant C was a 78-year-old lady who showed a whole range of emotions during our interview – from laughing heartily to tearing quietly. She lived alone in a public housing

flat after her husband's death but her children visited her regularly. As her flat was along the corridor, there was shouting and screaming from her neighbour's child who kept coming to her door during the interview. She was very tolerant of such behaviour.

Participant C was expressive and had a playful streak in her that showed up during parts of our interview when she laughed a girlish laughter. She teared up during our interview as she spoke about her late husband. I was conscious that her crying had triggered "the counsellor" in me, so I tried to stay in my "researcher" role and avoided flipflopping between the two roles. As I did not want to put her through undue pain when she narrated her experiences, I used some counselling techniques to affirm her. I believe I managed to strike a balance between allowing her to share her experience and not triggering more anguish. I did not want my data gathering to leave participant C with any negative effects. At the end of the interview, she was composed and appeared to be glad that she had agreed to my interview.

V.2.4 Interview with participant D

Participant D was a 68-year-old lady who preferred to be interviewed through a video call. I understood her choice since we were in the middle of a pandemic and was grateful that she took time out from looking after her young grandchildren to participate in my project.

She was interviewed in Mandarin, her language of choice even though she used Hokkien (a Chinese dialect) and English phrases during our conversation. Participant D was lively and expressive as she narrated her life experiences. She had been looking after her

half-brother before he passed away a few months earlier and she was sad that he was not a Christian when he died. She was also taking turns with her siblings to look after her mother who was suffering from dementia. Participant D's relationship with her mother had been a difficult one, especially after she became a Christian in her early teens. She had just completed a week of taking care of her mother and commented that it had been very stressful. Notwithstanding, she appeared to be very energetic during most of the interview and spoke at a rapid pace, laughing heartily at times. Besides caring for her mother, participant D also helped to look after her maternal and paternal grandchildren whenever her children were busy. Despite this busy workload, she volunteered whenever she could in the activities organized by her church.

V.2.5 Interview with participant E

Participant E is the youngest of the six interviewees at 66 years old. He was a missionary in another Asian country at the time of our interview, having retired from his managerial job in Singapore. He was the only research participant with tertiary education, higher than the other participants. The interview was conducted via video call using Whatsapp since he was outside Singapore.

Research participant E was a cautious person. Although he answered my questions readily, there were two parts of the interview where he asked to be deleted. The first part related to information that he shared but was worried that it might be politically sensitive. That part of the conversation was deleted to avoid any potential impact on his mission work.

He agreed to retain the second part when he realised that his identity would be kept anonymous, hence whoever he mentioned would remain anonymous too.

V.2.6 Interview with participant F

Participant F was the oldest of my interviewees, at 86 years old. The interview was conducted in her home. She agreed to be interviewed at her home but forgot our appointment on the day of our interview. When I called her at the bottom of her block, she was at a medical clinic waiting to collect her medication. I assured her that it was fine, and I could fetch her from the clinic. I waited for her to collect her medicines and then gave her a lift home. Later during our interview, she commented on this and felt that her mistake had turned into a blessing from God, i.e. sending someone to fetch her home so that she can avoid taking the public bus and then walking home alone.

She was a jovial person who laughed a lot and was a great host. She was the only interviewee with a domestic helper, but she wanted to be as independent as she could. For example, she went to the medical clinic alone despite her children telling her that she should go with the domestic helper whom they have employed to look after her. Although her movement was a bit slow, she did not appear tired after our interview but looked like she had enjoyed it. This interview was the longest of the six interviews because she had a lot to share and showed me her artwork in the middle of the interview.

V.3 Transcribing the interviews

V.3.1 The transcription process

I tried using auto-transcription software, i.e. “Descript” and “Express Scribe” to transcribe the recorded interviews but the accuracy rate was low. There were several reasons for this: the accents of the research participants; the use of multiple languages and dialects in the same recording; there were also background noises in some of the recordings; variations in the volume of parts of the recordings as the participants leaned forward or moved away from the voice recorder; and the fast pace at which some participants spoke. The lowest automatic transcription rate came from the interview conducted in Mandarin because our heavily accented local Mandarin was not readily understood by software developed using standard Mandarin.

Consequently, all the interview recordings were transcribed manually. When manually transcribed, I could transcribe close to 100% of the conversations except for a few words where loud external noises, such as clanking pots/pans at the hawker centre, obscured the voices in the recordings. The manual transcription was done with the help of the “oTranscribe” application as it allowed me to slow down the recordings.

V.3.2 Confirmation of the transcripts

After the transcriptions, I contacted the interviewees to give them a copy of their interview transcripts for their review. Participants B and F were comfortable not to review the transcripts when I contacted them. I printed and delivered the interview transcripts to participants A and C, and emailed a copy of participant E’s interview transcript to him since

he was overseas. They acknowledged receipt of the transcripts and allowed me to proceed to the next stage of the project. All three agreed to contact me if there were amendments, but none of them contacted me to make any amendments. For participant D, I gave her a copy of the transcript in Chinese. She asked for a few days to read it. After that, she agreed that I could proceed to translate it into English for the next phase of my project.

V.3.3 Translation of the Chinese transcript

Before translating the Chinese transcript, I had anticipated that there would be Chinese or dialect phrases that I might not be able to translate into English without losing some of their meanings. Even the English words used by my research participants might not have the same meaning as their meaning in standard English dictionaries because of how they were used in the local context. Translating from the colloquial Mandarin and dialects into English was even more challenging. Using a translation software yielded many sentences that had very different meanings from what participant D meant. So, I did the translation of the Chinese text into English manually. It was a very interesting process as it made me recollect my mother tongue, Hokkien and the dialects from my childhood including Teochew and Cantonese.

V.4 Coding the transcripts

V.4.1 The coding methodology chosen

The coding method chosen for this research is in vivo coding because it allows the participants to speak for themselves, i.e. using the terms used by the participants (Saldaña, 2016, p.105). As mentioned earlier, I had expected the research participants to speak in a

mixture of languages and dialects, switching between them to use the phrases that they believe best expressed themselves. In vivo coding allowed me to capture those phrases in my codes. Besides this, I hoped to “prioritise and honor the participants’ voice” (Saldaña, 2016, p.106) by using the words of the participants as much as possible.

The other coding method that I used was concept coding as it “extracts and labels big picture ideas suggested by the data (Saldaña, 2016, p.97). This method allowed me to capture ideas that were implied but not specifically stated by the participants.

V.4.2 The coding process

When I first started coding, I tried to code the transcripts manually with the aid of Excel spreadsheets. As I coded each subsequent transcript, I realised that some of my initial codes had to be changed or refined. Such changes required a re-coding of those transcripts that had already been coded earlier. I also noted that I had misunderstood some of the replies given during the interviews so did not follow-up on some points that the participants had brought up. This was due to my lack of experience in conducting one-to-one interviews and I hope to do better in subsequent research projects when I use interviewing as a research method again. However, a bigger problem that I discovered was that manually changing the codes for each transcript was a very labour-intensive process. There was also a risk of inconsistencies in the codes and how they were referenced. After struggling with the spreadsheets in vain, I decided to use the software, Nvivo. I found that once I had populated the data and codes in the software, it was easy to make changes to the codes or to add new data. There were also standard NVivo reports that I could generate easily, for example, the

report to generate frequently used words. Please see the sample page from the codebook Nvivo generated for my project in the table below.

Name	Description	Files	References
Disposition	Nature and character of the participants	6	430
1.At peace		6	29
2.Caring		6	57
2.1 Caring for others		6	33
2.2 Compassionate		3	11
2.3 Encouraging others		3	4
2.4 Love for creation		3	9
3.Concern for future generations		3	16
4.Empathic		3	14
5.Fear of becoming bedridden		1	10
6.Fear of God		1	5
7.Feeling blessed		6	44
8.Feeling thankful or grateful		6	94
9.Feeling useful		1	17
10.Happy		6	36
11.No fear of aging or death		6	63
12.No fear of illnesses and pain		3	6
13.Not fearful or anxious		3	5
14.Not of this world		4	13
15.Obedient to God		4	6
16.Reflective		3	6

VERSION_DEC 2025

Name	Description	Files	References
17.Respecting others regardless of faith		2	9

Table 5: Sample page of the NVivo codebook generated by NVivo 12

Referring to Table 5 above, column one row two shows that “Disposition” was a code that I had used. The second column shows the description of this code. The interview transcripts were imported into NVivo as “files”, so the third column shows the number of “files” or transcripts that had “Disposition” as a code. The “References” column indicated the total number of references that were coded to a particular code. Reading the first column of Table 5, one can see that the code “Disposition” has 17 child codes and four grandchild codes, i.e. 2.1 to 2.4. There is a number “6” in the column three row two field indicating that all six transcripts had references to the parent code “Disposition”, and the total number of such references was 430. With NVivo, I could code more intuitively instead of overthinking which codes to use and tainting the process with any preconceived ideas. This is because when using spreadsheets, I had to be very careful in choosing codes as changing them subsequently would result in a lot of work. In NVivo, it was also easy to create a “parent” on top of any code and to move codes across such “parent” codes, so re-categorising was made easier. The software also allowed me to choose if I wanted to “aggregate” the references from the “child” codes up to the “parent” code.

NVivo had a dashboard that allowed all codes to be displayed as I coded. This was a good feature as it provided an overview of all codes created, but it created a problem for

me. I discovered that I have an “obsessive-compulsive” trait that compelled me to try to find references for all the codes that I have already created in subsequent transcripts that I was coding. This way of coding might seem comprehensive, but it was restrictive for me. There were instances where I felt that I was trying to fit a square peg into a round hole, i.e. trying to find references to fit a code when such references did not exist in that transcript. When I detected this problem, I did another round of coding using Word tables where I could not see all the codes that have already been created.

A significant amount of time was spent in the coding phase, but it was worth the effort because the various rounds of coding helped me to understand each transcript better and made the analysis easier. I also had the satisfaction of finding a solution to my “obsessive-compulsiveness” when it created a problem in my work. I found that the combination of NVivo and Word tables worked well because I used NVivo mainly as a database while the Word tables were used to do the analysis. For example, when I needed to perform searches across transcripts, NVivo was very efficient. However, there is an administrative problem with NVivo, i.e. the product key must be renewed annually by the university. The new key can only be replaced when the old key has expired. There were years when the new key purchased was for a newer version of NVivo so that the existing NVivo installed on my machine could not accept the new product key and I had no access to the data uploaded into NVivo unless I upgrade to the new version. Unfortunately, there were significant differences between versions. Thus far, the product key changes in the last two years have created heart-stopping moments for me as I had to learn how to use the

features in a newer version of NVivo in order to access my referenced data even though I have already completed my analysis phase.

V.5 Recording the impact of the Covid-19 pandemic

The first case of Covid-19 was detected in Singapore on 23 Jan 2020 and first set of “circuit breaker” restrictions, i.e. was imposed from 7 Apr to 4 May which included shutting down all non-essential workplaces including eldercare centers, schools etc. Both private and public gatherings were not allowed. These restrictions were extended to 1 Jun 2020, then there were progressive loosening of the restrictions until Covid-19 vaccinations became available from 30 Dec 2020. Life returned almost to normal after most of the population was vaccinated and most restrictions were lifted on 26 Apr 2022 (Goh, 2022). During circuit-breaker periods, there was much fear as there was insufficient information about Covid-19 and deaths were reported every day in the media. To capture the impact of Covid-19 on the research participants, I decided to add two questions about the pandemic to my list of interview questions (see Annex A).

V.6 Conclusion

Due to the Covid-19 restrictions which shut down all the eldercare centers, the participants who were recruited for this project were all OAs that had volunteered at one of the eldercare centers that had agreed to participate in this research instead of its programme participants. Four research participants were interviewed in person and two through video calls. All transcripts were prepared manually including the Chinese transcript that required translation. In vivo and concept coding were used to code the transcripts. A variety of software were used to do the coding, i.e. Excel spreadsheets, the software NVivo and Word tables. The data gathering and coding process took

VERSION_DEC 2025

much longer than normal because of the pandemic and my long learning curve but it was worth the time and effort put in because I learnt more about myself and the research findings were enlightening. These are described in the next chapter.

VI. Chapter six – Findings

This chapter explains the themes arising from the coding process and how they were identified. It explains the process of coding and categorizing with examples to illustrate the process; as well as the categories and the patterns or themes that emerged.

VI.1 Details about coding the transcripts

Several rounds of coding were done on the six interview transcripts, each with a different focus. During the first round of coding, each transcript was read to code the participant's faith journey – starting from their family of origin, introduction to Christianity, conversion, and finally their current state of spirituality. In vivo quotes explaining the context of each of their research participant were extracted and coded. As the impact of Covid-19 was an area of special research, direct quotes were extracted to evidence the participants' interpretation of this phenomenon. This first attempt generated a lot of codes, but the coding, re-coding and generation of several code structures gave me a better understanding of the historical and current context of the participants.

The next round of coding was focused on capturing each participant's understanding what being a Christian meant to them and how it had impacted their engagement with life. In vivo and concept coding (Saldaña, 2016, p.97) were done. Spreadsheets were used in the first round and NVivo was used in both rounds of coding.

A third round of coding was done using only Microsoft WORD tables. The intention was to look anew at the transcripts to learn as much as possible about the participants and ensure the codes produced were as consistent as possible with the participants' meaning. The WORD tables originally consisted of three columns including

VERSION_DEC 2025

- Direct quotes from the transcripts;
- Exploratory comments (including descriptive, linguistic and concept comments); and
- Emergent themes.

They were modelled after the table in Jonathan Smith's book on IPA (Smith, Flowers and Larkin, 2009, p.84). Smith is the main author who introduced the IPA research methodology.

However, while analysing the transcripts, I realised that using the tables as they were, made me to jump from codes to emergent themes without explaining the process. Hence, I modified the tables so that the last column was changed from "Emergent themes" to "Categories". Saldaña (2016, pp.10) had called this transition from coding to categorising "synthesis", i.e. the move towards consolidated meaning. Given the large number of codes generated, consolidating the codes into categories according to their meanings, made it easy for me to see any patterns emerging amongst the categories, something which was easier than looking for patterns amongst codes. These patterns can then be analysed to see if they occurred across transcripts, i.e. if they are group themes. An example of these working tables is presented in section VI.3 which explains the actual coding and categorising process.

VI.2 Background information on the research participants

Before explaining the categorisation process, key background information on the six research participants are included here to aid in understanding the context of the research participants when examples from their transcripts are used later in this paper.

VI.2.1 Participant A

Participant A was born in Johore Bahru (JB), a city in the Malaysian State that is closest to Singapore, to a wealthy Chinese Christian family. She was the only second-generation Christian among the six research participants and she proudly proclaimed that “down the line, every generation that I looked there is either a pastor or missionary”. Unfortunately, during World War II (WWII), her father was taken away by the Japanese when he tried to retrieve the body of her grandfather who had been shot by the invading force. Her mother inherited a large part of her father’s legacy but could not get along with participant A’s paternal grandmother.

Participant A’s mother returned to her hometown in Singapore with her son and four daughters. She was then cheated of most of her husband’s legacy and felt that she could no longer bring up her five children. Participant A’s brother was returned to their grandmother because participant A said her grandmother “wanted” him. As the son of her eldest boy, there was a plot of land in JB, their hometown for him to inherit, but she did not want the four granddaughters. So, participant A’s mother sent participant A and her sisters to a welfare home which is in another Malaysian state, Malacca. Subsequently, the girls encountered “some unpleasantness” in the home and one of participant A’s sister “got sick”, so the girls returned to their mother in Singapore. They stayed with their mother in her rented room but had to find food for themselves during the day. The girls picked up vegetables from the nearby wet market to cook in the communal kitchen. Participant A described the poor relations among the neighbours renting rooms in the building: “If the

neighbour doesn't like you, whatever you're boiling, they just smash it. Then... you cannot complain, you just have to live together like that". The girls were also expected to support themselves and their brother "when we grew up, we have to, give him the money. My mom have to take money from us. How we earn and what we do, huh, it's our own. The girls, just have to fend for ourselves".

Throughout her struggles to survive, participant A held on to her Christian faith. She said she "floated" from church to church, attending their Sunday services until she joined a newly founded church in 1966. She has been with the same church and a volunteer in its various outreach programmes since its founding days.

VI.2.2 Participant B

Participant B was born near the end of WWII in a Singaporean Chinese family and had a secondary school education. As a teenager, one of his secondary school teachers took him to Sunday service but he did not become a Christian until "at the age of 38, my brother brought me to Christ". His brother studied theology and was involved in mission work in the Philippines. Participant B said that he was a "strong Buddhist" before he became a Christian and he participated in local religious rites and festivals such as the Hungry Ghost festival. These practices are not the typical practices of canonical Buddhists, i.e. Buddhists that followed the teachings of the two main schools of Buddhism in Singapore, namely Theravada and Mahayana Buddhism. What participant B had described were practices of the main Chinese folk religion in Singapore, Shenism.

Among local Chinese OAs, the term “Buddhism” often refers to “the Chinese syncretic religions practised in Singapore” as pointed out by the local anthropologist, Vivienne Wee, an associate faculty of the Singapore University of Social Sciences. Wee also wrote that “of the Chinese syncretic religions, the one most frequently encountered is Shenism. In fact, one may even say that the majority of Singaporeans who call themselves ‘Buddhists’ are in fact Shenist” (Wee, 1976, p.169,170). Shenism is a term coined by the British anthropologist Alan J. A. Elliot to describe the syncretic Chinese religion practised by the local Chinese which draws its themes from “popular and corrupt Taoism, with influences from Confucianism and Buddhism and, perhaps, more importantly, from ancient folk religion” (Elliott, 1955, p.29). Elliott visited Singapore as part of his research on the cults in the country between 1951-52. Most local Chinese in the 1950s practised 拜拜 (pronounced as BaiBai) or 拜神 (pronounced as BaiShen). “Bai” 拜 literally means to pray to, and “Shen” 神 means gods or deities, where “Shen” is “a major category among the powerful and fearful spiritual beings which have to be worshipped in order to secure human wellbeing” (Elliott, 1955, p.28). Therefore, Shenism is polytheistic and the “Shens” are able to communicate with their followers through dreams, spirit-mediums or the use of divination blocks 筊杯 (pronounced as Jiaobei), a pair of crescent shaped blocks (Wee, 1976, p.172).

The term “Shenism” is not a commonly used term among the locals and it has also not been listed as a religion option that one can choose from when the local government departments collected statistics on the religious affiliations of Singaporeans, for example, during its population censuses. Hence, the local Shenists usually select either “Buddhism”

or “Taoism*” as their religion during the population census, with the asterisk on the “Taoism” option indicating that it includes Chinese traditional beliefs (Department of Statistics Singapore, 2021, p.31). This explains why participant B used the Buddhist and Taoist interchangeably. At the beginning of our interview, participant B said: “before I was a very strong Buddhist lor. My wife also got shocked that I became a Christian”, but later in our conversation, he said: “the Lord guide me lah because before that, before that I was Taoist”.

Participant B did not experience a complete transformation of his lifestyle immediately after he accepted Jesus as his saviour, it was a gradual process of change. During this period, he had important spiritual experiences that helped strengthened his faith. He is an active member of his church and after retiring from full time employment, he volunteered with several church outreach programmes.

VI.2.3 Participant C

Participant C said she was born in 1942 in a large Chinese “Buddhist” family in Malaysia. Again, based on her description of the religious practices of her family of origin such as praying to the deity, 观音 (pronounced as Guanyin, the Goddess of Mercy) at home, her parents were Shenists. She said her parents were “doing business all the time. So, they got no time for me”. Participant C was brought up by her elder sister as her parents did not want her and had wanted to give her away. She was introduced to Christianity as a young child but did not know much about the faith. Participant C said: “I joined the Methodist school so from there I learn about Christianity”. At the end of primary five, one of her friends wanted to be baptised. Participant C said: “she got baptised, so I followed her. I also

go and get baptised.... Never read in detail. Blindly go and get baptised”. When research participant C moved to Singapore, she met a lady near her sister’s home, and she brought participant C to church. According to participant C, “even though I become a Christian, I never touch the Bible. Just follow my friend to become a Christian” “I was quite active in the church lah, even though it's a Chinese church, picked up choir singing. Take part, when it's Christmas time, you go carolling and all that. Ha. Ha... Social gathering, like that”. Subsequently, participant C met her husband, and he joined her church. Participant C said: “Everything very smoothly until my husband passed away”. She was devastated as she struggled with her grief. “So I called the Lord, the Lord has helped me to get through this, this period”. Participant C said she then “wanted to know more about God” and became a “more committed” Christian. At the time of our interview, she was a volunteer in her church’s wake service team as well as its outreach programme.

VI.2.4 Participant D

Participant D was born in a large Singaporean Chinese family in the early 50s. Her family religion was “BaiBai”, another term for “BaiShen” or Shenism. But some of her siblings did not practise the family religion, especially her elder sister who subscribed to the ideologies of a local left-wing political party, Barisan Socialis, that was closely associated with the Communist Party of China.

Participant D said that she felt oppressed because she felt that her family members did not love her and wanted to control her. Participant D said: “I feel that I have no goals, no love, no love” “so life was very unhappy, really unhappy” “there was no mother's love,

no father's love". She became a Christian when she was a young teenager. She was "touched by God" and said that she was "in love with God". Unfortunately, her family did not want her to be a Christian, especially her mother. Participant D's mother and her siblings tried to get her to obey them using threats to her life and physical abuses. Participant D said she "bore it (the abuses) in silence" and held on to her Christian faith despite the violent oppositions from her immediate and extended family members. Participant D said that she had experienced many "miracles" that made her grow closer to God. She volunteered actively in her church's outreach programmes even though her health had deteriorated, and she walked slowly because of pain in her knees.

VI.2.5 Participant E

Research participant E, a 66-year-old man whose father "practise Taoism", is the only tertiary-educated participant. Before he became a Christian at 18 years old, participant E said he thought: "we can take care of ourselves, we don't need God". This belief was shaken when his friend died suddenly, and it triggered his "journey questioning life". He accepted a friend's invitation to church to study the Bible and eventually accepted Christ as his saviour.

Participant E said that: "logic has quite a big part in my walk with Christ, with God". He said: "To me, the Bible is also a fair and accurate record of God's dealing with men. And that make it believable to me. If it's all one-sided, then I wouldn't believe in it but because it is balanced, I feel that the Bible is believable, and I choose to believe in it". He was also impacted by "the quality of life" of the Christians he met in church, "the life they live, and

the joy they have”. He had resigned from his job and was serving as a missionary in another Asian country at the time of the interview.

VI.2.6 Participant F

At 86, participant F is the oldest participant in this research. Her education was disrupted by WWII. After the war, she attended a Methodist school where she was introduced to Christianity. She stopped secondary school after two years but did not enter the workforce. Instead, she got married and became a full-time mother. Although participant F said that the religion of her family of origin and her in-laws was Buddhism, based on her description, it is the local Chinese religion, i.e. Shenism. This is because both families had family altars for the “Shen” invited from the temples and participant F was taken to spirit-mediums by her mother-in-law whenever her children fell ill. A spirit-medium is a person possessed by a “Shen” to facilitate communicate with the followers of that “Shen”.

When participant F’s daughter became a Christian in secondary school, she talked to participant F about Jesus and encouraged her to attend church activities. Participant F joined the activities in her daughter’s church but became a Christian only a few years later at the Singapore Billy Graham Crusade (SBGC) when she felt that she was being “called”. The SBGC event managed to draw 337,000 attendees over five days at a time when the population in Singapore was only 2.3m and more than 11,000 became Christians in those five days (Salt&Light, 2019). Participant F was a greeter in church and volunteered in the

church's outreach programme but all these activities stopped during the time of her interview because of the Covid-19 pandemic.

Bearing in mind this background information about the research participants, the coding and categorisation of the codes will be explained next.

VI.3 Process of coding and grouping the codes into categories

To illustrate how a transcript was coded into child and parent codes, and then consolidated into categories, I have extracted a row from the working table used to analyse the transcript of the interview with research participant A.

In the table below, participant A talked about how the key verses, John 3:16 and Prov 30:8-9 were important in keeping her “going”. She also gave an example of how her interpretation of Prov 30:8-9 helped her to reject bribes that were offered to her at work. She became aware of God's guidance only when one of those that tried to bribe her, asked her if she was a Christian. Participant A then felt blessed that she had such guidance.

In this example, participant A's belief in John 3:16 was coded as “God loves me”; and Prov 30:8 as “God guides me” using concept coding. These were then parked under the parent code “God cares”. This parent code “God cares” was subsequently categorized to “Own theological beliefs” with other beliefs that participant A has about her faith (see last column of Table 6 below).

	Quotes from transcript A	Exploratory comments:		Categories and codes
		Descriptive comments	<i>Linguistic and/</i> <u>conceptual</u> comments	(Categories are in bold font)
13	Interviewee A: from young, I was stuck with this (John 3:16). I also stuck to the verse of this Proverbs. I think it's 30:22-23 Lord don't give me so much wealth or riches that I forget about you, or don't give me too little that I would go and steal or something about the name. These two verses kept me going. So, when I was working, because I work in Finance. I have to approve contract/tenders. The vendors will come at the end of the year give ang pow and all that. I said: "No, no, can you put it into the...." Some will sarcastically say that "you own the company? Why don't you take the money and pass my bill above all the others" to get payment, you know. I say:" sorry, I don't take this". Others would say that: "wah, you are	The first verse was John 3:16 (mentioned earlier in the interview) The second set of verses that A remembered was Prov 30:8-9 (she mis-remembered the verse numbers) Participant A described how she had refused to accept bribes, and this allowed others to identify her as a Christian.	<i>"stuck with"</i> <i>"kept me going"</i> <i>"Wake up"</i> <i>"wah, you are a Christian?"</i> <i>"blessed"</i> <i>"guide me"</i> <i>Participant A used the words "wake up" to describe her realisation that she was behaving like a Christian in the eyes of others.</i> <u>Practising her beliefs in real</u>	Own theological beliefs: God cares -God loves me -God guides me Outcome_spiritual practices - Remembering key verses Outcome_impact on daily living -Ethical behaviour Disposition -Feeling blessed

	Quotes from transcript A	Exploratory comments:		Categories and codes
	Christian?" All of a sudden, I wake up (with a laugh): Is that how a Christian behave? That sort of thing. So, along the way, I say, um, I'm blessed that the Lord guide me		<u>life</u> <u>spontaneously</u>	

Table 6: Row 13 from working table on transcript of A's interview

The fact that research participant A remembered the verses was coded as “remembering key verses” and consolidated to the category “ Outcome_spiritual practices”. In addition, this incident was coded as “ethical behaviour”. This was then categorized as an outcome of her faith which has changed her daily living under the category “ Outcome_impact on daily living”. Finally, the fact that she said: “I’m blessed” was coded as “feeling blessed”, then consolidated to the category called “Disposition” as a quality that participant A presented. In total, this extract shows how codes were categorized into four categories, i.e. “Disposition”, “Outcome_impact on daily living”, “Outcome_spiritual practices” and “Own theological beliefs”. The full list of categories and their related codes will be discussed in the next section.

VI.4 Categories identified

Through the consolidation process, eight categories were identified in the transcripts. Please see the Table 7 below. Seven of the categories were identified in all six interview transcripts,

except one which was identified in three of the transcripts. The “References” column refers to the total number of quotes that were coded to each category.

Categories	Transcripts	References
1.Disposition	6	430
2.Influences	6	432
3.Outcome_ impact on daily living	6	386
4.Outcome_ spiritual practices	6	271
5Own theological beliefs	6	437
6.Spiritual experiences	6	354
7.Impact of Covid-19	6	92
8.Advice to grow as a Christian	3	8

Table 7: Categories

VI.4.1 Disposition

The first category in the Table 7 above is “Disposition” which is a consolidation of the different codes used to describe the qualities of the research participants. In the table below, those codes that are coded in more transcripts are placed higher up the table.

Categories and codes		Transcripts	References
	Disposition	6	430
1	Caring	6	57
	<i>Caring for others</i>	6	33
	<i>Compassionate</i>	3	11
	<i>Encouraging others</i>	3	4
	<i>Love for creation</i>	3	9
2	Feeling blessed	6	44
3	Feeling thankful or grateful	6	94
4	Happy	6	36
5	No fear of aging or death	6	63
6	At peace	6	29
7	Not of this world	4	13
8	Obedient to God	4	6
9	Concern for future generations	3	16
10	Empathic	3	14
11	No fear of illnesses and pain	3	6
12	Not fearful or anxious	3	5
13	Reflective	3	6
14	Respecting others regardless of faith	2	9
15	Fear of becoming bedridden	1	10

VERSION_DEC 2025

Categories and codes		Transcripts	References
16	Fear of God	1	5
17	Feeling useful	1	17

Table 8: Disposition and its codes

In the extract from participant A’s transcript above, “feeling blessed” (see Table 6 last column) was the code that was consolidated to this category (see highlighted phrase in row 2 of Table 8). In the rest of her transcript, participant A also had other codes consolidated to this category including being “caring”, “concern about future generations”, “being empathic”. A total of 17 child codes were consolidated to “Disposition”, six of which were coded in all interviews.

All six participants talked about being “caring”, “feeling blessed”, “feeling thankful or grateful to God” and “no fear of aging or death”. Under the code “caring”, there are four grandchild codes, i.e. the participants talked about “caring for others”, “being compassionate”, “encouraging others” and “the love for creation”. They also talked about being “happy” at this stage of their lives. The last disposition that all six of the participants talked about during their interviews was the feeling of being “at peace” (see highlighted phrase in row 6 of Table 8), including in the face of major operation such as a heart bypass. This list of “dispositions” is not surprising given the research participants were supposed to be OAs that are positively engaged with life, but it is useful as it shows the actual attributes that these participants possessed.

VI.4.2 Influences

The next category “Influences” is a consolidation of all the factors that had affected the participants’ faith whether positively or negatively. The codes that were consolidated into this category is listed in the table below.

Categories and codes		Transcripts	References
	Influences	6	432
1	Conversion experience	6	41
	<i>Born in Christian family</i>	1	5
	<i>Converted to Christianity</i>	5	36
2	Early initiation to Christianity	6	18
3	Impact of other faiths	6	70
	<i>Conflicts with local beliefs</i>	6	37
	<i>Fears associated with local religious practices</i>	2	33
4	Impact of local culture	6	84
	<i>Christianity deemed western or foreign</i>	2	19
	<i>Filial piety</i>	2	8
	<i>Kampung spirit</i>	1	8
	<i>Language barrier</i>	2	17
	<i>Patriarchal attitude</i>	5	21
	<i>Social or familial pressure</i>	1	6

Categories and codes		Transcripts	References
	<i>Too shy to lift up hands to worship</i>	1	5
5	Significant life events	6	112
	<i>Financial difficulties</i>	2	3
	<i>Health issues</i>	2	6
	<i>Losing loved ones</i>	4	25
	<i>Mistreated by family (family of origin)</i>	3	63
	<i>Physical abuses</i>	1	2
	<i>Prejudicial treatment because of faith</i>	2	13
6	Difficulty understanding Bible	3	6
7	Support and role models from church	3	16
8	Search to understand faith	3	64
9	Supportive family (own nuclear family)	3	10
10	Social interactions in church	2	3
11	Looked down upon because of poverty	1	1
12	Proud of Christianity	1	3
13	Using logic to understand faith	1	4

Table 9: Influences and their codes

The first observation under this category is that all six research participants had conversion experiences including participant A who was a second-generation Christian.

Conversion experiences “involve a major change in a person’s thinking, feeling and willing – in short, in their total behaviour” (Westerhoff, 2000, p.94). Participant A was envious of her husband because he studied the faith before converting to Christianity so he was able to live as a Christian wholeheartedly after conversion. On the other hand, she carried the Christian label from birth but spent many years searching her faith. She compared the faith journey of Christian converts like her husband and her faith journey, saying: “So they know from reading the Bible now they know what it is life is (*they learnt their life purpose*). So they do everything. For us, since born leh, I don't have that. Only the years He bring us.” Her husband was a Buddhist when they got married but he “embraced Christianity” after studying the Bible and receiving God’s calling. Despite being born in a Christian family and attending church service from young, participant A said that she and her siblings were “very happy” to attend church on Sundays “not for the service ah, because as children we wear new clothes. So, you just waited for Sunday where you have new clothes, you know, wear nice clothing to church”. After the tragic events happened in her family, she went through a long phase of being critical: “....like myself to float around from one place to another place to hear the sermon but you doesn’t like it, you can go back and say: aiya, the sermon or the church is no good”. She visited church after church and “was looking for years”. She admitted that she could not “go all out for it (her faith)” because she was not “ready” whereas her husband was able to live the Christian life once he decided to become a Christian.

As mentioned above in the background information of the participants (see section VI.2 above), only the participant D experienced an immediate conversion – her centers of value, images of power and master story changed, i.e. contents of her faith (Fowler, 1995, pp.281–282) which in turn changed how she lived. Her change was obvious enough to be noted by her family, triggering their attempts to coerce her to renounce Christianity (see section VI.5.5 below for details). The rest of the participants took some time for the contents of their faith to change and to apply that to their daily living.

The second finding was that the five research participants who were Christian converts were introduced to Christianity when they were very young, i.e. in their teens, either through the school, teachers or fellow students.

The third finding was that all the research participants had exposure to Shenism (see section VI.2.2 above for more information on Shenism) including participant A, the second-generation Christian. The key “conflicting” belief between Shenism and Christianity mentioned by most of the research participants was that Christians only serve one God but Shenism is polytheistic with many family rituals to pray to various “Shen”. Hence, many Shenists regarded those who have converted to Christianity as having rejected their lifestyles and in more extreme case, them. Some of them are wary of Christians as they do not want their family members to become Christians. Participant A described an incident where she helped a fellow patient to the ward toilet during a hospitalisation stay. Instead of being thanked, participant A was “warned” by the daughters of this fellow patient against talking

to their mother because “we are staunch Buddhists (Shenists), don't come and disturb my mother”.

For two of the participants, the fears associated with certain local religious practices served as a push factor for them to become Christians. Participant B talked about being attacked by evil spirits when he was working on an island where bomohs (Malay shamans and traditional medicine practitioner) prayed at random graves; and participant F described the fear that she felt when told by the spirit-medium that her child became sick because certain spirits had been offended and she had to give them offerings at a specified crossroad to appease them.

In their interviews, all six also described significant life events that they felt had changed their lives, impacting their spiritual lives directly or indirectly. These included the loss of someone dear suddenly or through a painful illness, being sent away to a welfare home and being threatened with death by one's mother. These changed the participants' perspective of who they needed in life. For some, it triggered the search for God, and others a renewed reliance on their Christian faith.

Finally, the last influence coded in all six transcript was the impact of the local culture, especially the patriarchal attitude which had adversely impacted the lives of the female participants when they were young. Interestingly, those who held such attitudes were the powerful female family members such as the participant A's grandmother and the mothers of the participant D and F. When participant A's mother could not afford to upkeep

her children, her grandmother took in the only boy in the family because she wanted to give him a piece of land whereas participant A and her sisters were sent away to a welfare home.

The impact of local culture also included local ideas and concepts which influenced how the participants understand their Christian faith. Please refer to the example in the table below:

	Quotes from transcript A	Exploratory comments:		Categories and codes
		Descriptive comments	Linguistic and/ <u>conceptual</u> comments	
5.	Interviewee A: Don't worry whether you are Christian or what, but the (kampung) spirit should be there. Care for one another.. And then from there, you want to...they want to change. "Oh, very good, you are from a Christian home", your ways and how you displayed, they might follow you.	Participant A thinks of kampung spirit as something that "should be there" regardless of faith but when it is displayed it could be seen as Christian behaviour which might attract others to "follow you".	<i>"Kampung spirit", a local term was used to describe Christian living. Kampung is the Malay word for village.</i> <u>Described her understanding of Christian living using terms familiar to her.</u>	Influences -Impact of local culture - kampung spirit (integrating local culture)

Table 10: Row 5 from working table on participant A's interview transcript

In this example, participant A indigenised her idea of Christian living using the local concept of “kampung spirit”. She used to live in a Malaysian kampung as a very young child and said the neighbours kept their doors open and lived harmoniously regardless of race and religion. They were hospitable, feeding their neighbours’ children as their own. “Kampung spirit” was participant A’s idea of what a Christian neighbour should be like and helped her vocalise her idea of Christian living.

VI.4.3 Outcome_impact on daily living

The next two categories are the outcome of their faith, i.e. its impact on the research participants’ daily living and the resulting spiritual practices that they engaged in. With regards to the impact on their daily living, an example of the code consolidated to this category, i.e. “Ethical behaviour” has already been shown in Table 6 above. Participant A’s ethical behaviour at work was an example that participant A gave of how God had guided her at work. In this category, the first four codes in table 11 below were found in all six transcripts.

The codes “Having meaning of life” and “Volunteering to serve others” were related (in rows numbered “1” and numbered “4” of the table) according to the participants. All of them talked about doing God’s work in this stage of their lives and this meant serving in church-organised programmes. Given that the research participants selected were supposed to be positively engaged with life, having meaning of life and volunteering were not surprising but it was illuminating to know what their exact life purpose was and how they were achieving it.

Categories and codes		Transcripts	References
	Outcome_impact on daily living	6	377
1	Having meaning of life	6	39
2	Reframing	6	29
	<i>Having Christian mindset</i>	1	1
	<i>Unanswered prayer</i>	2	14
3	Trusting God	6	51
4	Volunteering to serve others	6	68
5	Obedying God	4	44
6	Taking on caregiving duties	4	10
7	Wanting to do more for God	4	19
8	Ethical behaviour	3	6
9	Not of this world	3	10
10	Reflecting	3	4
11	Accepting others instead of judging them	2	3
12	Focus on God	2	5
13	Having habit of donating and giving	2	7
14	Helping others keep their faith	2	9
15	Need for self to change	2	13
16	Not bearing grudges	2	5
17	Respecting others regardless of faith	2	11

VERSION_DEC 2025

Categories and codes		Transcripts	References
	Outcome_impact on daily living	6	377
18	Accepting consequences for choices made	1	3
19	Advocating respect in family	1	2
20	Forbearing others	1	6
21	Keeping holy	1	6
22	Living simply	1	7
23	No need elaborate funeral	1	1
24	Not seeking limelight	1	2
25	Nurturing the young	1	1
26	Spending time with loved ones	1	6
27	To treasure everything	1	4
28	To treasure life	1	2
29	Want peace	1	1
30	Wanting to know more about God	1	3

Table 11: Outcome_impact on daily living and its codes

All the participants showed that they were capable of “reframing” events in their past using a Christian perspective. Please refer to section VI.5.5 below for more on this capability. “Trusting God” codes behaviours that the participants have undertaken because of their trust in God. For example, participant E described how he resigned from his job when he was 50 years old to join a mission ship for two months, despite warnings from

others that he would have difficulties finding a job after that. He said: “I trust Him, that this is what He wants me to do”. All six transcripts had codes in this category, showing that they have all described how they lived their lives trusting God to be the one in charge.

VI.4.4 Outcome_spiritual practices

All the participants talked about the spiritual practices that they engaged in after becoming Christians. The list of such practices are listed below in Table 12.

	Categories and codes	Transcripts	References
	Outcome_spiritual practices	6	271
1	Attending church and small group	6	25
2	Praying	6	70
3	Quiet time with God	6	11
4	Studying Bible	6	24
5	Bringing others to the faith	4	83
6	Remembering Scriptures	4	24
7	Singing Hymns and worship songs	4	24
8	Calling God Abba	1	8
9	Responding to God's call	1	2

Table 12: Outcome_spiritual practices and their codes

The four spiritual practices that all six research participants said they engaged in were: attending church and small group, praying, daily quiet time with God and studying the

Bible. Research participant A is the leader of her small group and she said she spent time talking to God every morning. She also talked about praying to God and spending time reading the Bible “I go back to the Bible and try to find out what this verse is trying to tell me” as she felt that one has “to be guided by the Bible”. Participant B also described similar spiritual practices: “attend church sermon, study the Bible, so slowly I grow strong in the faith” “I just study the Word, understand the Word and pray to the Lord. Morning pray, study his Word.” Participant C attended church services regularly and started reading the Bible after she joined a small group with her late husband. She became “more committed” after her husband’s death and “wanted to know more about God”. She also talked about how shameful she felt about not reading the Bible previously: “don’t read the Bible. So shame, call yourself a Christian but you never touch the Bible”. For participant D, she enjoys “daily spiritual feeding” where she talks to God and reads the Bible. Regarding prayer, she said: “as for prayers, frankly, prayer is whenever. I can pray everywhere and anywhere. I pray in the kitchen, I pray as I walk, I pray when I am seated, I can pray anywhere, I don’t need to be deliberate. I don’t pray only when there is something on today.” She also spent half an hour every night praying with her granddaughter. Participant E attends Sunday services and two small groups, one in English and the other one in Chinese. For him, “quiet time is mandatory”. Finally, participant F said: “morning I will read my Bible lah. Then before I read my Bible, I follow the daily bread. I follow the daily bread every day” and she felt that she “must spend quiet time with God”. Several participants also talked about the difficulties that they had understanding Scriptures, either when reading the Bible or listening to preachers. For instance, research participant F described her pastor’s preaching: “His

English is very posh. I cannot understand then I tell my daughter: Aiyo, I don't know what he's saying today". Her daughter encouraged her by telling her: "Mummy never mind, you take one word come back okay, today you take one word come back". Participant F said she eventually agreed with her daughter: "Today pastor said that yeah, okay, the rest never mind. One day one word". Hence, using "posh" words to teach Scripture was not useful to participant F, but chunking the sermon into bite sizes was helpful.

Four of them, i.e. participants A,B,D and F also described specific experiences where they tried to bring others to the Christian faith. Although research participant E did not describe such an experience during our conversation, he was a missionary sent to another Asian country and telling others about Christianity would be a key goal of that role.

For all the four female participants, singing hymns and worship songs was also very important as it comforted and moved them. Both participant A and C identified hymns that comforted them when they thought of their late spouses. Participant D described how the hymns sung at the service, where she converted, moved her and she felt touched by God: "when I heard the hymns being sung, I was moved. I heard them and I was touched by God." Finally, participant F described how singing "God will make a way" helped her when she could not visit her daughter who was sick overseas. To the four, they meant the words that they sung. For example, participant A said: "whenever there's a hymn, I always look at the words, don't just sing like that" and participant F said she was scared of singing "I surrender all" because she could not do so.

VI.4.5 Own theological beliefs

To live their faith, the research participants have Christian beliefs that they subscribe to. Those discussed in the interviews are consolidated into this category and shown in the table below. There were five beliefs that were brought up by all six research participants.

VI.4.5.1 God cares

The first belief was that God cares about them - He guides, loves, protects, and generally takes care of them (see the first row of table 13 below). It is especially important for those participants that did not have parental love such as participant A and D (see section VI.2 Background information on the research participants). Participant A said that “If I am left to myself and I don't have this (John 3:16), I think I'm now nowhere” whereas participant B said that “He loves me dearly” “the Lord guides me” “God is protecting me all the while”, the latter is especially important to him because he said: “twice I was attacked by those evil spirits before I became a Christian”. Participant C said that after her husband passed away, God “became more real to me” “taking care of me” “the Lord console me” and “through his illness, I mean, the Lord really give me peace.” Participant D, who felt “no love” from her family, was touched by God during a worship service and was “in love with God” since. She said: “God saw how much you love Him, so whole-heartedly, so sincere, I was able to meet God again. God met me repeatedly because my whole-heartedness, my devotedness”. She had experienced “many miracles” and blessings after she became

a Christian including being blessed with children “I was barren, God gave me a son”. Participant E believes in God’s “love for us, you know, as His children” “where the Bible describes God as our father, it’s an image I can associate, closely associate with” as participant E’s late father was a father that loved his family. Finally, participant F believed that God “so love” her preserving her from the time she was in “my mother’s womb, when I was not a Christian till now I am a Christian, but I am so blessed. That in my mother’s womb You preserved me to be a Christian when I am more elderly”. For the participants, this belief that God cares for them is supported by their lived experiences, and such care is valuable to them.

VI.4.5.2 God is in charge and His plan

The next two beliefs mentioned by all the research participants, especially in connection with the then ongoing pandemic were: they believed that God was in charge/in control and that God had planned everything. Participant A narrated an incident where her stepbrother’s attempt to sell her mother’s home without her permission was thwarted. Participant A’s mother suffered from dementia and he had asked her to move in with his family, taking over her care. On the day he brought an agent to see her flat, participant A’s mother was visiting her next-door neighbour so she questioned and stopped him. Participant A said: “that’s why, on the same day you know. How did my mother know that they are going to be there?” She felt that it was all in God’s control. Participant B also said: “He is God, He created everything, so He knows what His plan for the world” “He is in charge of everything”. Participant C

echoed this when she said: “God is in control. So, leave it to Him, surrender to Him” whereas participant D said that “the days of our lives are in God's hands” “all things hoped for have already been planned by God” and “God’s plan is the best”. Participant E also said that “God is in control” and participant F said that it is “God’s way to do all these things”. This belief helped them not to be anxious during the Covid-19 pandemic. See section VI.4.7 below for details of their responses to the pandemic.

VI.4.5.3 Believe in heaven

The belief in heaven helped to remove the fear of death and mitigate some of the fears of illnesses. All the participants said that they were not afraid of death even though some said they have asked God to spare them from becoming bedridden before they die. Both participants A and C believed that their husbands who passed away were in heaven. When queried about her husband’s whereabouts by her mother who had dementia, participant A told her: “Mum, he’s in heaven”. When participant C talked about her late husband, she said: “I am sure he is with God”.

Participant B also said: “I believe in God. God said that you will be with me in heaven. I already have the assurance that I will be with Him in heaven”. Participant D believed that “the real beginning is in heaven” whereas participant F said: “Aiyo, death I go and meet my husband up there, my brother, then meet my Lord, the King. I want to go and see our Father in heaven. And God got mansion for us, we already said ... our mansion is up there”.

VI.4.5.4 Believe in the Bible

All the research participants believed in the Bible, and participant E explained how he arrived at the conclusion that the Bible was “believable” through logic. He said: “the harmony, the Old Testament, the New Testament, the events that preceded the coming of Christ. The way God use the Old Testament sacrifice to prepare the way for Christ's sacrifice, to atone for the sin. All these, the harmony there tells me that, you know, it wasn't an accident. It wasn't by chance, I believe. Oh, everything just happened to harmonize and work out perfectly. It wasn't random. There was... God's hand was in it. So that was the first part why I believe in the Bible.” The second reason was that he felt the Bible is honest: “when the Bible recorded human history or its heroes, it recorded the good and the bad of these heroes....To me, the Bible is honest.... a fair and accurate record of God's dealing with men. And that make it believable to me. If it's all one-sided, then I wouldn't believe in it but because it is balanced, I feel that the Bible is believable and I choose to believe in it.”

The other research participants implied their belief in the Bible when they studied and relied on its verses to guide them in their lives. This is despite the difficulties that some of them face in understanding the Bible (see Table 9: Influences and their codes, item 6). For example, participant F said: “Bible...sometime I say: God, today Old Testament and the name also cannot read ... I can't understand. But I can sometimes this verse I know, that verse I know, then the whole thing sometimes I don't know. Today, no message from You. I say, thank You”. Instead of feeling

dejected, participant F accepted it as no message from God for that day when she could not understand the Bible passage and thanked Him for that.

Categories and codes		Transcripts	References
	Own theological beliefs	6	437
1	God cares	6	80
	<i>God guides me</i>	5	31
	<i>God loves me</i>	2	9
	<i>God protects me</i>	4	10
	<i>God takes care of me</i>	1	14
2	God is in charge or in control	6	54
3	God's plan	6	35
4	Believe in heaven	6	29
5	Believe in the Bible	6	12
6	God can be relied upon	5	56
7	God gives us choices	3	24
8	God is everywhere	3	12
9	Need to draw near to God	3	5
10	No need to understand everything	3	7
11	About unequally yoked	2	20
12	Can't serve two masters	2	7

VERSION_DEC 2025

Categories and codes		Transcripts	References
13	God is real	2	3
14	God the creator	2	4
15	Honour parents	2	3
16	Know God know love	2	6
17	Learning about faith from own experiences	2	5
18	Need to be true or sincere to God	2	19
19	True God	2	9
20	Whole household is saved	2	2
21	About baptising children	1	2
22	About church traditions	1	7
23	Definition of family	1	4
24	Definition of neighbour	1	3
25	God is no man's debtor	1	2
26	God is spirit	1	1
27	God is always victorious	1	1
28	God's kingdom	1	3
29	God's will	1	3
30	Jesus died for our salvation	1	1
31	Need to attend church to stay on Christian line	1	1
32	Need to have personal relationship with God	1	4

VERSION_DEC 2025

Categories and codes		Transcripts	References
33	Need to practice love God gave	1	1
34	Need to serve to be part of the Body	1	2
35	Spiritual path	1	7
36	World under the grip of the evil one	1	3

Table 13 Own theological beliefs and their codes

VI.4.6 Spiritual experiences

The category “Spiritual experiences” is a consolidation of all the codes that were used to describe the spiritual experiences of the research participants.

Categories and codes		Transcripts	References
	Spiritual experiences	6	354
1	Personal relationship with God	6	199
	<i>Feeling God's call</i>	2	3
	<i>Sensing God's presence</i>	4	15
2	Answered prayers	4	25
3	Encounters with the Holy Spirit, dreams and other miracles etc.	3	129
4	Attacked by evil spirits	1	1

Table 14: Spiritual experiences and their codes

All six participants talked about having a personal relationship with God, had felt God's presence and either talked to Him or heard His call. Four of the participants recounted specific instances where their prayers were answered. Three of them, i.e. participants A, B and D, described their encounters with Jesus or the Holy Spirit.

Participant A was thankful to Jesus for His visit when she was hospitalized after an operation, and participant B was able to work on the island where he was attacked by "evil spirits" because he felt God's presence with him.

In her interview, participant D described one of the "miracles" that she experienced after becoming a Christian. Her mother practised "Baibai", i.e. Shenism (see section VI.2.2 for more information on Shenism) and had a Shenist altar at home where she offered prayers regularly. When she discovered that participant D had become a Christian, she became upset with her daughter and wanted her to renounce Christianity. She asked participant D to kneel at this family altar, telling her: "Kneel, if you kneel, I will spare your life". When she refused, her mother asked her to choose between being hung or chopped to death using the noose and the big chopping knife she had placed on the family altar. Participant D's mother then kicked her so that she knelt at the altar. In the extract in Annex B, participant D described how she prayed to God during that ordeal. As she prayed to God, participant D said a miracle occurred. The electrical candles on the family altar blew out suddenly and the joss sticks stopped burning. Although her mother refused to acknowledge that it was God at work, insisting that it was participant D's "unlucky hands" that had jinxed her "Shen", she stopped forcing participant D to pray at the family altar. This miracle made participant D thankful

to God as she felt that He had acted to help her during her ordeal, and that strengthened her faith.

VI.4.7 Impact of Covid-19

Because of my special interest in understanding how the pandemic had impacted the research participants, all the participants were asked about the impact of Covid-19 on them. Their common response was that they were not fearful or anxious about the Covid-19 pandemic. Participant A said that she did not feel anxious about Covid-19 and her only regret is that she is not able visit the home that she volunteered at. Participant B felt that “God is protecting us”, and participant C said that: “I was quite calm, I have peace, I am not worried and all that. I know God will take care of that. No anxiety or this and that. I was quite calm. Whatever it is, God is in control. So, leave it to Him, surrender to Him ah.” Participant D felt that “we are in the presence of God ... you don’t need to worry about it”. Participant E said that he is “not worried” about it and participant F also said that there was no negative impact on her.

Of the six, only participant D talked about Covid-19 being a wake-up call: “I just use spiritual thinking to think, I think people in this world keeps sinning, so God wants to use this thing to teach you restraint. So, everyone can't come out to meet up, ok? They are locked up, have lots of quiet time to think”.

The impact on their daily lives from the government-imposed pandemic-related restrictions ranged from feeling “very difficult” to “more happy”. Participant C had to stop all her volunteering work so she felt that the Covid-19 restrictions had made her life “very

difficult” but was hopeful that the restrictions would be lifted once Covid-19 “stop”. On the other hand, participant F said she was “more happy” because she could access Sunday worship services from other churches online.

Overall, the participants’ perception of Covid-19 was affected by their faith positively. They were not fearful or anxious and most of them expressed their belief that God is in control of the situation.

Categories and codes		Transcripts	References
	Impact of Covid-19	6	92
1	Not fearful or anxious	6	11
2	God is in control	5	7
3	Volunteering activities stopped	5	6
4	Low impact	3	10
5	Obey God and local authorities appointed by God	3	7
6	Negative impact	2	8
7	Positive impact	2	19
8	Chance to repent	1	13
9	Chance to show love	1	3
10	God wants to use this thing to teach restraint	1	4
11	Like Noah's ark	1	4

Table 15: Impact of Covid-19 and its codes

VI.4.8 Advice to grow as a Christian

The category “Advice to grow as a Christian” arose because I have asked participants B and E if they had any advice in this area. The rest of the participants were not asked this question because it was not one of my planned interview questions. Notwithstanding, participant D talked about this issue and some of their comments were coded and consolidated into this category.

Categories and codes		Transcripts	References
	Advice to grow as a Christian	3	8
1	Pray to the Lord	2	2
2	Believe in the Lord	1	4
3	Implanted into the God's Word	1	1
4	A good mentor	1	1

Table 16: Advice to grow as a Christian and its codes

They suggested staying close to God through prayer and studying God’s word, and having a good mentor would help young Christians to become mature Christians. Participant B also suggested using a different strategy for those who were uneducated as compared to those who were educated. This is because he worked with OAs who were mostly not well-educated. He felt that the emphasis should be on imparting a few key beliefs to them. This is in line with one of the earlier findings above where some of the research participants held on to a few key verses or beliefs and these were sufficient to guide them in their daily living.

VI.5 Identifying Patterns/Themes

Besides synthesizing the codes into categories to give them “consolidated meaning” per Saldaña (2016, pp.10), I also noted that there were interactions between the categories. These interactions or patterns emerged after the categories were created, especially after the last round of analysis using the Word tables. By identifying the categories in the last column of the Word table for each section of the transcript, I could see the interaction between the identified categories and drew diagrams to illustrate such interactions. These interactions or patterns were not only identified in the transcript of one participant but occurred across several participants. This is explained in the following subsections.

VI.5.1 Pattern of holding on

In the attempted bribing incident, participant A (Table 6 above) said that she was “stuck” with a few key Bible verses which told her that God loves her and guides her on how to live her life. Those were participant A’s beliefs about God, and she reacted to the situation in her workplace spontaneously accordingly. When her ethical behaviour allowed her to be recognized as a “Christian” by others, her beliefs were reinforced because she felt that she was guided and blessed. This pattern is represented in Figure 1 below.

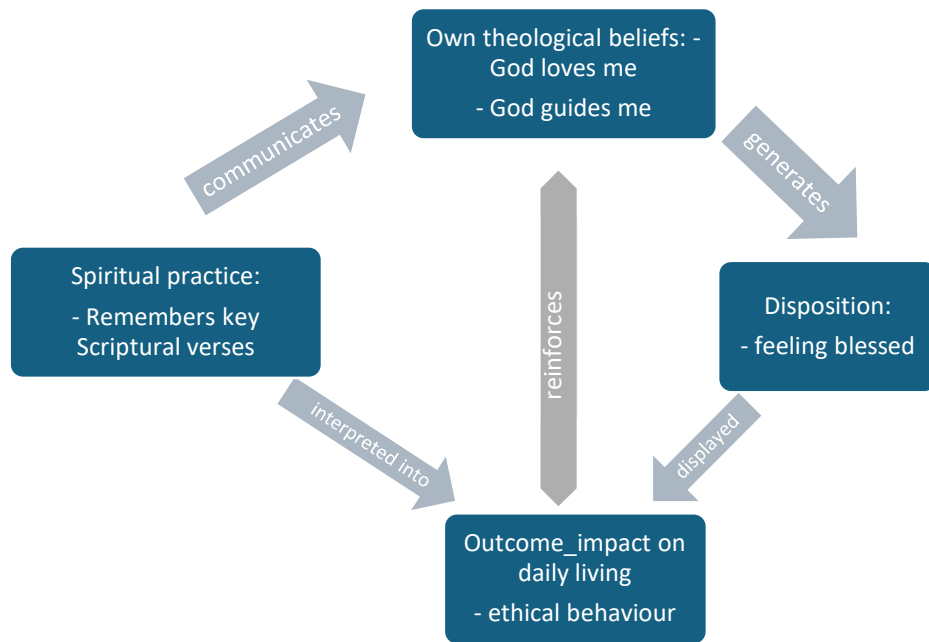


Figure 1: Pattern of holding on (participant A)

This pattern of holding on to key verses/beliefs was repeated in other parts of A’s interview. She said that “If I am left to myself and I don’t have this (John 3:16), I think I’m now nowhere also, I don’t, I don’t think I’ll go to church you know” because church was “not rosy”. When she was young and poor, she felt that people in the churches “don’t look at you because you’re poor or whatever”. Despite this, her belief that God loves her made her continue her search for a church, attending Sunday services at different churches. She said that this was her way of “staying on the Christian line”. Finally, having found her current church, where she was a pioneer, she has been with it for more than five decades as an active member and volunteers in the church’s outreach programmes.

This pattern of holding on was also repeated in other research participants. For example participant B believes that God loves him, and he has the key to heaven (Matthew 16:19), Jesus “prepare many rooms for me there” (John 14:2). During our conversation, he repeated four times that he has the key to heaven. These beliefs resulted in him not having any fear of death or aging. He “want to do God’s will during the later part of senior years, continue serving the Lord”, so he volunteered actively in outreach programmes to help those who needed help, and talked to them about Christianity. He believed that it was God’s will for him to serve God by serving others and telling them about Him. He said: “I feel happy serving people”. He was also “very happy” when one of them “receive Christ”. Research participant F also said during her interview that she re-memorised Psalm 23, Psalm 100, Psalm 121 to avoid forgetting them: “I frighten wait I Boey..Um Kee Teck”. The quoted sentence was spoken in a mixture of Singlish and Teochew, a Chinese dialect, and was translated to “I am afraid that I cannot remember”. Finally, in our discussions on the impact of Covid-19, all the participants were not fearful or anxious because they held on to their belief that God is in control of the situation.

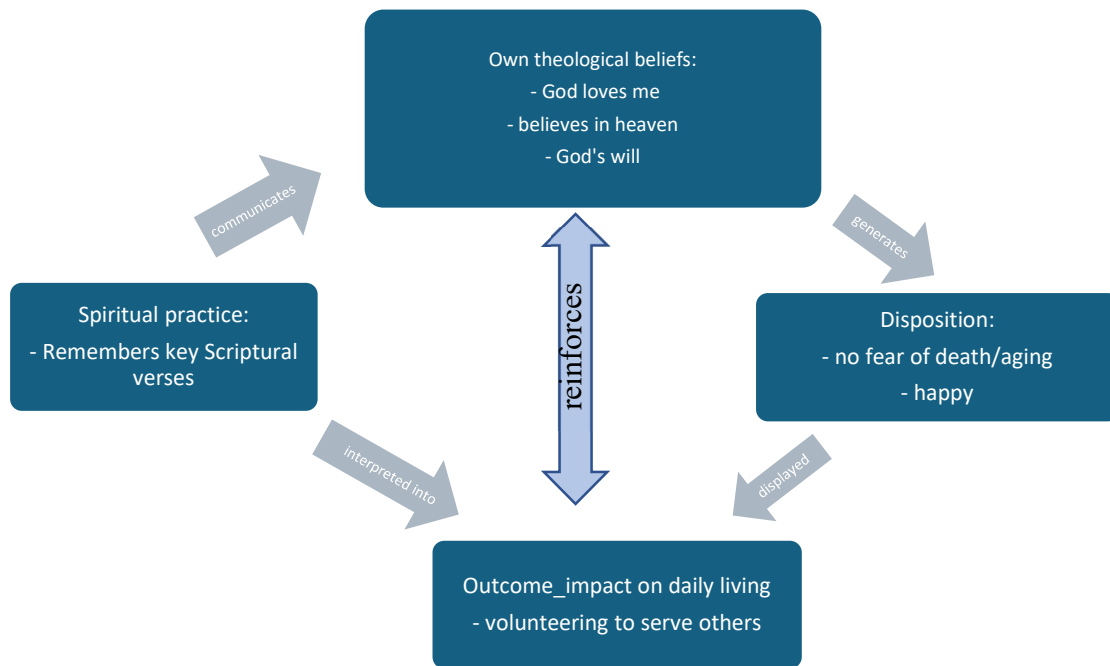


Figure 2: Pattern of holding on (participant B)

This “holding on” pattern gave a snapshot of faith contents of these research participants – showing the value of God’s love to them, His authority over their lives and their need to be part of God’s plan.

VI.5.2 Pattern of healing

In participant A’s transcript, there was also a pattern of healing. Participant A was sent to a welfare home with her sisters while her elder brother attended a prestigious boys’ school under their wealthy grandmother’s guardianship (see section VI.2.1). The girls had to fend for themselves, and participant A said: “my mum is one she loves herself only”. Notwithstanding that, participant A believed that one had to respect one’s parents when they

were alive because she said: “respect is very important, your family tree”. She also said that “God doesn't say that this person cannot be this, so who are we to say. Just accept them lah. (paused) Life is like that. So that you have not to bear grudge”. In fact, participant A took over the care of her mother, who had dementia in her old age, in the last five years of her mother’s life. This pattern of healing of key relationship was also seen in the transcripts of two other research participants, i.e. C and D.

Participant C was the 13th child and a girl. Participant C’s parents had “no time for” her. She said: “I was supposed to give away also and my sister took me and hide and kept me. So, she brought me up”. Participant C stayed with her sister even after the latter got married and moved with her to Singapore. She later found support from her Christian friends and churchmates. Participant C said that her parents “don’t even care if I become this, become that”. As she reviewed her life, participant C was able to reframe this as part of God’s plan. She said: “God stopped all these things so I was saved. I didn't get given away”. Her relationship with her mother had also improved. During our interview, participant C proudly showed me a cross which she said her mother gave her.

Finally, participant D was also born in a large family where she said she felt “oppressed”. She was expected to obey her mother and her elder siblings without question. Her description of her mother was: “Mum's heart was one-sided, she didn’t care if you are good or bad, when she does not like she just does not like you. She would disregard your perspective; she is always right”. She was physically abused and threatened by her mother after she became a Christian. Participant D said her mother: “cut my hair into patches, threw

away my shoes” and tore her clothes to make her afraid. There was one occasion where participant D’s hand was broken by her mother because she went out at night to attend a Christian event without permission from her mother. When participant D’s mother had dementia in her old age, she took turns with her sibling to look after her mother until her recent death. Participant D said that “If I continue to remember how badly she had treated me in the past, then I am not a believer of Jesus”. For participant D, she was able to care for her mother because of her Christian beliefs. This helped to heal the relationship with her mother.

From this pattern, one can see the participants’ ability to act according to their faith beliefs (e.g. honour your parents) and reframe their familial struggles using the Christian worldviews that they have developed, thus achieving healing of their relationships with their respective mothers.

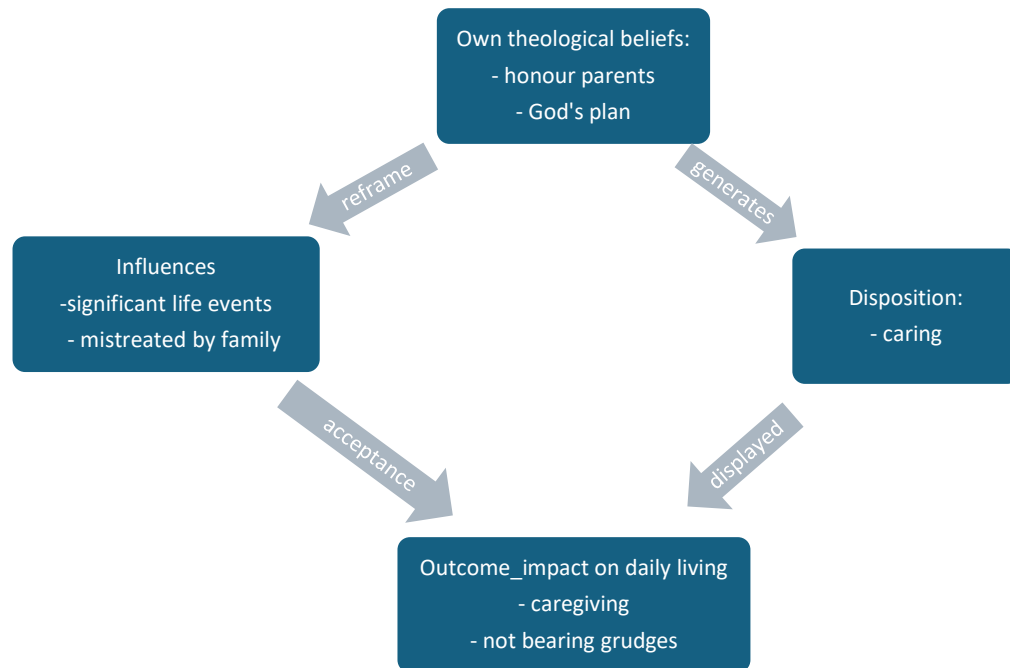


Figure 3: Pattern of healing (participants A and D)

VI.5.3 Pattern of indigenising

In the transcripts of participants A and D, there was a pattern where both used concepts that Singaporeans are familiar with to interpret their faith. Participant A recognised the local concept of “kampung spirit” in her understanding of Christian living (please see Table 10 above for extract of participant A’s interview). To her, it meant to “care for one another” “You can come to my house and I can come to.... So at that time you don't have barriers like if you're Muslim, you cannot come to my house, that sort”. She believed that displaying kampung spirit would also allow the neighbours to recognize that this is a Christian home. “Kampung spirit” is a local term used to describe the community spirit that

existed when most Singaporeans lived in “kampung” which is the Malay word for villages. It is also something that the Singapore government has been trying to keep in the older Singaporeans and develop in younger Singaporeans after the mass resettlement of most of her residents from kampungs to high rise public housing blocks. Hence, this is a familiar concept to locals.

Next, in participant D’s interview, she described her struggle between “being filial” and obeying God’s command to have no other gods before Him (Exo 20:3) when she became a Christian in her teens. As a young teenager, an important part of participant D’s understanding of “being filial” was to obey her parents unquestioning. Unfortunately, her mother wanted participant D to renounce Christianity in front of the whole kampung (see Annex B).

The Singaporean concept of “being filial” was derived mainly from the Confucian concept of “filial piety”. Under the government’s “many helping hands” approach in managing social welfare, Singaporeans are expected to be self-reliant, failing which, their families should be the next in line to look after them. Hence, filial piety is actively promoted as a virtue to encourage children to look after their aging parents at home. Participant D’s understanding of the Bible was that God meant for her to be “filial” even though the word “filial” is not found in the Bible. This was an integration of a local concept of “being filial” into her interpretation of what is required of her faith, i.e. honour your father and your mother (Exo 20:12a). As a teenager, she struggled to integrate this concept but was unsuccessful. Over time, her understanding of “being filial” changed. Hence, by the time of our interview,

she was able to indigenise her interpretation of “honouring your parents” with the local concept of “being filial” to live it in her life. Despite the physical and mental abuses inflicted by her mother, participant D shared the caregiving of her mother with her siblings when she had dementia in her old age.

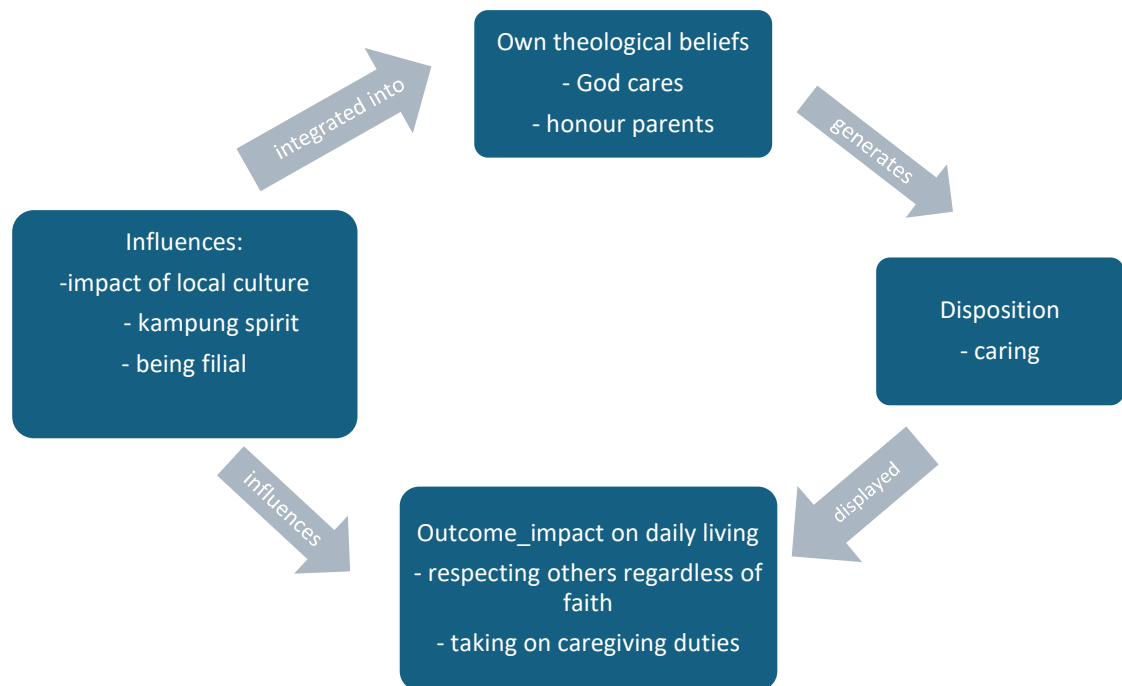


Figure 4: Pattern of indigenising (participants A and D)

Participants A and D did not choose to disown all their local cultural practices/values but instead tried to integrate some of them into their Christian faith. This ability to indigenise their faith will be discussed further in the next chapter.

VI.5.4 Pattern of discerning

In the pattern of indigenising, participants A and D integrated the local concepts of “kampung spirit” and “being filial” into their Christian living. However, not all local concepts and practices were kept after the research participants became Christians.

Participant B continued a local practice, i.e. social gambling, after he became a Christian, but eventually discarded it. He said: “first few years I still play mahjong, after that I say: no no no, it's not the right way to become a Christian. I give up everything, buy 4D everything”. 4D is a form of lottery where one bets on which four-digit numbers would be the winning numbers published by 4D operators. In the 70s, almost every village had runners from 4D syndicates that would collect bets from the villagers before a game day, usually weekends plus one more weekday. Currently, 4D gambling is legal as long as it is organized by licensed operators. Gambling using physical mahjong games is also legal when played among family and friends at home. Such forms of “social gambling” are also acceptable and not frowned upon among the locals. However, participant B has chosen to disown this hobby. He said: “the Lord guide me lah because before that, before that I was Taoist. I still gamble. I see people I go and gamble with him. I win his money, I feel I'm happy. Before that I never think of that. He earn a small salary, I go and gamble with him. Play mahjong all that, win his money, it's not good. Now, I have empathy on people, I love people, I don't want to hurt people, because he has a family to look after”. Participant B mentioned two ways by which he decided whether to continue to own or to disown a practice: (i) based on his understanding of God's will; and (ii) whether his heart is “at peace”. In this

case, participant B believes that God loves people so he did not want to hurt them by taking all their money through gambling. So, he discontinued this practice. Participant B also talked at length about this disposition of being “at peace” which he valued. He used to work on an offshore island where he was attacked by evil spirits. He said: “but after I became a Christian no more attack. I am very at peace”. He was also prompted by God whenever there was danger at work. He said: “I feel that sense the Lord is calling me to go there. The oil they forgot to shut the sampling point”, “my heart is not at peace. So, I have to go and check”. It helped him avert danger at work several times. In his daily life, sometimes, there were TV shows that made he “feel uncomfortable if you watch”. To him, this discomfort was the Holy Spirit telling him: “A, you cannot watch it, that thing is not good for you”. Hence, participant B also interpreted such a feeling as a reminder to be holy, he said: “because as Christians, we are called to be Holy. So, we don’t watch. This type of show, we off it”. Thus, being “at peace” was used by participant B as a test to discern if something was wrong as he said: “your heart is not at peace, always uncomfortable when something is wrong”.

Besides participant B, the other participants also mentioned being “at peace” during their interviews. This disposition was something that they acquired after they became Christians but could be lost. For instance, participant A took over the care of her mother immediately after her husband’s death but refused her mother’s offer to bequeath her flat to her. She told her mother: “Mum, I have my own flat, I don’t need, I just want a corner and live in peace”. Participant A had already achieved this peace that she wanted because others around her have observed that she does not look “down” and participant A also said: “nothing

bothers me now”. Based on what participant A had said, she valued the peace that she had achieved more than another flat; and she did not think this peace was a permanent attribute, but one that could be lost through her behaviour.

The other research participants also talked about being “at peace”. When asked about the impact of the Covid-19 pandemic, participant C said: “I have peace, I am not worried and all that. I know God will take care of that. No anxiety or this and that. I was quite calm. Whatever it is, God is in control. So, leave it to Him, surrender to Him”. In fact, earlier in our conversation when participant C talked about looking after her husband after he was stricken by a painful form of cancer, she said: “through his illness, I mean, the Lord really give me peace. Even though he's so sick when I was supporting him, I don't feel sad when I was helping him for a few years, I feel very peaceful...I feel that now he should be in the hand of God so feel more at peace”. Being “at peace” was participant C’s way of knowing that she is living according to God’s plan and “God will take care of” the situation.

Participant D talked about being “filled with peace”. She said: “those who believe in the Lord, they were at peace”. To her, those who experienced God would want to build a relationship with God and would understand His will (“you really experience...really experienced God, it becomes really different. You want to really build a relationship with God, Then, you will understand God's will..... all things hoped for have already been planned by God. When you follow God’s footsteps, that is hope that is your wish, no more problems”). When Christians follow God’s plan, they would be “at peace”. Hence, for participant D, being at peace was a disposition of those who believed in the Lord.

Finally, participant F also talked about being at peace. The religion of participant F's parents and parents-in-law was Shenism, and they required her to follow certain practices. By 27, participant F was already a mother of four children. Whenever her children fell sick, which happened frequently, she would be asked to consult spirit-mediums who would ask her to pray at certain cross-roads. Such practices frightened her. Participant F said: "last time I'm not Christian. I can be very frightened. Aiyo inside like ...can shake lah. I can shake.. Tremble like so scared this thing going happen then. Don't know what... But now with God, trust and obey lah I pray". Participant F: "previously I used to BaiBai but the more I pray, the worst it was... ... no peace". After she became a Christian, she said: "Now I have Jesus, I have peace and joy in my heart". Although both involved praying, she discerned the difference between the two because of the peace and joy she felt. Hence, for the research participants, being "at peace" was a disposition and an important discerning "test". Their ability to own or disown certain practices was aided by it.

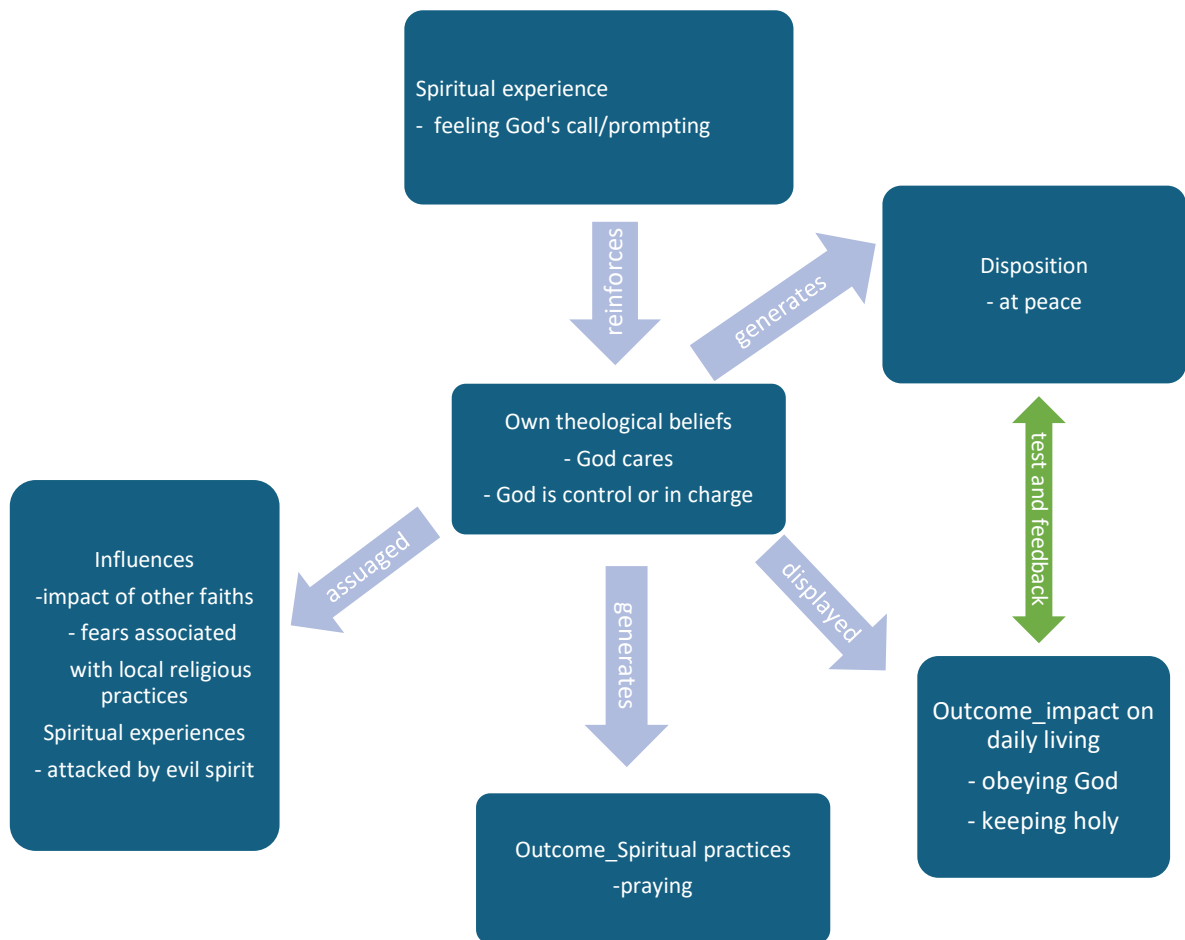


Figure 5: Pattern of discerning

VI.5.5 Pattern of retelling

During the interviews, all the research participants gave examples of how they look back at a past life event and retold it using their current Christian worldview. One notable point is that participant A did this during our interview for an incident that happened to her years ago. As a pioneer of her church, participant A had tried to organise Bible study for the ladies in the neighbourhood but “nobody turned up”. The church then organised cooking classes for the ladies. Participant A had paid for the classes but instead of attending class, she sat with an old lady outside the class because “she’s alone” “she wants the attention, to talk to her someone after her heart”. When participant A first described this incident, she said she did not mind “sacrificing” her cooking class, but she then lamented: “why am I so foolish to go and to sit with her rather than attend the class?”. However, when I suggested that perhaps she had seen the needs of the old lady. She pondered for a few seconds, then she reframed and saw the incident as God giving her a boost as she had strayed from her original objective. She had wanted to bring the ladies in to study the Bible, not learn how to cook. Participant A said: “These are the little things after you think it through. Why is it so funny that all these things fit into this, just to boost you up, maybe it is to boost me up. Boost me up so that I don't stray away and.. and learn cooking... I can't bring them to my Bible class, I can still do outreach. One by one. So, there's a lot of ways of thinking it”. In those few minutes while we were talking, she had changed her view of the event.

This reframing of past incidents using a Christian perspective had also happened in the other participants' lives. For example, participant B had developed a hearing problem more than 20 years ago. He had prayed for healing but was not healed. He said: "At times, I may think that why God you have forsaken me, why You don't heal me? You touch me You say 'heal' it will be healed". Instead of persisting along this line of thought, he explained that he had since changed his perspective based on his belief that God loves him and must have a purpose for not healing him. Participant B said: he "can function" because his ear "didn't deteriorate lah, every time there are new inventions to let me hear – hearing aid". He was "quite comfortable with everything God does" and "I tell the Lord, I trust Him. Even if He kill me or heal me".

In the case of participant C, she had retold her life story after she became a "more committed" Christian. She said: "After my husband passed away, I am left alone then I have more time. Then I have flashed back. Oh dear, good thing God guide me, or else I don't think what I would be.... first and foremost I was about to be given away. The couple came and take me.... my sister took me go and hide. Then how God stopped all these thingsSo I was saved. I didn't get given away. Given away to a very poor family some more. Rubber tappersThen I wouldn't be around here. That's why I say thank God". To put participant C's comments into context, Malaysian rubber tappers of her era were mostly poor. Many of them were unable to provide adequate healthcare for their children as they lived on huge rubber plantations far away from towns. As an adopted female infant, her comment about not being "around" was a real possibility. She also retold her husband's baptism as part of

God's plan: "Like my husband, you know how God touched him. He immediately say: "I'm going to get married. I want to marry you. Oh, but first I will get baptized first". I don't have to force him, you know.. It's all like written by God, all ready for you....see how blessed? Cannot be more blessed". Through the reframing of her life story using her Christian worldview, participant C felt blessed and thankful to God. It also reinforced her belief that her lived experiences were part of God's plan.

Participant D came from a traditional Chinese family where she was expected to obey her elders and not have independent thoughts. After discovering that she had become a Christian, her mother asked her to give up her faith and forbade her from going to church. Her mother broke her hand with a stick when she returned home after attending a Christian event at night. Her room was searched, her clothes and Bibles were torn. Participant D said: "they threw my things, continued to torture me, monitored my actions, watching me every day to see what I was doing". She was also slapped repeatedly for singing, "when I sing, she would slap my mouth, my elder sister slapped me". Her mother asked participant D's auntie who lived in town to persuade her to "leave this faith, leave Jesus. She said if I continue to believe in Jesus, she would want me dead that day....She wanted to remove my name from the family and would no longer acknowledge that I am her daughter". Participant D's auntie tried to persuade participant D by telling her that her friends who became Christians "were cheated by their pastors to do this and that" and "those pastors are just messing around". Participant D was not convinced by her auntie so her mother threatened to kill her with a noose and knife (see extract of D's interview in Annex B) lest she brings

shame to the family by “messaging around”. Participant D talked about how she suffered not only physically but mentally from such experiences as she was only in her early teens, and how she struggled between loving God and obeying her mother. However, by the time of our interview, she has reframed these experiences. She said : “The spiritual path is like a staircase, a ladder. If you have to slowly climb to the sky, you will definitely go through a lot of tribulations...After each tribulation, God sees that you have survived He will give another one and another one. But you become stronger after each torment, and when tribulation comes, you will not be afraid because after experiencing it, you know God will really help you, then what would you be afraid of?” Instead of striking fear in her, Participant D reframed all that she suffered at the hands of her mother as training so that she can become stronger. This reframe also allowed her to approach each of these as an opportunity to receive help from God.

Participant E converted to Christianity after the sudden death of his schoolmate when he was a teenager. He became frightened as his schoolmate’s death made him realized that life is fragile and he is not in control of life. However, he managed to reframe the uncontrollable, frightening event into something that is part of God’s plan: “So I, I do remember, being very shocked and frightened and sad that he passed away, but as to why God allowed that to happen. I can't say lah. I guess that I know that personally, I benefited for me, through his death that I came to know God lah. I know his family must have been very shocked and sad. Even their classmates must have been very shocked. I mean, I remember quite a number of us were at the funeral, at the wake. So yeah...I.. I.. I think God

has planned, sometimes we know things unexpected happen. And if we... make the wrong choices, it could lead us to a very different outcome”. The reframing helped participant E to fit this distressing event into his journey to become a Christian. With his reframe, it was something that God had control over and was also an important turning point on his faith journey.

The next example of reframing is from participant F. She had felt strongly that her whole family should all be Christians. In fact, one of the original reasons for her learning about Christianity was that her daughter had become a Christian. She said that: “Then I know, um, after my daughter shared, I was telling myself: yes, since the children want to be Christian, I know Jesus is the living God. I also like to come along with them and all in one family, same faith”. Hence, when one of her grandchildren started dating a non-Christian, she was uncomfortable with that. She quoted 2 Cor 6:14a: Do not be yoked together with unbelievers. She had struggled with this issue because she believed the Bible and had interpreted this verse as telling Christians not to marry non-Christians. By the time of the interview, she showed how she had reframed this by admitting that she cannot control the behaviour of “falling in love” and drew attention to the fact that non-Christians can become Christians, using herself as an example. She declared: “In love, you do not know. If God give them like that...last time I'm not Christian why now also Christian? God give people different timing lah... .now we plant, we go witnessing we also cannot say you come. We talk to them also God's timing to bring them. I'm not God. God's timing”. Hence, she told her grandchildren that if they fall in love with non-Christians, she expected them to work

hard to tell them about Christianity, “God said, equal-yoked. You all take not equal-yoked, you all must do hard”. This reframing allowed her to live with this “disobedience” of the Bible – she cannot control who falls in love with whom, neither can she “control” God who had allowed the couple to fall in love. This example also showed her ability to embrace paradoxes. Her understanding of the situation was not dualistic, being able to accommodate not only “right” or “wrong” but also “maybe”. She readily admitted she “do not know” but was able to offer her solution to manage the situation.

This pattern of retelling can be illustrated by the figure below.

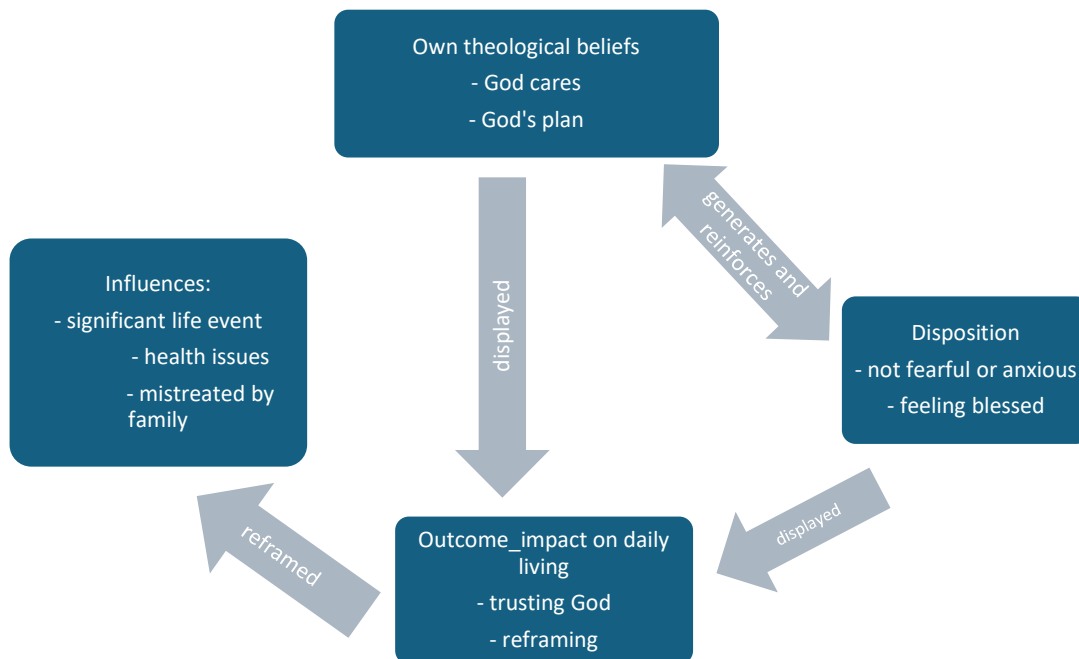


Figure 6: Pattern of retelling

VI.5.6 Patterns are themes

The patterns and the participants that presented them are listed below:

	Patterns:	Research participant					
		A	B	C	D	E	F
1	Pattern of holding on	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
2	Pattern of healing	Y		Y	Y		
3	Pattern of indigenising	Y			Y		
4	Pattern of discerning	Y	Y	Y	Y		Y
5	Pattern of retelling	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y

Table 17: Table of identified patterns

DeSantis and Ugarriza, (2000) proposed that a theme “brings meaning and identity to a recurrent [patterned] experience and its variant manifestations”. As such, it captures and unifies the nature or basis of the experience into a meaningful whole (as quoted in Saldaña, 2016, p.199). The patterns that I have identified fits into this definition as they

described the experiences of the research participants and its various manifestations across these participants. There was a terminology change in the IPA methodology during this research project such that the patterns displayed by an individual research participant is termed “personal experiential theme” (PET) and those patterns displayed across research participants are called “group experiential theme” (GET) (Larkin, 2021). Using this new terminology, the patterns in Table 17 are both PETs and GETs.

VI.6 Conclusion

The eight categories and five themes from the interview transcripts have addressed my research interest by providing an understanding of the research participants’ spirituality, the experiences that they believed contributed to their faith development and how they think their spirituality helped them stay positively engaged with life.

In the next chapter, the findings will be explored further in relation to wider literature to explore their significance for understanding the relationship between Christian spirituality and a positive engagement with life among these participants, i.e. older Chinese Christians in Singapore, and, potentially, other populations.

VII. Chapter seven - Discussion of Findings

This chapter discusses my understanding of how the findings discovered in this research project relate to my research question in the light of relevant literatures. I discuss the key beliefs and patterns that emerged through the data, the importance of the state of being at peace and the skills demonstrated by my participants. These findings were discussed in the light of the Singaporean faith context, highlighting ways in which my participants exhibited signs of hybridised faith and the active indigenisation of their faith, and in the light of the concepts of reframing and integration, highlighting how participants were able to adapt their faith to life's challenges. The faith development theories of Fowler and Westerhoff (mentioned in sections III.2.2.3 & 4) are used to gain a better understanding of the research participants' stages of faith development. Since these are widely used faith development theories, it is useful to see the extent to which they illuminate the data collected as a way of contextualizing this research within the wider faith development literature and a way of identifying gaps in understanding the faith development of these Singaporean OAs.

VII.1 Analysing the findings to answer my research question

My research purpose was to understand how the spirituality of my research participants contributed towards their positive engagement with life. What I found was that the selected research participants had their own theological beliefs which affected their dispositions and how they lived their daily lives including the spiritual practices that they engaged in. These theological beliefs helped form their Christian worldview which allowed them to reframe their lived experiences positively. They experienced healing and had the capacities to heal broken

relationships in their lives. They also had the discernment to own or disown practices that they had or encountered as they lived their faith. From their interviews, two of them showed that they were able to integrate local practices to indigenize their faith. Lastly, all the research participants were also able to be “at peace” and not be anxious about the vicissitudes of living as an OA in Singapore.

In the Western literature of faith development much of the attention has been focused on understanding and naming discrete and predictable stages of development as exemplified by the theories of Westerhoff and Fowler. My research was not designed to discover whether or not these theories apply in the Singaporean context, nor to articulate indigenous stages of faith development and yet because I was purposively studying not only older people but people of mature Christian faith I am interested to consider points of resonance and dissonance between these theories and my own findings, not least in order to know how relevant or not these theories are for use in my context.

Fowler speaks about faith that is adequate for the stage in life of each person. He believes that each stage “has the potential for wholeness, grace and integrity and for strengths sufficient for either life’s blows or blessings” (Fowler, 1995, p.274). My main interest in this research is to articulate the ways in which the faith of my participants strengthened them for life’s blows and blessings in order to support the faith of other older Christian adults in the Singaporean context. As I explore the skills and practices revealed by the data, I will, also note points of connection with and difference from both Fowler and Westerhoff’s theories.

VII.1.1 Key beliefs and the pattern of “holding on”

The first area to discuss is the research participants’ theological beliefs as these formed the foundation of their worldview. Referring to section VI.4.5 (in Chapter six – Findings), all the participants believed:

- i. God cares about them,
- ii. that He is in charge or in control of everything, and
- iii. He has a plan which they are a part of.
- iv. in heaven; and
- v. in the Bible

Fowler believes that both “form” (“structure”) and “contents” of one’s faith exert power in shaping a person’s life-sustaining, life-guiding meanings (Fowler, 1995, p.273). He described the contents of faith as consisting of centers of value, images of power and master stories. Centers of value are the causes, concerns or persons that consciously or unconsciously have the greatest worth to us. Powers are that which we align ourselves to sustain us in the midst of life’s contingencies, that which can be relied on in life or death. Finally, master stories are the stories that we tell ourselves and by which we interpret and respond to events that impinge on our lives. The five theological beliefs that were shared by all six research participants can be organized into these elements as follows:

Contents of faith:	
Centers of value	God’s care/love, Heaven

Images of power	God
Master story	God's plan (Bible)

Table 18: Contents of faith of the research participants

To a large extent, using Fowler's language, the "form" or "structure" of these contents is highly conventional in the Singaporean context. Fowler described the features of Stage III (synthetic-conventional) faith to include: using faith as a vehicle for creating a sense of identity and values. The Stage III person is acutely tuned to the expectations and judgments of significant others; and does not have their own identity and autonomous judgment to construct and maintain an independent perspective. He or she has an ideology but has not objectified it for examination and is unaware of having it. Its image of authority is located in the incumbents of traditional authority roles. Fowler pointed out that most church members are in Stage III Synthetic-conventional faith and my data indicated that most of my participants have characteristics of Stage III, with some having the characteristics of the stages V and VI.

Most of the participants' images of authority are their church leadership and their identities were significantly impacted by their activities within their church. For example, participant E's sense of belonging and identity is strongly linked to his involvement in church activities. Participant E said: "from my perspective, I will feel the belonging, I belong to the body if I'm serving, then I feel that I'm part of the body of the church or the body of Christ. If I am not serving, then I become an observer. Like an outsider looking in...".

Besides showing characteristics of Stage III, participant A also showed “identification with the species” (Fowler, 1995, pp.243–244) which is a characteristic of Stage VI Universalising Faith – where she felt compassion for the foreign workers that worked at a construction site opposite her block of flats. Participant A said: “Lord. I see opposite, I say: can You prevent them from having accident? They are contractors/workers opposite. You look at them, you look around you, you just say a simple word to God, lah”. Similarly, although participant F has many characteristics of Stage III, she was “alive to paradox and the truth in apparent contradictions” which is a characteristic of Stage V Conjunctive Faith. Within her closely knitted family, she said she wanted everyone to be “saved”, and they all became Christians eventually. However, when she was informed that one of her granddaughters had a non-Christian boyfriend, participant F struggled with the dissonance because of her understanding of 2 Cor 6:14a “God said equally yoked”. Then she referred to her own experience of having been a non-Christian previously and said that she would trust God, “if God give them like that (i.e. allowing them to fall in love)...last time I'm not Christian why now also Christian?”. She believed that “God give people different timing” to come to Him. Through reframing it, she saw this as an evangelising opportunity: “I tell my children, since y'all bring them, they're not Christian, this is the way that y'all have to bring them to Christ” “You all take not equal-yoked, you all must do hard”. Her openness to embrace multiple meanings and perspectives, plus ability to manage the tensions arising from this issue showed some characteristics of Stage V. As a whole, it was difficult to fit the six research participants neatly into Fowler's stages.

There are significant cultural critiques of Fowler's work that suggested the Western origins of his theory obscure rather than illuminate how faith develops in non-Western contexts. Fowler's theory is heavily influenced by structural developmentalists Piaget and Kohlberg as well as Erikson's work in psycho-social development (Fowler, 1995), all of whom have done their work in the Western context. One key reason suggested by critics that Fowler's theory might not be applicable outside the Western context was the material impact of the Enlightenment on his theory. In Fowler's own words: "the conception of faith with which faith development theory works is both made necessary by the Enlightenment and is part of the fruit of the Enlightenment's effort to "reform" religion" (Fowler, 1992, p.25). According to British practical theologian, Jane Leach, in the West the Enlightenment emphasis on the turn to the subject and the demythologising of symbols into more abstract concepts has made this a stage that educated Christians need to go through to reach a new equilibrium in which story and metaphor find a new place. In cultures that have not experienced the Enlightenment, the faith journey of individuals will inevitably be different (Leach, 1997). This is consistent with findings of Asian research from India and Japan, that have shown that the developmental sequences followed in their countries are different from those in Western societies. For instance, the Indian psychoanalyst, Kakar, in his study of the Indian childhood found that ego differentiation is "structurally weaker and comes chronologically later than in the West" (Kakar, 2004, p.104) because of a difference in "the pattern of their nurture" (Kakar, 2004, p.100).

Besides differences due to culture, another critique of Fowler's theory is based on the feminist critique of Piaget. Gilligan (Gilligan, 2016) and Slee (Slee, 2004) had pointed out that ego differentiation is much more relational in women even in the West as they are socialised into caring roles. Since Stage IV relies on notions of individuation, women are often described in terms of Stage III.

Based on my interaction with the local Chinese OAs, ego differentiation was also not an emphasis in their nurture. This is especially so for females. The first wave of Chinese migrants had strong ties with China until the Cultural Revolution (CR) where connections with overseas Chinese had serious adverse consequences for the Chinese in mainland China. Many Chinese traditions and customs that were prohibited/discontinued during the CR because of the call to destroy the "old four", i.e. old ideas, old culture, old customs, and old habits, were preserved by the Chinese in South-East Asia. These included Confucian teachings and many Chinese folk religious practices.

Singaporean Chinese OAs were strongly influenced by traditional Chinese teaching such as the Threefold obedience and Four virtues (i.e. San Cong Si De, 三从四德). The Threefold obedience requires females to obey their father before getting married; obey their husbands when they are married; and to obey their sons when they become widowed (未嫁从父, 既嫁从夫, 夫死从子). Research participant F was a typical female of that era, i.e. compliant and dependent on the males in her family. She would have been considered well-brought-up, making her a highly desirable daughter-in-law and wife when she was a young girl. For the local Chinese males, the common aspiration is for them to build up their own

moral character and knowledge; then to build up their family clans; to help govern the country; and then achieving peace for all under the sky (修身齐家治国平天下). Children were taught from a very young age that they should sacrifice personal interests for their communities such as families, clans, countries. With such expectations, the individual was not considered more important than the communities that he/she was a member of. For the local Chinese OAs, ego differentiation or individuation was not as important as survival and prosperity of the community.

Moving from one stage of Fowler's faith development stage to another requires the development of specific cognitive abilities, i.e. "structure". Most of the research participants did not seem to have the "structures" of Fowler's later faith stages (at least not apparent from their interviews), but their faith was able to support them in their old age. It makes sense then to look at how the "contents" of their faith helped them and if this can be used to develop a theory that is more applicable to local Christians.

To understand better the contents of the faith of my participants, I looked at their historical and cultural background. The research participants are all descendants of migrants from China. The Chinese have archaeological records of the supreme being, known as Di or Shangdi (上帝), dating back to Shang dynasty around 1600 years BCE. Shangdi is believed to have authority and control over the sociopolitical and natural realms (Poceski, 2009, p.8). He reigned over all other spirits and divinities, ruling over them as the king. He is often regarded as aloof and inaccessible, removed from people's everyday lives and concerns. The latter are managed by the other deities in his court and they are the ones that

the Chinese people would turn to for help instead of Shangdi, i.e. the specific deities in charge. During the transition from Shang to Zhou dynasty (around 1046 BCE), the supreme deity of the Chinese pantheon was replaced with 天 (pronounced as Tian and literally translated as the sky) with the additional attribute of being a moral force that was unambiguously good (Poceski, 2009, p.11). By the Autumn and Spring period (770-481 BCE), Confucius and his followers were advocating “respect deities/ghosts but keep away from them” (敬鬼神而远之). Confucius felt that there were already enough affairs of the living to manage, without having to take on ghosts/spirits (未能事人，焉能事鬼), hence his emphasis on the former. But this quote also shows that he believed in the existence of the supernatural and in fact, in the most authoritative Confucian writing, the Analects, he was recorded as saying that he learnt Tian Ming (天命), i.e. what Tian had commanded him to do with his life, when he reached fifty years old. Confucianism has a very strong influence over the local Chinese, not only because of their heritage but also due to the Singapore government’s emphasis on it especially under the government led by her first prime minister, Lee Kuan Yew, from 1959 to 1990.

From the above discussion, one can see that the first three of the five key beliefs listed above are not new to the local Chinese. For most local Chinese, it is not difficult to believe that there is such a supreme God. The question is: is the God of the Christian faith that supreme God? For the six research participants, their spiritual encounters played an important part in answering that question. Participant A (a second-generation Christian) saw Jesus at the foot of her hospital bed when she was hospitalized for an operation. Participant

B said the Holy Spirit “haunted” him to become a Christian and he also felt the Holy Spirit’s protection from the evil spirits at his workplace after he became a Christian. Participant C felt God’s presence and was comforted by Him during her husband’s illness and subsequently when she was grieving from his death. Participant D was a teenager when she was “touched by God” at a worship service, she then experienced several miracles including one that happened when her mother threatened to kill her because of her refusal to renounce Christianity. Participant E became a Christian after he studied and found the Bible believable, and his faith was strengthened when God answered his prayers at several key points of his life. Participant F became a Christian after attending Church services for several years when she felt God’s calling at a major evangelical event. She also felt His presence and was comforted when she prayed for His help during several family crises. These spiritual experiences reinforced their faith in God. Besides those initiated by God, the rest of experiences occurred as a result of prayer, an activity which all of them practised daily (see Table 12: Outcome_spiritual practices and their codes).

My next observation is that the five theological beliefs taken together were sufficient to allow the research participants to build a Christian worldview that is positive about living since it means: one believes in the almighty God taking care of him/her now and after death, with the Bible as a guide to meet his/her daily challenges. This is illustrated in participant B’s life (see section VI.5.1) where participant B said that he believed that God cares for him, he has no fear of death or aging because he will be going to heaven. He “want to do God’s will during the later part of (his) senior years, continue serving the Lord”, so he

volunteered actively in outreach programmes to help those that need help, and talked to them about Christianity. He said: “I feel happy serving people”. He was also “very happy” when one of them “receive Christ”.

From his work with OAs, participant B had recommended that: “for those who are not educated, it's just believe in the Lord. Just pray about it”, i.e. instead of the systematic study of the Bible, they should focus on a few beliefs and spiritual practices. This corroborated the above observation that only five beliefs were sufficient for the research participants to build a Christian worldview that allowed them to be positively engaged with life. Most of the local OAs that I worked with did not have good memories and had a low level of literacy like participant F, who was frustrated when she could not understand the preaching of her pastor because his “English is very posh”. She also felt “so stupid” because she said: “people take notes (during Bible study classes), I also cannot spell everything. Because don’t go to work, everything never write, Um Kee Teck (Teochew for: cannot remember) lah”. For OAs like participant F, focusing on a few key beliefs and helping them to “hold on” to key verses either from the Bible or hymns was more helpful for their daily living.

The next finding to discuss is the integration of local practices into Christian living, which shows that the research participants have indigenised their faith and were able to choose which practices to own or disown.

VII.1.2 Patterns of indigenising and discerning

Although the first London Missionary Society missionary set foot in Singapore in 1819 (Sng, 2003, p.31), to many Singaporean OAs, Christianity is still a “foreign” religion. According to a local researcher and pastor, Lee Chong Kau, “singing hymns with western melodies and hanging up pictures of Jesus looking very much like a westerner” did not help to correct the local Chinese OAs’ view that Christianity is foreign (Lee, 1987, p.10). This is corroborated by participant F who she said her grandmother used to called Jesus “番仔的老爷” (pronounced as Huan Kia Ke Lao Yeh, a Teochew phrase for: the foreigners’ God). There were many misconceptions about the early Christians because of the cultural and language barriers. Before the 1970s, the average Chinese families would frown upon their daughters mixing with male strangers outside their family gatherings as they risked gaining a bad reputation. Church activities were not something that the elders from traditional Chinese families appreciated because they did not want their daughters singing and interacting with male outsiders. They also did not understand the Holy Communion – some even thought that Christians ate human flesh and blood because of the Eucharist. Referring to the interview with participant D, her mother was adamant that she cannot be a Christian and even threatened participant D with death as she said: “I don't want you to live in this world “xia sway”(a phrase in the Hokkien dialect for: to bring shame upon) me”. Participant D’s auntie told her that Christian gatherings were gatherings to engage in immoral activities even though her auntie had not been to any church activities previously. The subsequent physical abuses and mental anguish suffered by participant D showed that new converts like

her needed help in understanding and better manage the key areas of conflict with the local culture so that their sufferings could be minimized. Although Participant D said that she “become stronger after each torment”, important lessons can be learnt by the local church and fellow Christians to help new converts especially in the light of Matt 11:28-30.

The other key barrier for local Chinese especially the oldest-old, is the language barrier because most of them do not understand English. Although there are Chinese Bible, the full meaning of certain words may not be easily translated into Chinese. For instance, Participant D told her mother that she would pray for her mother to have peace, but her mother said she did not want peace. The phrase participant D had used was “平安” because peace is translated into this phrase in the Chinese Bible, but “平安” has a narrower meaning than the “peace” as used in the Bible. Based on my interactions with local Chinese OAs, they use “平安” mainly to describe “security”, such as being safe or secured against mishaps, diseases, or even evil spirits. Participant D’s mother was in her 90s and Singapore is relatively crime-free and disaster-free. Safety or security would not be a key concern for her, even good physical health may not be her main concern, especially since she had already suffered through two bouts of cancer. She may even be weary of living; security was most probably not what she was looking for. According to the Bible scholar, Daniel Arichea, the term “peace” is used in at least five different ways in the New Testament: as (1) the absence of war or chaos; (2) a good relationship with God or Christ; (3) a good relationship among people; (4) an individual virtue or state, i.e. tranquility or serenity; and (5) part of a greeting formula (Arichea, 1987, p.201). All the research participants talked about being “at peace”

which I have categorised as having Arichea's fourth meaning of peace (see Table 8: Disposition and its codes). Since being "at peace" is a state, it would have been better translated into the phrase "心安". In the Analects, Confucius suggested that being at peace or not (安乎?) should be used by his disciple to discern if the latter's suggestion was appropriate (Lunyu: YangHou, on mourning vigil). As Lunyu was in Classical Chinese, most contemporary writers used this phrase "心安" to describe this litmus test that Confucius had suggested (further discussion on "at peace" can be found in the last discussion point of this chapter). Hence, using "平安" to talk to participant D's mother could have limited her understanding of "peace" as described in the Bible. This example shows the richness of the Chinese language and the granularity that one may need to go into when translating concepts from other languages into Chinese.

Christianity needs to be understood and practised in context, i.e. become a contextualized faith when it crosses culture otherwise it may cause sufferings such as the anguish experienced by participant D. James Engel, the Chair of Communications of Wheaton College for 18 years, wrote in his book "Contemporary Christian Communications: Its theory and practice" that contextualization requires thinking in three dimensions: an understanding of

- the original context of biblical revelation so that the essence of biblical meaning may be abstracted apart from the cultural context in which it was communicated.

- the cultural filter through which each interpreter must evaluate biblical texts so that contamination may be minimized.
- the cultural context of the hearer so that truth is communicated with true biblical fidelity (Engel, 1979, pp.266–267).

Engel wrote that becoming a Christian should not mean becoming de-cultured if he/she is originally not from a Christian country, instead the principle of dynamic equivalence should be used by (1) beginning with a proper hermeneutic; (2) find linkages between Christian ways and cultural patterns; (3) provide for a contextualised theology; (4) make every effort to avoid syncretism (Engel, 1979, p.275) which occurs when cultural elements that are intrinsically false or evil are assimilated into Christianity (Engel, 1979, p.283).

Contextualising the Christian faith to take into account cultural differences will produce diversity especially in how the faith is lived, but this is biblical as explained by Emmanuel Larney, Professor of Pastoral Theology and Spiritual Care at the Candler School of Theology, in his book “Postcolonializing God: New Perspectives in Pastoral and Practical Theology”. Larney interpreted the Tower of Babel story in Gen 11:1-9 as God, the Creator, recognizing the actions of the Shemites as a departure from the diversity of creation. “The oneness of language and culture had produced a hegemonic, power-hoarding, name seeking group of humans whose intention to dominate would be unchallenged (Gen 11:6). Their desire to control, dominate and conquer all, even the heavenly realm, would be unstoppable. The divine purpose implicit in the diversity of all creation, that there would be ‘checks and

balances’, many different voices to listen to, and a range of possible cultures to embrace, had been endangered” (Lartey, 2013, p.2). Hence, God confused their language and dispersed them. Lartey highlighted the three lessons learnt from this passage: First, that the existing diversity of languages and cultures is the result of divine redemptive action. Second, God prefers diversity. Third, God acts to affirm human diversity (Lartey, 2013, p.3).

Among the research participants, some attempted and were successful at contextualising their understanding of Christian concepts using local concepts. For example, participant A used the “kampung spirit” that she enjoyed while living in the kampung as a child, to explain her understanding of Christian living. This is an example of indigenising the Christian concept of a good neighbour using a local concept. When participant D became a Christian as a young teen, she attempted to interpret God’s command to honour one’s parents (Exo 20:12) using the local concept of “being filial” (see Annex B). Prima facie, these two concepts seemed similar but “being filial” as interpreted by the local Chinese of that era meant that the child should not contradict her parents at all especially in public, whereas Christians are expected to “obey your parents in the Lord” (see Eph 6:1a). When participant D’s mother insisted that she renounce Christianity and pray at their family altar (see Annex B), she disobeyed her mother publicly because she did not want to disobey God’s commandment to have no other gods before Him per Exo 20:3. Participant D said: “I can’t serve two masters, I said: God, I choose you today, I just want to serve you”. This act of disobedience in front of her whole village was interpreted as being unfilial by the young participant D. It caused her a lot of mental anguish which tormented her more than being

threatened, kicked and forced to kneel by her mother. As Singapore became a developed country, younger Singaporeans become more educated and savvy socially and technologically. The fact that they became better informed than their parents was inevitable. The local concept of “being filial” have changed because many children found that they could not obey their parents unquestioningly. As her understanding of “being filial” changed, participant D was able to reconcile it with God’s command to honour one’s parents and practise it in her Christian living. Despite her tumultuous relationship with her mother, participant D cared for her mother when the latter suffered from dementia. For participant D, the pain inflicted by her family to force her to renounce Christianity strengthened her faith in God. She said: “you become stronger after each torment, and when tribulation comes, you will not be afraid because after experiencing it, you know God will really help you, then what would you be afraid of?”.

Hence, their attempts to integrate local concepts into Christian living were positive for both participant A and D. However, remembering Engel’s warning that every effort should be made to avoid syncretism (Engel, 1979, p.275), there is a need to discern which local concepts/practices to own or disown and not integrate all local customs that the new Christian had been practising before conversion.

Participant B gave an example of having continued a local custom after he became a Christian and then eventually discarding it. After becoming a Christian, participant B continued to play mahjong. Among the local Chinese, it was acceptable to gamble as long as it is not compulsive gambling. In fact, it is customary to gamble during the lunar new

year festivities. On the eve of the lunar new year, it is a tradition for the children to stay up to 守岁 (pronounced as Shou Sui), i.e. “guard” the transition to the new year as a gesture to bless the family with good fortune and their parents/grandparents with good health in the coming year, thus longer lives. Mahjong or cards are played to keep everyone awake. Furthermore, during the 15 days of lunar new year festivities where relatives and friends gather, there will also be social gambling using the red packet or 红包 (pronounced as hong bao) monies exchanged. In addition, many local Chinese also play mahjong to socialise as participant B said: “we just want to have the fun of it”. Participant B said he gave up social gambling because “it's not the right way to become a Christian”. This is an example of what will happen once Christ takes central place in one's world, “shock waves flow from the center to the circumference” (Willowbank report cited in Engel, 1979, p.274), and this customary practice that participant B felt was inconsistent with his faith was disowned. This is also an example of discernment by participant B based on his understanding of God's will.

Even though there are many Christians converts among the Singaporean Chinese now, some cultural issues are still not satisfactorily addressed. One important but difficult issue to deal with is the practice of ancestral veneration. In her interview, participant A mentioned that her mother, who was a Christian, had asked her to buy flowers for a deceased relative “so and so want flowers, put it at the window” but participant A reminded her: “Mom, remember you are a Christian”. Participant A did not want to follow this practice because she did not think it was consistent with Christianity. They were a pair of mother-daughter

who have been Christians for many years, yet they had different understanding of ancestral veneration.

Daniel Tong, a local Anglican priest who had done more than 30 years' research on Chinese traditions and practices, wrote: "the traditional Chinese practice of ancestral veneration is syncretic, with no clear line drawn between acts of reverence and respect, and acts of worship...Sound biblical discernment, therefore, must be exercised with regard to this practice to determine that which is acceptable to our Christian faith. Rightly advocated and encouraged are the concepts of filial piety and social responsibility of mankind. The family unit is truly something Christians must diligently work to maintain, uphold and build. Though ancestral worship is not to be practised by believers, we should nonetheless learn the need to remember our dearly departed with thanksgiving. It is good for Christians to raise their children to remember their ancestors, as this would aid not only in the development of solidarity within the family, but also in the passing on (to the next generation) of the Christian faith" (Tong, 2012, p.113). Hence, despite it being difficult to draw a line between showing respect and ancestor worship, it should still be drawn so that the baby is not thrown out with the water. This is an especially sensitive issue because many Chinese families have family altars at home where tablets of deceased family members are placed and offerings are made regularly. New Christians are likely to struggle to set boundaries when participating in such familial activities.

Bearing in mind that five out of the six research participants were from a Shenist background, it is important to recognize that the contents of their faith had changed after

their conversion to Christianity. Shenism is polytheistic and the powers of a “Shen” are limited to adding a bit more to one's store of luck and slightly reducing one's ill-luck. Shenism's fundamental tenet is the belief in fate, that is, the belief that a person's life in this world is predetermined – one cannot escape one's fate. The key concern is to make the best use of one's predetermined quota of good luck and to minimize the effects of the predetermined quota of ill-luck (Wee, 1976, pp.171, 172). Hence, the content of faith for typical Shenists would include good luck as one of the centers of value, multiple “Shens” as images of power and an unchangeable life path as the master story. This difference in faith contents should be taken into account when contextualising Christianity for new converts to transit smoothly into Christian living and it is a difficult journey when undertaken without help.

The process of becoming Christian was not only one of discerning which key practices to discard and which to maintain. For the research participants, the process of contextualising their faith was an ongoing personal challenge. None of the research participants talked about how their churches helped them in this process. Fortunately, decades after becoming Christians, the research participants had contextualized their faith having the ability to own/disown selected local practices, live their faith within their social circles in an “at peace” state.

These patterns of owning and disowning local beliefs and practices illustrate the ways in which while the faith of my participants might be largely conventional, it is also highly “owned” even though Westerhoff stated that “few adults have owned faith”

(Westerhoff, 2000, p.97). According to Westerhoff, the movement from earlier faith stages to “owned faith” involves “conversion experiences which may be sudden or gradual, dramatic or undramatic, emotional or intellectual, but they always involve a major change in the person’s thinking, feeling and willing”, i.e. their total behaviour. Persons with owned faith “strive to witness their faith in both word and deed”, struggling “to eliminate any dissonance between their faith as stated in their beliefs and their action in the world”. The struggle of the “searching faith” stage continues but are dealt with in new ways. “Liberation, wholeness of life, spiritual health and identity are known and persons with owned faith can live a life in but not of the world”. (Westerhoff, 2000, p.95).

One major difference between the context in which Westerhoff was located and the context of my research participants is that of Christianity being a minority faith to which the majority of my participants were converted. This change in the contents of their faith was a conscious act and involved significant struggle leading to a strong sense of ownership.

The only exception was participant A who was a second-generation Christian and her faith development matched the path described by Westerhoff. She experienced Christian faith as a child, being born into a Christian family with “at least a pastor or missionary in each generation” on her father’s side of her family. She had happy memories of attending church service on Sundays and sought to continue this practice even after her family broke up after her father’s death. Based on her description, she went through the “experienced faith” and “affiliative faith” stages during those early days of her life. She then went through Westerhoff’s “searching faith” because she described a long period of “searching” as she

visited different churches on Sundays looking for one to settle in. Participant A said that she could understand those who “float around from one place to another place to hear the sermon”, saying “the sermon is no good, the pastor is no good, that is no good, church is no good” as she had also experienced this period of doubt and critical judgement. After years of searching, she found a church that had just been planted and has been there since, i.e. from 1966 to our interview date. As pioneers of the church, she actively knocked on the doors of residents living near the church with her pastor every night to invite them to come to the new church. She was also involved in organizing activities for those residents who did visit the church. She recalled the early days of her church fondly during our interview and commented about her “searching faith” days: “It is not that the church or sermon is no good, it is we are unsettled. The message doesn’t come into our hearts. We don’t accept it, that’s why, to us it’s 唔通 (pronounced as um tong, Cantonese for: did not make sense), so we cannot accept it. Until we are ready, then we go all out for it”. These comments showed that she has reviewed the struggles of her “searching faith” stage and was able to deal with the dissonance that she had previously. During our interview, participant A had a sense of calmness about her. She was living in peace and said she was just “passing through” the world. Her friends had observed that she was “not living in this world” and always “don’t look down”. She also showed the capacity to care for fellow humans. For example, she prayed for the construction workers when she saw how dangerous their working environment was. She was able to stand up for what she believed in. She described an instance where some attendees asked for restaurant-standard food in an outreach event for the needy. Even though the person in charge of the event was worried about offending the complainants,

VERSION_DEC 2025

participant A stood her ground and “put them in their place” because they were not “the needy” since they had children that brought them to restaurants. She also demonstrated during our interview that she was also able to resolve any dissonance between her faith beliefs and her actions through reframing (please see section VI.5.5).

The other five research participants came from families of origin who were Shenists. As Shenism is very different from Christianity, their conversions would have entailed a major change in the total behaviour of the research participants – something that Westerhoff described as a necessary feature of “owned faith”. Firstly, to become a Christian and join a local church, they would have renounced Shenism and dropped all Shenist practices. The typical Singaporean Shenist families have family altars at home and members of the family are expected to perform rites at these altars regularly e.g. the first and 15th day of each month on the lunar calendar, plus during important festivals such as Qing Ming and Hungry Ghosts Festival. On major festivals such as Qing Ming or Lunar New Year, ancestral worship sessions which involve all family members and even extended family members are held both at home and at the temples etc. Once the research participants became Christians, they no longer participated in such activities. They also went through baptism and adopted the discipleship practices such as those identified by Wesley, i.e. involvement in church activities, engaged in works of piety and mercy, developing Holy tempers. Hence, the change in their total behaviour would have been “major”.

They were all introduced to Christianity as teenagers but two of them, participants B and F, did not become Christians until much later in their lives. Participant B accepted

Christ “at the age of 38” and felt God’s presence and protection at his workplace where he had been previously attacked by evil spirits. However, his conversion process was a gradual one as he joined a church, a small group and started studying the Bible. He stopped the Shenist practices that he used to engaged in and over time, disowned other practices that he felt he should not have as a Christian e.g. social gambling. At the time of the interview, he said: “I want to do God’s will during the later part of (my) senior years”. He loves God (“He loves me so dearly, so how can I not love Him back?”) and “love people”. Thus, he spends his time volunteering in his church’s outreach programmes. Participant F also went through a gradual conversion process after she accepted Christ at an evangelical event. She stopped her Shenist practices “last time not Christian I think that, uh, end of the month, pray to the god of the house to protect the house, protect us, no sickness, no nothing. Now Christian, no more, no need to pray” to the god of the house. She became a member of her church, participated in church activities, learnt to pray, volunteered at her church and spoke to anyone who would listen about her Christian faith e.g. on the train. Participant F had felt that she was “nothing” previously but after becoming a Christian, she realised that she could tell others about her God, she said: “I reflect my life back. I say: God, You really use me ha. I am nothing. I always think I am nothing, You pick me from the darkness into light”. Her conversion gave her a sense of purpose and worth and changed her total behaviour. She also exhibited “owned” faith in that she “strive to witness to that faith in both word and deed” and she was also able to eliminate any dissonance between her faith as stated in her beliefs and their actions in the world (Westerhoff, 2000, p.95).

The three participants that became Christians as teenagers were participants C, D and E. Participant C's parents did not want her, so she was brought up by her sister. She studied in a Chinese primary school for three years and then was switched to an English medium Methodist primary school where she struggled because "ABC also don't know how to spell". Fortunately, she met one of her best friends there and they did everything together including going to Sunday school. Participant C said: "I think around end of Primary 5, I think, she got baptised, so I followed her. I also go and get baptized. Never read in detail. Blindly go and get baptized" "even though I become a Christian, I never touch the Bible. Just follow my friend to become a Christian". Participant C said: "I was quite active in the church lah, even though it's a Chinese church, picked up choir singing. Take part, when it's Christmas time, you go caroling and all that ... Social gathering, like that". She would have experienced faith and then affiliative faith at that stage of her life because according to Westerhoff, persons with affiliative faith "seek to act with others in an accepting community"(Westerhoff, 2000, p.91). They need to participate in the community's activities e.g. singing in the choir, having a part in the Christmas pageant, to be "wanted, needed, accepted and important to the community"(Westerhoff, 2000, p.92). When her sister married and left Malaysia, participant C moved to Singapore with her where she met her husband. After 46 years of life together, he passed away from a painful form of cancer. Participant C experienced the conversion experience described by Westerhoff after the death of her husband. Before that, she was "busy with children or him (husband), got no time for God, only Sunday go to church and come back that's all. Never read the Bible and all that". She had felt God's presence while she looked after her ill husband. So, after his death, she said

she “attend service, attend all the different, different activities in church. I wanted to know more about God.” That was when she had “searching faith”. She said that she felt “more closer to God. I really can feel His presence. I can really feel Him”. She was also able to resolve the dissonance between her faith and her past experiences (the belief that God cares vs having parents that did not want her) using her Christian worldview (refer to section VI.5.5 for details of her reframing). Hence, she has the key features of “owned faith”.

Participant D is the middle child in a large family where she said there was “no love”. Her father was a sailor who was hardly home and her mother “did not care” for her. Her first contact with Christianity happened at around 14 years old when she attended a church service. She said:” When I heard the hymns being sung, I was moved. I heard them and I was touched by God”. Her conversion to Christianity was immediate as she was touched by God and she said: “ I was in love with God” after that. Her behaviour changed significantly and was noticed by her family members. Her mother tried to force her to renounce Christianity through physical and verbal abuses but her faith was strengthened by various spiritual experiences included miracles (see section VI.4.6). She struggled to eliminate dissonance between her faith and her action in the world (section VI.5.3) and she declared that: “worldly things were not important to me anymore”.

Participant E also went through “ a major change” in his thinking, feeling and willing (Westerhoff, 2000, p.95), a feature of “owned faith” when he accepted Christianity at 18 years old. One of his friends had died suddenly when they were working together during school vacation. He said: “I always thought we can take care of ourselves, we don’t

need God” but the sudden death “began my journey questioning life, you know, the purpose of life? And what is life? And why, why is life so fragile?”. He started attending Bible study classes with a friend even though he was not a Christian and became a Christian after he found that the Bible was believable. Hence, there was a major change in his thinking. His behaviour also changed, for example, he resigned to go on a short-term mission trip even though it would have been difficult to find another equivalent job after that. He was also active in church, volunteered in church outreach programmes and is now a missionary.

Using Westerhoff’s theory, I could place my research participants in the “owned faith” stage, although participants C and F also showed characteristics of “affiliative faith”. Westerhoff’s stages are useful to me in recognizing the strong sense of owned faith in my participants. However, my criticism of this theory for its application in Singapore is that its last stage seemed easily attainable by local Chinese Christian converts. Christianity is not the dominant religion in Singapore, most of the Chinese Christians were from Shenist families. For them, becoming a Christian had required a major change in their total behaviour. Hence, for these new converts, this theory of expanding concentric rings may be an accelerated or short-circuited process and not a gradual expansion unless Westerhoff’s theory is also applicable to their lives after their introduction to Christianity but before they accepted Christianity as their new faith.

VII.1.3 Patterns of retelling and healing

Under the theme of retelling (section VI.5.5), the research participants used their Christian worldview to reframe their lived experiences to arrive at a different understanding

of such experiences. This Christian worldview was built based on their theological beliefs. The ability to reframe their lived experiences allowed the research participants to integrate or re-integrate (if they attempted integration previously) the lived portion of their lives positively. The term “integration” has a specific meaning in gerontology and it is used in this sense here. It is the process of putting one’s life experiences into a coherent whole to see meaning/purpose in it (Mehta, 1997).

VII.1.3.1 Reframing skills

Reframing was a term used by the three founding members of brief therapy in their book on change. According to Watzlawick, Weakland and Fisch, to reframe means to “change the conceptual and/or emotional setting or viewpoint in relation to which a situation is experienced and to place it in another frame which fits the “facts” of the same concrete situation equally well or even better, and thereby changes its entire meaning” (Watzlawick, Weakland and Fisch, 1974, p.65). Such changes could be first-order change that occurs within a given system which itself remains unchanged; and second-order change that alters the system itself. Both types of changes are useful but there are situations where first-order changes only create more of the same and are ineffective. The American pastoral theologian, Donald Capps in his book “Reframing – A new method in pastoral care” showed how reframing was used by Jesus to bring about second-order changes. He also identified 13 techniques of reframing (Capps, 1990, pp.28–50) including dereflection, surrender tactic, providing a worst alternative, paradoxical intention, relabeling and benevolent sabotage. These six named

techniques were found in the interview transcripts with my research participants though none of the research participants mentioned that they were trained in such reframing. The following are examples of these techniques used by the research participants:

VII.1.3.1.1 Dereflection

Dereflection is the reframing technique where one uses something else to detach from the problem to a more positive object (Capps, 1990, pp.30–31). Participant A was upset with her noisy neighbour (e.g. screaming in the night), after she had given them feedback about keeping the noise level down at night to no avail. Instead of “cursing” them or praying for them to be changed, she reframed the problem and asked for herself to be changed. Participant A said: “I always say, give me the patience or give me... increase my focus on You so that I don’t focus more on this earth”.

She shifted herself out of the worldly frame to focus on God, thus not allowing her peaceful way of life to be disturbed by her neighbours’ behaviour. This is a practical way of managing disputes with neighbours in Singapore because 80% of the locals live in public housing flats, in close quarters with multiple neighbours. Being embroiled in disputes with neighbours is not uncommon and can be highly disruptive to one’s life. Moving away is normally not a good option because there are many regulations that make it difficult to sell and then buy another public housing flat. Furthermore, one could be moving from one set of difficult

neighbours to another set of neighbours who is just as difficult or even worse. Participant A's ability to reframe not only is helpful in developing her relationship with God, it also improves her living standard by reducing the annoyance that she felt and the potential danger that she may encounter as a female OA living alone with neighbours who might be offended if she complained against them.

VII.1.3.1.2 Surrender tactic

Participant B has a hearing problem and had prayed for healing for many years. However, the healing had not materialised. Instead of seeing this as God not caring for him, he decided that it must be serving a purpose that he did not understand; and surrendered the situation to God saying that he will wait for God. He said: "At times, I may think that why God you have forsaken me, why You don't heal me? You touch me You say: "heal", it will be healed. The Word is power. So I think everything God does there is a purpose, so at least I can hear and pass the day, then I am ok. Wait till the Lord say: "my son, you will be healed".

VII.1.3.1.3 Providing a worst alternative

Participant C was to be given away as an infant but her elder sister hid her from her prospective adoptive parents and brought her up. This was how she reframed the event: "I was about to be given away. The couple came and take me.... my sister took me go and hide. Then how God stopped all these thingsSo I was saved. I didn't get given away. Given away to a very poor family some more. Rubber tappersThen I wouldn't be around here. That's why I say thank God".

She reframed her lived experience of nearly being given away into a rescue from a tragic life (the worst alternative). After the passing of her husband, she was lonely and grieving, and this reframe helped moved her out of that into a “thankful” stance. It allowed her to see that God was in control, looking out for her from her birth and that she was never alone.

VII.1.3.1.4 Relabeling

Participant E converted to Christianity after the sudden death of his schoolmate. He became frightened as his schoolmate’s death made him realized that life is fragile and he is not in control of life. However, he managed to relabel the uncontrollable, frightening event into something that is part of God’s plan:

“So I, I do remember, being very shocked and frightened and sad that he passed away, but as to why God allowed that to happen. I can't say lah. I guess that I know that personally, I benefited for me, through his death that I came to know God lah. I know his family must have been very shocked and sad. Even their classmates must have been very shocked. I mean, I remember quite a number of us were at the funeral, at the wake. So yeah...I.. I.. I think God has planned, sometimes we know things unexpected happen”.

VII.1.3.1.5 Benevolent sabotage

According to Capps, this reframing technique involves taking a one-down position, based on a frank admission that one is unable to control the other’s behaviour. The key element is that the desired behaviour is clearly stated (Capps,

1990, p.38). Participant F used this technique to manage a situation which was difficult for her. She brought up this subject during our interview and quoted 2 Cor 6:14a: Do not be yoked together with unbelievers. She struggled with this issue because she felt that the Bible should be obeyed. However, she also knew that not just her, her grandchildren also could not to control themselves to only fall in love with Christians. By the time of the interview, she showed how she had reframed this by admitting that she cannot control the behaviour of “falling in love” and drew attention to the fact that non-Christians can become Christians, using herself as an example. She said: “In love, you do not know. If God give them like that...last time I'm not Christian why now also Christian? God give people different timing lah... .now we plant, we go witnessing we also cannot say you come. We talk to them also God's timing to bring them. I'm not God. God's timing”.

Hence, she told her grandchildren that for those whose spouses are not Christians, she expected them to work at bringing them to the faith. This reframing allowed her to live with this apparent “disobedience” of the Bible – she cannot control who falls in love with whom, neither can she “control” God who had allowed the couple to fall in love. By admitting her helplessness, it allowed her to stay true to the hymn that she had memorized, i.e. that she “trust and obey” God and then “God will make a way”.

VII.1.3.2 Reframing and healing

The frame that one uses to interpret an event affects the conclusion drawn. Being able to reframe to see situations from a Christian worldview allowed the research participants to draw conclusions that are coherent with their Christian faith and created space for healing to take place. For example, participant C became thankful and felt blessed instead of feeling upset with her parents for wanting to give her away. Participant D was able to forgive her mother for her abuses and saw them as opportunities to “become stronger” and to receive God’s help. Reframing helped them to heal their relationships with their parents. From the findings, reframing did not seem difficult since all research participants were able to do it. In fact, participant F demonstrated that she could reframe the Christian story for the Singaporean context where Christianity is not the dominant faith. As such, she demonstrated some characteristics of Fowler’s Stage V – being alive to paradox and the truth in apparent contradictions, and striving to unify opposites in mind and experience.

VII.2 The importance of the state of being “at peace”

VII.2.1 The state of being “at peace”

All the research participants talked about being at peace with God and themselves. Most of them went through suffering in their earlier years, including mistreatment by their own families. Those who had broken relationships especially with their mothers, were able to heal those broken relationships as they lived their Christian faith. One reason was their ability to reframe their past experiences using their Christian worldview (see

section VII.1.3.2 above). This Christian worldview allowed them to keep their life purpose in mind when reviewing their lives, see themselves in God's plan and accept their lives as lived. This state of being "at peace" could be compared to the results of achieving ego integrity in Erikson's 8th stage or the result of being able to manage dissonance in "owned faith" described by Westerhoff. This state also reminds me of the result of "integration" in old age that Mehta discussed in her paper "The effects of religion on subjective aging in Singapore: An interreligious comparison." (Jianbin and Mehta, 2003). She wrote that: "At advanced old age when life's journey is ending, the need for integration increases" largely because of "the heightened awareness of the reality of death and the attendant search for meaning to one's life". She defined "integration" at this stage as a complex, multidimensional subjective process through which the individual connects various parts of his/her life into a meaningful whole. From her research, she concluded that "religion can play an integrative role, which facilitates personal adjustment to the aging process" (Mehta, 1997). Following this line of thought, their Christian faith allowed the research participants to go through the integrative process to arrive at the state of being "at peace". But this state can be lost as participants A and B mentioned in their interviews.

VII.2.2 As a discerning tool

Since it is a state that can be lost, some participants used it as a test to make decisions in their daily lives. For instance, participant A said that she did not accept her mother's offer of her flat because she thought it would disrupt her peace. Participant B said he had averted major incidents at work because he checked for problems when his heart is

“not at peace”. He even used it to decide which shows to watch, he said: “you feel uncomfortable if you watch the show.... we off it”. Although the participants did not specifically give an account of the first time they reached this state of being “at peace”, they talked about the acts associated with this state. For example, participant B said: “Only the church, only go to the church I have a peace of mind” when he started attending church. Participant E said he was going for a major operation and was fearful, but “many people started to pray for me. And then after two days, I felt peace, the fear of dying sort of went away”. Participant A linked this sense of peace to choosing Christian living and not wanting “all these (material) things”. Participant D said that “those who believe in the Lord, they were at peace” and participant C said that she felt at peace because she believed that God is in control. Participant F said that she felt peace and joy when she “trust and obey...pray” to God. Hence, maintaining the attitude of believing in and obeying God (see Table 11 where “trusting God” were coded in all six transcripts), and performing practices such as praying and going to church helped the research participants to stay “at peace”.

VII.3 The skills demonstrated by research participants

Based on the discussion above, the research participants had demonstrated ‘owned faith’ albeit within a largely conventional framework. The skills that helped them to develop their faith. are tabulated below according to where they were demonstrated.

	Patterns:	Skills:	In transcripts of:
1	Pattern of holding on	Able to find oneself in the Christian master story	All
2	Pattern of healing	Able to reframe their past experiences using the Christian master story	A, C, D
3	Pattern of indigenising	Able to own or disown local concepts	A, D
4	Pattern of discerning	Able to own or disown practices	A, B, C, D, F
5	Pattern of retelling	Able to reframe their past experiences using the Christian master story Able to embrace paradoxes and reframe the master story	All F

Table 19: Skills demonstrated by the research participants

From the interaction with the research participants, I sensed the need for them to be hold on to their Christian faith. This could be due to the fact that five of them were converts and the only second-generation Christian went through a long and difficult “searching faith” process. They demonstrated that they could find themselves in the Christian master story and play their roles. This skill is not necessarily demonstrated by all Christian converts.

From the examples cited in the pattern of healing, we can see that an important skill demonstrated by the research participants was the ability to reframe their lived experiences. This ability to reframe was also demonstrated in the pattern of retelling. In her retelling/reframing example, Participant F also demonstrated the ability to embrace paradoxes where she showed that she could manage the situation when her understanding of the Bible was contradicted. She was able to reframe her master story to accommodate this. Finally, most of the participants demonstrated that their ability to own/disown local practices/concepts in order to live their faith in their daily lives. These skills may not be all that is needed to support local OAs in their old age but they were useful to these six research participants to arrive at their current state of being positively engaged with life.

VII.4 Conclusion

Referring to chapter VI and the discussion in this chapter, my observations with respect to their Christian spirituality, i.e. lived reality of their faith, showed that all the six research participants were at the “owned faith” stage. They have a Christian worldview which allowed them to live positively in their old age. Although 36 beliefs were talked about during our interviews (refer to Table 13 Own theological beliefs and their codes), the five key beliefs that all of them shared were the key pillars in this worldview. Their ability to reframe their lives as parts of God’s plan is important as that gave meaning to their existence. They also demonstrated the ability to reframe key events in their lives, especially losses and abuses, into necessary parts of their master stories. Thus, allowing these sufferings to make sense to them. Some of the research participants contextualised their faith to incorporate local concepts/practices instead of trying to

de-culturing themselves once they became Christians. At least one of the research participants also demonstrated the ability to embrace paradoxes – going beyond the duality of “right” or “wrong” and embracing multiple perspectives and being conscious of the limits of her understanding. They were also able to maintain the state of being “at peace” through spiritual practices such as attending church services, praying, and holding on to key verses.

Given my primary interest has been to support the spirituality of Christian older adults, I believe that the most significant findings of this study relate to the faith contents, practices and skills that belong to the “owned faith” of these participants. In the next chapter I synthesize these findings as my contribution to knowledge and as a basis for my contribution to practice.

VIII. Chapter eight – Contributions to knowledge and practice

This research has revealed the contents of the research participants' faith, the skills and practices that have kept them positively engaged with life. This information will help in designing interventions for local OAs and the results of such interventions could stimulate more research interest and support for spiritual interventions for OAs.

VIII.1 Contribution to knowledge

VIII.1.1 A local model of faith development

The six research participants did not fit neatly into any of the stages of Fowler's faith development theory but there was enough evidence that they have "owned faith" theorised by Westerhoff. They were at peace in this stage as they have skills and practices to help them do so: (1) they were able to find themselves in the Christian master story so that they are part of God's plan and their existence has meaning; (2) they were able to discern and decide which local practices/concepts to disown or own in their Christian living; (3) they could also reframe their lived lives, i.e. review their lived experiences and see them as part of their master stories. One of them also displayed the ability to embrace paradoxes and reframe her Christian master story. For more details, please refer to Table 19: Skills demonstrated by the research participants in chapter VII. These skills are organized and presented in the spiral figure below. The spiral indicates the movement within the "owned faith" stage as different skills developed and are demonstrated. The ability to find themselves in the Christian master story to make it their own is placed first because upon conversion, this was what the research participants did. The ability to embrace paradoxes is

placed last among the skills on the spiral because it is wisdom which, if it develops, tends to develop much later in life. The straight arrow represents the faith journey and “conversion” is written in blue font to highlight it as an important point of this journey. After conversion, the research participants started their transformation towards the target of developing “Universal love” as they seek to become more like Jesus.

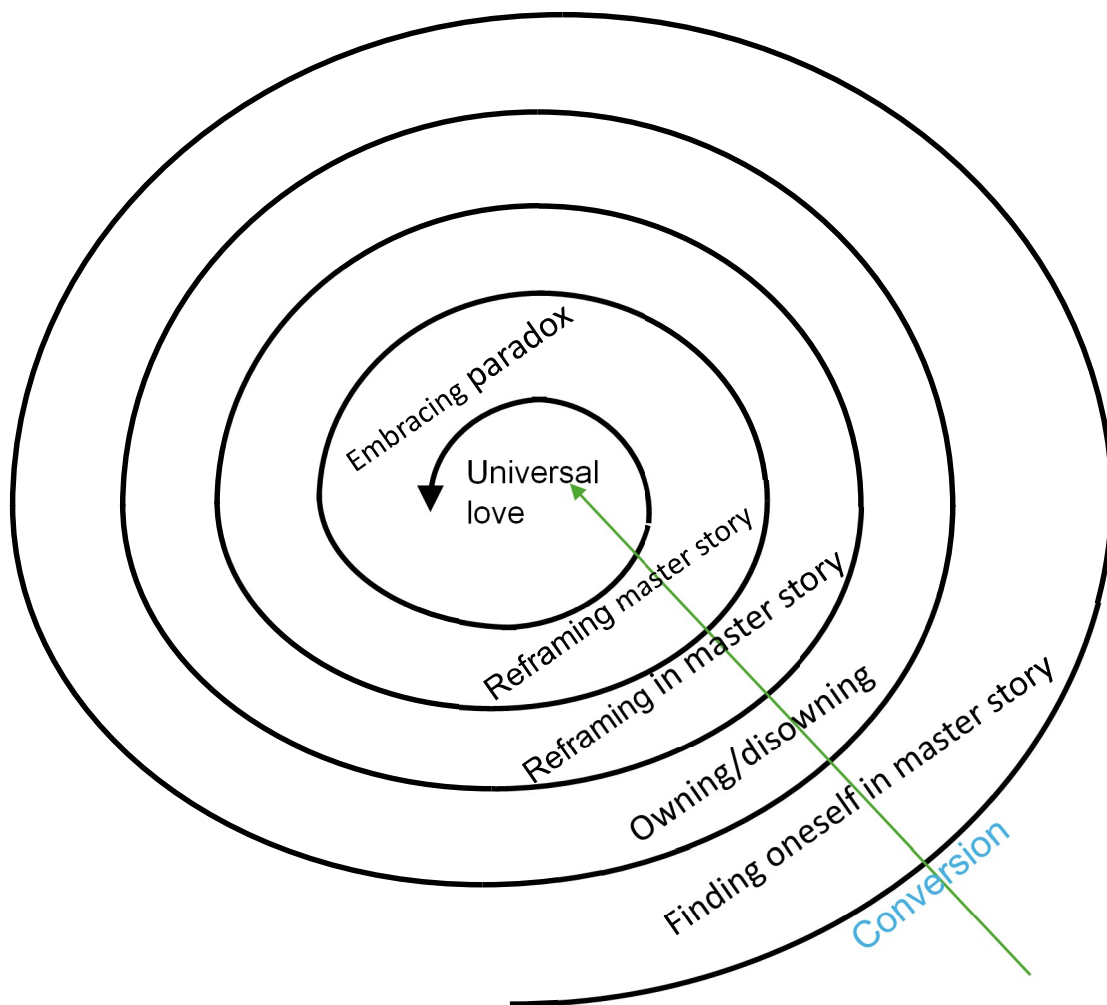


Figure 7: Skills demonstrated by research participants

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Although this finding arose from only six participants, it suggests a way of understanding the faith of local Chinese Christian OAs and could be tested in a larger population of such adults. In addition, the concentration on the development of “owned faith” suggests that this model may be relevant to Christian converts in other contexts.

VIII.1.2 Master stories and theological beliefs of the research participants

As mentioned in the last chapter, the five key beliefs shared by all the research participants were sufficient to build a worldview that is positively engaged with life. These beliefs are the key contents of their faith – showing what they valued, the power that they relied on and their master stories. The latter are the stories that we tell ourselves and by which we interpret and respond to events that impinge on our lives. They disclose the ultimate meanings of our lives (Fowler, 1995, p.277). After conversion, the research participants were able to find themselves in God’s plan, giving meaning to their existence. This finding is consistent with Mehta’s finding that religion helps the individual make meaning with his/her lived life (Jianbin and Mehta, 2003). The research participants are in their old age and have spent most of their lives, that means if the lives that they lived did not serve a purpose or the purpose is no longer valid, it is difficult for them to be positive about life. By believing that there is a caring God who has planned for and been in control of their lives, helped the research participants integrate their lived experiences into a coherent life with purpose. In addition, the belief that they are destined for a better place, i.e. heaven, gives them hope even as their bodies fail.

The five key beliefs identified as being important to the six research participants are likely to be useful to other Christian OAs. They can be used as the basis for OAs to explore their own theological beliefs, their worldviews, and how these beliefs and worldviews have impacted their outlook of life in old age. In other contexts, core beliefs might vary from this but the idea of inviting people to explore, discuss and consciously own their beliefs could be useful in clarifying their worldviews and the incongruencies that could be making them negative about their lives.

VIII.1.3 Owning and disowning local concepts and practices

The research project has highlighted the gap in supporting new converts when they were contextualizing their newfound faith for daily living. From the interviews, the research participants learnt to manage the owning/disowning of local practices and concepts on their own. Although they gained greater understanding of their faith through such struggles as suggested by participant D, there is also a risk that some might give up and acquiesce or use inappropriate compromises when they encounter such challenges. The local churches have been dealing with this issue of contextualization for many years but new converts continue to struggle with these same local concepts/practices such as being filial, and respect for ancestors (discussed in section VI.5.3 above) indicating a gap in communication and support here.

After decades of living their faith, the litmus test that the research participants used for discerning what to own/disown is the state of being “at peace”. From their descriptions, this “at peace” can be a state of tranquility/serenity or the result of a good relationship with

God, referring to Arichea's descriptions of how the term "peace" is used in the New Testament (Arichea, 1987, p.201). More research is needed to understand this test better but it is useful to have identified the two states of being "at peace" that were important to these OAs. Being "at peace" shielded them from negative emotions and could be useful to other OAs too. This finding provides evidence to support further research on how to help people achieve this state including helping to navigate owning/disowning as culture shifts and changes.

VIII.1.4 Spiritual practices of the research participants

In the owning/disowning process, the research participants talked about using "at peace" state as a tool. They also talked about the practices that give them peace, i.e. going to church and prayers, besides maintaining a "trust and obey" attitude towards God (see section VII.2.2). In discussing their spiritual experiences, praying was their main way of encountering God. These spiritual experiences which included encounters with Jesus and answered prayers, were important in cementing the participants' faith.

Further, referring to the table of their spiritual practices, the five that were practiced by all research participants were: attending church and small group, praying, "quiet time" with God and studying the Bible (see Table 12). For the research participants, "quiet time" is a time slot set aside to pray, read the daily devotional such as "Our Daily Bread" and read the Bible. Attending church and small groups also involved praying. Hence, the key spiritual practice for the research participants is praying. Meditation is notably missing from table 12. This is an area that could be explored for OAs to create more spaces for them to

be in God's presence. This is to put oneself in the way of spiritual experiences and being formed by God's universal love, and is different from skills and tasks. It would involve increasing the range of spiritual practices.

VIII.2 Contribution to practice

VIII.2.1 Targeted Christian education for Christian OAs

At the time of the interviews, I noted that the research participants attended small group meetings (see Table 12) regularly but most did not attend other Christian classes even before the Covid-19 pandemic. The participants' small groups met regularly for worship, discipleship, fellowship and outreach (except during part of the pandemic). Because of the myriad of purposes, their small group meetings were not suitable for targeted education. From the findings of this project, classes to develop the skillsets shown in Figure 7 above would be helpful to OAs. For example, reframing techniques can also be taught to those who have not reviewed their lived lives and are struggling to find meaning in them. Each OA can be assessed so that they can be organized into appropriate groups according to their faith maturity, literacy and skills. This would include compiling a list of their existing skillsets so that, for instance, they do not attend training in reframing if they are already trained in that. This targeted education can include helping the Christian OAs develop their Christian worldview. The findings from this research had shown that five key beliefs were sufficient to form the foundation of the research participants' Christian worldview. These could be used as the baseline for discussion with OAs. The OAs will be encouraged to explore their own beliefs and worldviews as well as their impact on the OAs' outlook of life.

For my own practice, I plan to work with my church to organize classes for Christian OAs who are interested in understanding their faith development. The objective of these classes is to help the participants self-assess and reflect on their faith journeys to learn where they are and where they want to be on their faith journey. Using the list of beliefs found in this project, the attendees will be encouraged to discuss their theological beliefs and how these have changed their daily living including their dispositions, the work they do and their spiritual practices etc. They will also be encouraged to share any spiritual experiences that they may have encountered. Again, the findings of this project will be useful for such classes – the spiritual experiences can be shared after anonymization to initiate discussions. The theories of faith development from Westerhoff and Fowler will be discussed as an option for those classes where the attendees are attuned to Western culture. Otherwise, only the model in Figure 7 will be discussed. Hence the classes will be organized by their educational background, besides by cohort and language used. They will be kept small, i.e. maximum five persons per class, to facilitate sharing and ensure confidentiality is preserved. The information shared in the classes will be collected to aid my future research with the written consent of the attendees. Each attendee will also have a one-to-one session so that the attendees will have customized maps of their faith development journeys and destinations. They will also be introduced to reframing so that they can decide if they want to attend training in reframing. As discussed in section VII.1.3, there are many reframing techniques available and they are not difficult to use as demonstrated by the six research participants in this project. The purpose of the reframing training is to teach the OAs reframing techniques. They will be encouraged to share one past event or an issue that has

significantly impacted them so that the session is grounded in their lived experiences. The reframing class will also be interactive because the attendees could have their own reframing techniques which I can learn from.

VIII.2.2 Greater emphasis on increasing spiritual experiences

Currently, members in my church are divided into small groups called “Life groups”. A Life Group acts as a Bible study and fellowship group, and is the primary place of care and ministry as they are the “basic building blocks” of the church. There are life groups for OAs but OAs are also found in other life groups such as those for ladies or couples etc. This is because having members organized into small groups is the tradition of my church so many members grew old in their groups.

Starting with the OA life groups, there could be greater emphasis on creating space for spiritual encounters with God. The research participants said they had daily quiet time with God and most were able to pray anywhere and anytime. Hence, they had more opportunities for spiritual encounters. Bearing in mind this finding, there should be greater emphasis on waiting upon God as spiritual experiences had strengthen the research participants’ faith. Together with the research results, I plan to research and organize a pack for these OA life groups emphasizing prayer as the space to encounter God. This is not to de-emphasise the needs and prayer requests of these OAs but to encourage them to look at prayer from a different perspective, i.e. as a chance to *wait* upon God and sense His presence. Another practice notably missing from my research participants’ table of spiritual practices

is meditation. This is the other area that I plan to research into to increase spiritual encounters with God.

VIII.2.3 Publicising Biblical understanding of local practices

As mentioned earlier in section VII.1.2 above, the participants had struggled with owning/disowning local practices on their own. The theological interpretation of local practices is important to help the local Christians contextualise their faith, there should also be practical implementation guides (e.g. Christian living in a Shenist family) that are acceptable to the local community to avoid any unnecessary guilt or fear on the part of the new Christian and misunderstanding or misgiving on the part of their non-Christian family and friends. For my own practice, I plan to compile a booklet of those local practices that have been discussed in published books or articles with their theological interpretation and implementation guide for discussion with the church pastoral team. The purpose is to get the church's approval so that these can be shared with selected OA life groups. There could be a pilot project to get feedback on their experiences with these practices. A report will be submitted to the pastoral team after the pilot and further research or follow-up will be discussed with the team.

VIII.3 Learning journey for me

As mentioned in chapter II, this project has been transformational for me. Not only did I learnt how to create space for God to show His grace e.g. through prayer times, more importantly, this project has changed my outlook towards living. I used to feel guilty when I am not actively “doing” something but my health did not permit a busy lifestyle now, hence I go through emotional

cycles of ups and downs. I was also “triggered” by the health and care issues raised by the OAs that I worked with. Having learnt how the research participants lived their core beliefs, I examined my own core beliefs and realized that I have not been living them. This realisation made it possible for me to truly accept that I am part of God’s plan and need to flow with it. With my new slogan of “accept and flow”, I have been able to manage the recent bouts of illnesses/hospitalisation without big mood swings. Although there was sadness, there was also thankfulness because I know where we are heading. Hence, for me, this learning journey has been valuable and necessary.

VIII.4 Limitations and Future Research

The research participants for this project were Chinese Christian OAs who were selected because they were positively engaged with life. Because of these very specific selection criteria, the sample was not representative of the larger population of OAs nor of the Christians of Singapore. It describes the experience of a specific aging cohort. Later cohorts will have had a different social and educational experience and this may shape their spiritual experiences and needs differently. Hence, the findings of this study cannot be generalized. These findings are useful though for the study of other cohorts, such as those of other age ranges, other ethnicities and religions. The next project that I would like to undertake would be to understand the spirituality of Christian Indian-Singaporean OAs who are positively engaged with life. The Indians are the next largest group after Chinese among the local Christians. Many of them are also converts like the Chinese OAs. Going forward, with appropriate support and funding, future research projects on Muslim OAs, Buddhist/Taoist OAs and those OAs without professed religions would allow local gerontologists to have a better understanding of the diverse spirituality of local

OAs and how to support their spiritual needs effectively in old age. In addition to using the methodology from this study to study other cohorts, a further area of research concerns the way in which the state of “being at peace” functioned for this cohort. I am interested to know how culturally specific this criterion is for Christian discernment, and to know more about how it is experienced and used as a principle for integrating faith and life.

VIII.5 Conclusion

Through this research project, pictures of the lived reality of the research participants’ faith were revealed allowing an assessment of how it supported them in old age. Their faith stages were also compared against seminal theories of Fowler and Westerhoff to determine their applicability to the research participants. Westerhoff’s theory was a better fit because Fowler’s theory is more embedded in the Western culture as compared to Westerhoff. Notwithstanding, both aided in developing a model of faith which I have trialed with a fellow Christian who found it to be enlightening for her. Given that the research design, the findings is not generalizable to a larger population but the project has met its research purpose and highlighted areas for fruitful research e.g. the state of being “at peace”, its implication for OAs and how it could be attained; whether a similar state of spirituality would support Christian OAs of other ethnicities etc. Furthermore, the findings will be used to develop customized classes and information packs for OAs that I work with. The feedback and lessons learnt from these will be compiled and used to generate questions for my future research with other ethnic and faith groups.

Annex A

Questions for semi-structured interviews:

Basic data gathered as part of screening for research participation

1. *Health status: cognitively unimpaired and able to give informed consent*
2. *Age: at least 65 years old*
3. *Community-dwelling: with family members or alone with/without domestic helper*
4. *Language used: English or other languages/dialects*
5. *Gender*
6. *Employment status*
7. *Religious affiliations, if any*
8. *Inclination to talk about their spirituality: prepared to be interviewed on this or not?*

A. Understanding context and rapport building - life history of participant:

1. Can you tell me about yourself?

Prompt to focus answer: Everyone has ups and downs, we can start with joyful experiences or joyful periods of your life.

2. How about other events/experiences that you consider life-changing or turning points in your life?

Prompt: to cover sad events or any other events that is life-changing

3. What are the experiences that helped you grow as a person?

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4. What experiences contributed to the development of your spirituality?

Follow-up explanation: By spirituality, I mean your religion, purpose or meaning in life, or your connection with God.

5. As you look back, what has given your life meaning/purpose? For instance, it could be your work, relationships, faith or social status etc.

Follow-up questions: Given that these give your life meaning, how do you attain or maintain them e.g. what do you do or not do? Prompt for beliefs and practices to better understand them.

B. Details of phenomenon:

1. Earlier in our conversation, you described the experience of ____ (quote each one that participant has described as a result of earlier questions). Can you tell me more about it?

(details are needed to see it in context)

2. What were the effects or impact of this experience on yourself and those around you e.g. family, friends, others or society at large etc.?

Prompt: to widen circle of impact to see participant's view of self in the context. To cover each of the experiences of life-changing events and/or key relationships mentioned by participant.

3. How did you feel when you were undergoing the experience?

Prompt: to find out participant's response and reflections then

4. When you look at that experience today, how do you think you have been changed by it?
5. How do you think you would have responded to it today?

Prompt: to find out participant's response and reflections now

C. Meaning making:

1. Having described the experience of ____ (use the words provided by the participants as far as appropriate), what does it mean to you?
2. Of the relationship with ____ (quote key relationship described by participant), can you tell me what it means to you?

Prompt: to allow participants to talk about the meaning of each key relationship including those with loved ones, with the sacred, with groups such as faith organisations, civil organisations, political affiliations etc.

3. What would you say give your life meaning now?

Possible follow-up questions:

- i. *What are your hopes of the future?*
- ii. *What are your fears of the future?*
- iii. *What is the impact of such future expectation on your day-to-day living now?*
4. What does **aging** mean to you? What do you think is the impact of the life changing experiences and key relationships on this?

Prompt: to explore aging of self and others.

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5. What does **death** mean to you? What do you think is the impact of the life changing experiences and key relationships on this?

Prompt: to explore death of self and others (general and loved ones) but will be sensitive to feelings of the participant.

D. Covid-19:

1. What is the impact of Covid-19 on you?
2. How has it changed your life or perspective about life?

Annex B

	Quotes from transcript D	Exploratory comments:		Categories and codes
		Descriptive comments	<i>Linguistic and/</i> <u>conceptual</u> comments	(categories are in bold font)
2	Interviewee D: Because I was a teenager, 14/15-year-old female student, wouldn't I fear death? What methods to use? Beatings did not change your behaviour. Ok, then I will use death to intimidate you. Do you know what she did after then? She said: My relatives have tried persuading you and you have not listened. She put the jute rope and the big chopping knife on the altar and said: you kneel before the altar. Kneel, if you kneel, I will spare your life. If you don't kneel, you choose between being hung	D asked God for help as her mother has asked her to pray at the family altar but D believed that she should only serve God. Hence, she could not pray to other gods. However, she also believed that God asked her to be "filial" and her interpretation of being "filial" meant obeying her mother. This created a problem for her and she prayed to God for help. While she prayed, her mother started slapping her.	<i>"my heart had been touched by God" "Only God is the true God" "praying" "can't serve two masters" "to be filial" "slapping my mouth repeatedly"</i> <u>D had been influenced by the local culture and had interpreted the Scripture as God saying that she has "to be filial to" her parents. This superimposition of the local "filial" concept created a problem for her when she was a teenager.</u>	Own theological belief -God cares -true God -can't serve two masters Outcome_spiritual practices -praying Outcome_impact on daily living -trusting God Influences -Impact of local culture - filial piety -Impact of other faiths -conflicts with local beliefs

	by the jute rope or killed by the big chopping knife. Look, I want to say that I really was not afraid. It was really amazing, because my heart had been touched by God, and I know that only God is the true God, While praying to God, I said: God, please help me You said that a person can only serve one Lord, I can't serve two masters, I said: God, I choose you today, I just want to serve you, But God, you also said to be filial to our parents So what should I do now?			-Significant life event - Mistreated by family
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	I don't obey my mother , I'm not filial What should I do? I asked God. I'm just spoke to myself. I was just talking to myself. Then, my mother started slapping my mouth repeatedly.			
4	Interviewee D: You know that a miracle happened? Do you know what happened? That candle (the electrical candles at the altar) went POP! Exploded! They burned out! Scared her to death! The three joss sticks that she lit and forced into my hands, they slowly, slowly, one stopped burning one by one, until all were extinguished.	After D was kicked so that she knelt at the family altar, the electrical candles on the altar burned out and the joss sticks also stopped burning.	“miracle” “thank the Lord” “God show His power” “God is greater than everything”	Spiritual experiences -Encounters with the Holy Spirit, dreams and other miracles etc. -Miracle Disposition -Feeling thankful or grateful Own theological belief -True God

	That really scared them, the onlookers also saw what had happened. In the end, do you know what my mother did? “Wah, your unlucky hands, your unlucky hands that jinxed my “Shen”. Unlucky hands!” I thank the Lord, God showed His power to show them, our God is greater than everything			
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